



## Harvesting anxiety

Assam goes to the polls amidst another political churn

The BJP is seeking a third consecutive term in Assam in Assembly polls on April 9, while the Congress is fighting to make a comeback after 10 years in the wilderness. In 2021, the coalition of BJP, AGP and UPPL won 75 of 126 seats, with the BJP alone winning 60. Communal mobilisation and welfare schemes make the standard BJP toolkit here too, but Assam is a unique theatre of political experimentation for the party and its governments at the State and the Centre. Conflicts over large-scale migration of Bengali-speaking people have long shaped Assam’s politics. Nativist politics developed primarily in opposition to this migration. The BJP’s growth has come by recasting that nativism into a question of Hindu-Muslim conflict, creating a new political dynamic weakening subnational outfits and pressuring the Congress. The Citizenship (Amendment) Act 2019 enacted a communal eligibility clause for people who entered India from Bangladesh. Nativist opposition to citizenship for any immigrant – including Hindus – and other factors stalled the large-scale rollout of the law, but rhetoric over demographic change remains the mainstay of politics. This will be the first Assembly poll after the 2023 delimitation of constituencies, which has displayed patterns of communal gerrymandering, reducing the impact of Muslim voters and enhancing representation for indigenous communities. BJP functionaries, including Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, have been open about the intended impact.

Meanwhile, the BJP continues to recruit leaders from the Congress. The AIUDF, mainly representing Bengali-speaking Muslims in lower Assam and the Barak Valley, contributed to the collapse of the Congress in 2016, now fights for survival, contesting alone after exclusion from the Congress-led Opposition alliance. The Congress has allied with the Rajior Dal, led by activist Akhil Gogoi, and the AJP, a party born from the anti-CAA movement that channels renewed Assamese sub-nationalism among younger voters. Their common ground is the promise of democratic governance, land rights, and inclusive development. The AGP, once the torch-bearer of Assamese regionalism, is a junior NDA partner contesting 26 seats, its independent ideological space largely absorbed by its larger ally. In Bodoland, the BJP has replaced its 2021 partner, the UPPL, with the BPF, an older formation. In 2021, the BJP had managed to subsume most regional sentiment through alliances and the recasting of the migration debate. Big infrastructure projects are presented as milestones, but allegations of crony capitalism and disregard for the environment are serious. Such substantive questions get sidelined as fear rather than hope dominates.

## Digital exile

The government could be creating a system of arbitrary censorship

A decade-long trend in digital governance in India crescendoed last week when a slew of social media accounts operated by independent activists and journalists were blocked apparently for criticising the Union government and Prime Minister Narendra Modi over his government’s West Asia policies and the LPG crisis. In seven years, from 2014 to 2021, the number of URLs, posts, and accounts blocked ballooned from 470 to 9,800; since then, there is evidence that entire accounts, especially if they were publishing politically unfavourable comments, were being blocked. There was a wave of censorship during the farmers’ protest in 2020-21; the government restored many accounts after international outcry but this also demonstrated that it was not beyond mass censorship. Similarly, the government used emergency powers under the IT Rules to block links to a BBC documentary in 2023, which also expanded the definition of what constituted a “threat to public order”. But when Twitter (now X) challenged several blocking orders, between 2021 and 2022, in the Karnataka High Court, the High Court dismissed the plea and fined Twitter, further emboldening the state to censor accounts.

In *Shreya Singhal* (2015), the Supreme Court of India upheld Section 69A of the IT Act 2000 precisely because of its procedural safeguards, including requiring reasoned orders and judicial review. In practice, however, the government has been diluting the safeguards through an expansive use of Rule 16 of the 2009 Blocking Rules, which requires blocking proceedings to be confidential. When this stipulation is invoked to withhold blocking orders or their reasons from affected parties, it undermines their ability to challenge the action in court, eroding the very safeguards that justified the constitutionality of Section 69A. The 2009 Rules also require blocking orders to be reviewed by a committee composed under the IT Rules 2009, yet this is an entirely executive body and has never overturned a government blocking order. In effect, the government is openly and systematically bypassing the right to be heard and violating the doctrine of proportionality. Rule 16 is a procedural rule, yet the government is using it to override the constitutional right to free speech while shielding itself from judicial review. A person’s entire account being blocked amounts to a digital exile, removing the person from the public square, which is a hallmark of an authoritarian government rather than of a liberal democracy. The government’s plan to decentralise blocking powers to multiple Ministries could effectively create a regime of arbitrary censorship, where any department can silence a critic without the specialised oversight, however flawed, of the IT Ministry.

# ‘Double engine’ — cute slogan, a serious federal question

Every election season produces memorable slogans. Most fade once the votes are counted, but some linger and begin to shape how citizens think about governance itself. One such phrase is the “double-engine *sarkar*”. At first hearing, it sounds harmless, even cute: two governments working in tandem to accelerate development. Yet, behind the metaphor lies a serious constitutional question about India’s federal compact.

The idea is simple: if the same party governs both the Union and the State, development will move faster because the two governments will work in harmony. Taken at face value, this is unexceptionable. Of course governments at different levels should coordinate. That is indeed cooperative federalism. The real question is what happens when they do not share the same political ideology. But the “double-engine” slogan carries a deeper implication. It suggests that development flows preferentially to States governed by the same party as the Union government.

### ‘Aligned States’ benefit

During election campaigns the message is often made quite explicit: elect the party ruling at the Centre so that your State can benefit from faster development. If you do not, you will be starved of funds. This is where the constitutional difficulty begins.

India’s Constitution does not envisage a system where State governments depend on the goodwill, or charity, of the ruling party at the Centre. It creates a federal structure in which the Union and the States are partners within their respective spheres. The Union government represents the Republic as a whole, not merely those States governed by the party in power in New Delhi.

Public money collected through national taxation belongs to the Union of India, not to the ruling party. Taxes are collected in the name of the Republic, from citizens of every State regardless of how they vote. The distribution of these resources cannot depend on which party governs a State. A citizen in Kerala or Tamil Nadu pays the same taxes as a citizen in Uttar Pradesh or Madhya Pradesh. The constitutional promise is that both will receive their fair share in return.

India’s constitutional framers understood this danger. That is why they built institutional safeguards into the system. The most important is the Finance Commission. Under Article 280, the Finance Commission is appointed every five years to recommend how Union revenues should be shared with the States. Its purpose is vital: fiscal transfers must be rule-based, not politically negotiated. The Commission evaluates States on objective criteria – how far their incomes lag



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Fairness, not political alignment, must guide India’s federal balance

behind the national average, their population, geographic size, and fiscal capacity – so that politics cannot determine who gets what.

### Issues raised by States, federal friction

Recent debates around fiscal federalism show how sensitive this issue remains. Southern States have expressed concern that the use of more recent population data in allocation formulas may penalise them for having successfully controlled population growth. Another issue is the increasing resort of the Union government to cesses and surcharges, which fall outside the divisible pool and are not shared with States. This effectively reduces the quantum of resources available for constitutionally mandated sharing, concentrating more fiscal power in Union hands and weakening the financial autonomy of States. The Sixteenth Finance Commission, which is currently deliberating, will have to grapple seriously with these concerns if it is to restore confidence in the fairness of the fiscal federal arrangement

Governments in Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have argued that States which acted early to stabilise population should not be penalised in the distribution of national resources. Senior Ministers from these States have at times remarked, in visible frustration, that they feel reduced to “beggars”, pleading for funds that constitutionally belong to them. This is not the language of political theatre. It reflects a genuine structural grievance about the terms on which States participate in the Indian Union.

Federal friction is visible not only in financial matters but also in the legislative process. In recent years, Governors in some States have sat for long periods over Bills passed by elected legislatures, effectively using the constitutional office as an instrument of political sabotage. Tamil Nadu and Kerala have witnessed particularly prolonged delays. The pattern is difficult to ignore: the delays have been in States that are governed by parties opposed to the ruling dispensation at the Centre. A Governor who withholds assent to legislation passed by an elected Assembly is, in effect, a second engine running in reverse.

Such delays have drawn judicial attention. In *State of Punjab vs Principal Secretary to the Governor of Punjab* (2023), the Supreme Court of India made it clear that a Governor cannot use inaction to stall the legislative process. The Court emphasised that the Governor’s office is not meant to function as a parallel political authority over an elected legislature.

More recently, in *State of Tamil Nadu vs Governor of Tamil Nadu* (2025), the Court observed that prolonged inaction by a Governor

# Trump’s Section 301 weapon, lessons from the past

Within hours of the February 20 ruling of the United States Supreme Court that U.S. President Donald Trump lacked authority to impose his infamous reciprocal tariffs, the U.S. administration invoked Section 122 of the Trade Act of 1974 to impose a 10% temporary surcharge on imports, effective February 24 to July 24, 2026. Section 122 requires the existence of a “balance of payment” (BOP) crisis. This has already been challenged by 24 U.S. States in the United States Court of International Trade, on the ground that, like the preceding tariffs, these too have no legal basis, nor is there any BOP crisis facing the U.S.

Under World Trade Organization (WTO) rules of international trade, import restrictions, not tariffs, are permissible in limited situations involving serious BOP difficulties, which could arise due to actual or any imminent threat of serious decline in a country’s monetary reserves. None of these situations exists for the U.S.

In any event, since the Section 122 tariffs have a limited 150-day shelf life, Mr. Trump promised “other tools” and initiated two sets of “Section 301” proceedings – one alleging “Structural Excess Capacity and Production in Manufacturing Sectors”, and another alleging “Failure to Impose and Effectively Enforce a Prohibition on the Importation of Goods Produced with Forced Labor”. India is listed in both proceedings, along with the European Union (EU), Japan, Singapore, South Korea, China and many others. The factual and economic rationale for both, at best, is specious.

### Furthering unilateral action

Section 301 sits under “Title III” of the U.S. Trade Act in the chapter “Enforcement of United States Rights under Trade Agreements and Response to Unfair Trade Practices”. Section 301 authorises the Office of the United States Trade Representative to investigate foreign trade practices and impose unilateral tariffs based on a determination that such practices are



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The Section 301 proceedings demand action from India and other developing nations to revive multilateral rules

unjustifiable, discriminatory, or restrict U.S. commerce, or violate trade agreements.

A clear anomaly in Section 301 is that it provides the U.S. the right to unilateral determination of what is governed by rules of international trade. To state the obvious, one cannot be the judge of one’s cause. To address this, soon after the WTO came into being in 1995, the EU initiated a dispute against the U.S. arguing that because Section 301 provides unilateral rights to the U.S. without any assessment of its international obligations, such a provision violated WTO law.

The WTO disputes panel agreed that even the threat of conduct prohibited by the WTO would enable one country to exert undue leverage on others. It compared Section 301 to a “big stick”, that, merely by being carried could be “as effective a means to having one’s way as actually using the stick”.

The panel, however, refrained from holding Section 301 as illegal based on an assurance from the U.S. administration that it would render determinations “in conformity” with its WTO obligations. This deference to the U.S. was predicated on the U.S.’s standing by that assurance. That deference has today come to haunt WTO members.

### Now, key decimator

A 2020 report of the U.S. Congressional Research Service (CRS) notes that until the start of the Trump administration (in 2016), the U.S. stood by its word and used Section 301 primarily to build cases and pursue dispute settlement at the WTO. The report acknowledges that the Trump administration changed that and started using Section 301 as a weapon to impose tariffs as punitive measures. Pursuant to Section 301 proceedings against China in 2017, unilateral tariffs up to 25% were imposed. A WTO panel held in 2020 that these tariffs violated the U.S.’s commitments under the WTO. The U.S. did not blink and appealed the panel ruling to the WTO’s

in assenting to Bills is constitutionally impermissible. These rulings together signal a firm judicial commitment to protecting the legislative sovereignty of elected State assemblies.

The experience of Delhi over the past decade provides a further illustration. Many initiatives of the elected government became entangled in disputes with the Lieutenant-Governor and the Union government. Courts eventually had to intervene. The lesson is not merely about one city; it is about what happens when the machinery of federal governance is used to punish a political opponent rather than serve the public.

Seen together – fiscal transfers, gubernatorial delays, and the Delhi impasse – these developments form a coherent pattern. The “double-engine” slogan is not merely a campaign metaphor. It is a description of how governance actually functions when political alignment is absent. And that is precisely the constitutional problem. The form of federalism survives; its spirit is quietly hollowed out.

India’s federal system has faced similar tensions before. In earlier decades, Article 356 was frequently misused to dismiss elected State governments. The Court’s landmark judgment in *S.R. Bommai vs Union of India* placed important limits on that practice. The challenge today is subtler: governments may remain in office, yet, governance itself may become hostage to political alignment.

### Structural reform needed

What is needed is not merely judicial intervention, but structural reform. The Finance Commission’s recommendations could be made more binding. A fixed statutory timeline, say, three months, could be prescribed for Governors to act on Bills, failing which assent would be deemed granted. Inter-State/governmental councils, already provided for under Article 263, could be revitalised as genuine forums for cooperative federalism rather than ceremonial gatherings. These are not radical proposals; they are logical completions of the constitutional architecture that the framers intended.

Political slogans will continue to animate election campaigns. But a slogan that implicitly threatens citizens with slower development if they choose the “wrong” party at the State level does not merely distort electoral choice; it corrodes the constitutional promise of equal citizenship. Development cannot depend on political alignment. It must rest on rules and institutions that treat every State, and every citizen, with equal fairness. That constitutional balance, not the number of engines pulling the same train, is the only engine India’s federal democracy truly needs.

appellate process. The only catch was that there was no WTO Appellate Body by 2020, since the U.S. had, single-handedly, blocked its constitution.

The U.S., as the chief architect of the WTO, including its enforceable dispute settlement mechanism, has been its chief decimator. Had the panel in 1999 ruled that Section 301 required amendment to ensure WTO consistency, the U.S. – then a trustworthy member of the multilateral system that it had helped create – would very likely have amended the section to eliminate any possibility of unilateral tariff imposition. And Mr. Trump’s toolkit would have fallen short of one potent weapon.

### The issue of trade agreements

Events over the past year have especially demonstrated the fragility of multilaterally agreed rules, and the significant systemic leverage the U.S. has been able to exercise by unabashed violation of those rules. And yet, we are also seeing some limits to that leverage. Malaysia has officially called its reciprocal trade agreement with the U.S. “null and void” after the U.S. Supreme Court’s decision. Unlike Malaysia, India had not yet signed an agreement with the U.S., and the government has indicated that it hopes for a “mutually beneficial trade agreement”. The pressures of the Section 301 proceedings will, no doubt, play a role in the conclusion of any negotiation.

Indian businesses need to actively participate in both Section 301 proceedings and make clear submissions exposing the absurdity of these so-called investigations. At the broader level, the core challenge for India and other developing countries is the need to revive multilateral rules. There is no substitute for the strength that comes from coalition-building to dilute the U.S.’s raw power advantage. India must step up and play that role.

The views expressed are personal

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Trump and war

The prosecution of the conflict with Iran under U.S. President Donald Trump reveals a disconcerting absence of strategic coherence and foresight. The presumption that targeted elimination of leadership would catalyse regime transformation has proven fundamentally flawed, as Iran has exhibited considerable

resilience against the United States-Israel offensive. Compounding this miscalculation is the administration’s oscillatory rhetoric — simultaneously proclaiming operational success while augmenting military deployments — thereby betraying policy inconsistency. Mr. Trump’s disparagement of NATO allies for their reluctance to engage

underscores growing diplomatic estrangement. Concurrently, internal dissent, exemplified by the resignation of Joe Kent, accentuates institutional unease. **N. Sadhasiva Reddy,** Bengaluru

U.S. President Donald Trump appears to recognise no limits. Earlier it was Venezuela; now it is Iran,

and he has openly suggested that Cuba could be next — without clear justification. These actions risk plunging entire nations into crisis and instability. Mr. Trump seems to view global resources, particularly oil, as instruments of power. The international community must respond firmly to check such unilateralism. Otherwise, there may be no

end to these escalating, authoritarian impulses. **N.G.R. Prasad,** Chennai

Military action without a clearly articulated endgame risks prolonged instability, rising human and economic costs, and unintended geopolitical consequences. The concerns raised within the United States Congress reflect not just partisan

debate but the need for strategic clarity, defined objectives, and an exit plan. As tensions with Iran escalate, restraint, transparency, and diplomacy must prevail over open-ended military engagement. **Gopalaswamy J.,** Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

# India must use the AYUSH opportunity

The 2026-27 Union Budget and India's new Free Trade Agreement (FTA) with the European Union (EU) signals Ayurveda's ambitious leap into the global mainstream. The Ayurveda, Yoga and Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, and Homoeopathy (AYUSH) Ministry's budget has nearly doubled in the past five years, reaching ₹4,408 crore this year. Further, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman has announced three new All-India Institutes of Ayurveda, aiming to set top standards for traditional medicine, similar to how AIIMS leads modern medicine in India. These institutes will not just treat patients, they will teach and conduct advanced research as well. The Budget also turbo-charges the National AYUSH Mission, raising its funding by 66% to modernise dispensaries, establish AYUSH clinics inside government hospitals, and upgrade drug-testing laboratories. Together, these measures reflect an effort to bring traditional medicine into the mainstream health ecosystem rather than treat it as an alternative silo.

**Global reach**  
If the Budget gives Ayurveda depth within India, the India-EU FTA gives it global reach. In EU countries that don't specifically regulate traditional medicine, the trade deal allows Indian AYUSH practitioners to provide their services using qualifications obtained in India. It guarantees that Indian companies can open Ayurvedic clinics across Europe without the fear of sudden policy reversal. It also sets up a system where Indian safety certifications could eventually be accepted in Europe, which means that products approved in India might not need extra testing. However, this policy is also a moment which will test whether the country can merge faith in heritage with the discipline of evidence. For this is not just an economic expansion; it is a



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For Ayurveda and other AYUSH systems to enter the global mainstream credibly, they must submit to rigorous, independent, and transparent scientific evaluation

structural repositioning of Ayurveda within India's health system and the global market. When the alternative moves from local clinics to international markets, it enters regulatory and scientific arenas that demand proof. These treatments, understood as Traditional, Complementary, and Alternative Medicine (TCAM), will be evaluated within stringent regulatory and vigilance frameworks. This is precisely the moment when regulatory harmonisation becomes essential. If AYUSH products are to circulate in EU markets, they must meet international standards of safety, manufacturing quality, and claims regulation. Global ambition demands scientific accountability.

**Need for scientific evidence**  
If claims outpace evidence, India risks legal disputes, reputational damage, and the reinforcement of stereotypes about 'unscientific traditionalism.' For Ayurveda and other AYUSH systems to enter the global mainstream credibly, they must submit to rigorous, independent, and transparent scientific evaluation conducted by third-party research organisations. At present, many assessments are funded, designed, or overseen by the same Ministry that promotes AYUSH, creating a structural conflict of interest. Global credibility requires independently funded clinical trials, transparent methodologies, peer-reviewed publications, and the willingness to publish negative findings. A common defensive move in debates around traditional medicine or cultural knowledge is to frame scientific scrutiny as colonial bias or Western epistemic dominance. Certainly, the history of colonial medicine in India involved the marginalisation and delegitimisation of local systems of healing. While that history should not be forgotten, it does not follow that all demands for empirical evaluation are acts of epistemic domination. Demanding evidence is not cultural betrayal, and

scientific evaluation does not diminish tradition.

**Coexisting systems**  
Furthermore, TCAM systems endure not simply because of cultural loyalty, but because they carry different imaginations of the body, health, and illness. To engage with TCAM seriously is to recognise that they are not merely collections of remedies but coherent epistemologies. Systems such as Ayurveda are organised around ontological commitments about what the body is, how it is constituted, and how disorder emerges. The body in Ayurveda, for instance, is not a collection of discrete organs but an interdependent system embedded in environment, diet, season, and social life. Health is a state of equilibrium across physiological, psychological, and ecological registers, and illness is a disturbance in patterned relations rather than a discrete lesion. This stands in contrast to modern medicine, which has historically been grounded in anatomical localisation. Biomedicine excels at identifying specific causal mechanisms and intervening with precision at targeted sites. TCAM systems, by contrast, often operate through systemic logics. But the question is not biomedicine versus TCAM. The conceptual frames in TCAM do not need to replace biomedicine to be valuable. They can function as counterpoints that expand questions about what it means to be healthy. They offer alternative models of embodiment – models in which the body is ecological and dynamic. Thus, the goal is not substitution but dialogue. In that dialogue lies the possibility of strengthening scientific inquiry across the spectrum of care. Therefore, public investment should fund intellectual openness and scientific freedom. Global ambition will be sustained not by assertion, but by evidence, transparency and the courage to be rigorously examined.

# Building his own band of loyalists

The Telangana CM intends to shape the party's future with young faces

## STATE OF PLAY

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The Chief Minister of Telangana Revanth Reddy appears to be steadily consolidating his position within both the Telangana government and the State unit of the Congress, sending clear signals that he intends to shape the party's future leadership with young faces and create his own band of loyalists. This has been apparent in his appointment of party Whips to the Assembly and the Legislative Council. The three newly appointed Assembly Whips, Vemula Veeresham, Vijaya Ramana Rao and Yennam Srinivas Reddy, are relatively recent entrants to the Congress, from the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), Telugu Desam Party (TDP), and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) respectively. Similarly, Addanki Dayakar and Venkat Balmoor, both first-time legislators and known loyalists of the Chief Minister, were appointed as Whips to the Legislative Council. All are young as well. Patnam Mahender Reddy, who defected from the BRS and shares long-standing ties with Mr. Reddy, will continue as the Government Chief Whip in the Council.

**Active consolidation**  
Sources indicate that the recent decisions were influenced by Mr. Reddy despite the constitution of a coordination committee to bridge the gap between the government and the party. Alongside Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka and Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) president Mahesh Kumar Goud, the

committee includes senior ministers N. Uttam Kumar Reddy and Damodar Raja Narasimha. The inclusion of Minister Seethakka, regarded as a close confidante of Mr. Reddy, had drawn attention, particularly as several long-serving veterans were left out. Moreover, the recent developments involving senior leader T. Jeevan Reddy have added another dimension to Mr. Reddy's purported consolidation. Considered one of the most senior Congress figures in Telangana, Jeevan Reddy expressed dissatisfaction over the induction of a BRS MLA from his constituency without his consultation. Despite voicing his displeasure, he received little to no reassurance on the matter. Within party circles, the episode is viewed as a signal that any resistance to the Chief Minister's political strategy will not sit well with him. These measures also lay out the roadmap for the Chief Minister's long-term plan and repeated assertion – that his government will remain in power for 10 years. Senior Congress leaders interpret this not merely as political optimism but as a declaration of intent. His recent sharp exchanges with the Opposition in the Assembly reinforced this perception. While responding to taunts from BRS legislators, he declared that he would “crush” his opponents in the next elections, as he did

in December 2023. Though triggered by Opposition remarks, many within the Congress believe the message underscored his undisputed authority within the party. At present, there is no visible challenger to Mr. Reddy in the State unit. And his recent organisational decisions suggest that he is determined to ensure there are no parallel centres of power.

**Congress loyalist**  
Despite consolidating power within the State, Mr. Reddy has consistently underlined his loyalty to the Congress high command. He frequently credits Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra for reposing confidence in him at a critical juncture, attributing the formation of the Congress government in Telangana to their trust. He earned the confidence of the Gandhi family by bringing back Congress rule after 10 years of BRS rule. His elevation as TPCC president about a year or so before the 2023 Assembly elections marked a decisive shift in the party's fortunes. At the time, Congress's morale was at an all-time low, with a steady stream of defections to the BRS. Mr. Reddy's appointment injected fresh enthusiasm into the cadre. He projected confidence that the Congress could wrest power from the invincible K. Chandrashekar Rao. In a national climate where Congress was facing repeated electoral setbacks, the Telangana unit under his leadership defeated the BRS. The victory was viewed as one of the Congress's most significant State-level comebacks. Now, by building a cohort of younger leaders and trusted loyalists, he appears intent on shaping both governance and the party's future on his strengths.

# India's dual dependence on West Asia for urea production

Data indicate that the West Asian conflict threatens both domestic urea production and the stability of its global supply chain

## DATA POINT

**Nitika Francis**

The ongoing conflict in West Asia has disrupted global trade, leading to LPG shortages and a surge in crude oil prices. Data show that the crisis could also affect India's supply of Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG), putting at risk the production of urea, a key fertilizer in the country's majorly agrarian economy. The conflict has already started to impact India's urea supply. As of Sunday, industry sources told *PTI* that the country's urea plants are running at half capacity, with Petronet LNG Ltd, which operates India's largest liquefied natural gas receiving terminal, declaring force majeure amid disruptions to cargoes. The move triggered supply curtailments by state-owned gas distributors GAIL (India) Ltd, Indian Oil Corporation Ltd and Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd. India is heavily dependent on imports for its LNG supply, exposing many of its sectors to global shocks such as the U.S.-Israel attacks on Iran. Data show that in 2025, India bought more than 50% of its natural gas from the international market (**Chart 1**). In fact, India is the fourth largest buyer of natural gas in the world, with an imported supply of 261 lakh metric tonnes in 2025. A majority of these imports – more than 40% of it – are tied to long-term contracts with suppliers in Qatar (**Chart 2**). This supply may be in jeopardy as Qatar's LNG cargoes pass through the Strait of Hormuz, which has now become a central chokepoint in the Iran-Israel conflict. The UAE and Oman also ship LNG along this route, and both countries contribute to India's imported LNG supply. Overall, more than 60% of India's imported LNG could be affected by the closure of the Strait. In India, natural gas is primarily used to produce ammonia, which

in turn is used to produce fertilizers. In FY26, about 30% of India's LNG supply was used for the production of fertilizers (**Chart 3**). Demand also comes from industry and gas-fired power and city gas networks which supply to households and vehicles. LNG is the main feedstock for the production of urea, which is the most widely used fertilizer in India. Many urea plants use naphtha or fuel oil – both derived from crude oil – as their main input. However, as urea production is a highly energy-intensive process, these plants have switched to natural gas, which produces fewer emissions. National urea consumption hit 387 lakh metric tonnes in 2025, following a decade of steady growth. While domestic production has also been increasing (India produced about 306 lakh metric tonnes of urea in 2025), it does not cover the country's demand. Due to this, India also relies on imports of urea. Data indicate that the West Asian conflict threatens both domestic urea production and the stability of its supply chain. In 2025, India's urea imports exceeded 2,300 lakh metric tonnes, with a staggering 71% of these imports coming from West Asia (**Chart 4**). This total comprises 45% from Oman and a combined 26% from Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and the UAE, all of which rely on the Strait of Hormuz for transit. Amidst this scenario, the Government of India issued the Natural Gas (Supply Regulation) Order, 2026, officially including the fertilizer sector in its priority list. The government also stated that as of March 10, India's urea reserves have reached 61.51 lakh metric tonnes, about 10 lakh more than last year, ahead of the Kharif sowing season. However, only time can tell if India's import dependence for both domestic production and global supply trade will weather the ongoing geopolitical instability.

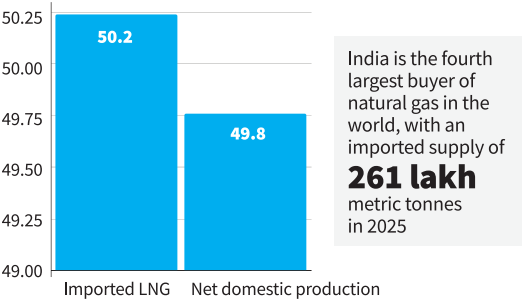


**Distressed supply:**  
A farmer sprinkles fertilizer on a paddy field in the Nagaon district, Assam

## Crop hazard

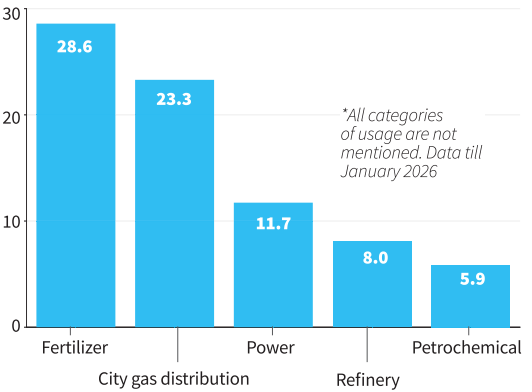
The data for the charts were sourced from the Ministry of Trade and Commerce, the Department of Fertilizers, and the International Gas Union

**Chart 1:** The composition of India's LNG supply in 2025-26 (in %)



India is the fourth largest buyer of natural gas in the world, with an imported supply of **261 lakh metric tonnes** in 2025

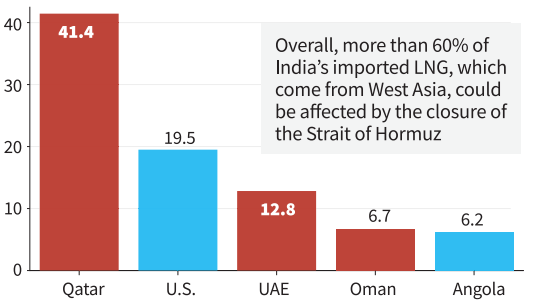
**Chart 3:** The distribution of LNG use in India in 2025-26 (in %)



**1** Industry sources said that the country's urea plants are running at half capacity

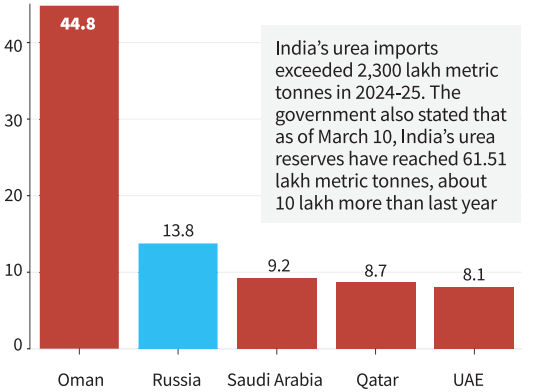
**2** Natural gas is used to produce ammonia, which in turn is used to produce fertilizers

**Chart 2:** Country-wise share (%) of India's LNG imports in 2024-25



Overall, more than 60% of India's imported LNG, which come from West Asia, could be affected by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz

**Chart 4:** Country-wise share (%) of India's urea imports in 2024-25



India's urea imports exceeded 2,300 lakh metric tonnes in 2024-25. The government also stated that as of March 10, India's urea reserves have reached 61.51 lakh metric tonnes, about 10 lakh more than last year

**3** LNG is the main feedstock for the production of urea, which is the most widely used fertilizer in India

**4** Chart 3 and 4 only include the top 5 exporting countries

## FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

**FIFTY YEARS AGO** MARCH 23, 1976

## Heavy fighting in Beirut's streets

Beirut, March 22: Lebanon's war-scarred capital exploded in its worst-ever violence to-day as rival forces battled with shells, mortars, and gunfire over demands for the resignation of President Franjieh. The hardpressed Head of State called an emergency cabinet meeting. It was the fiercest outburst of fighting in Beirut in 11 months of murderous civil conflict in which more than 10,000 people have died. The clashes between the President's supporters and those who want him to go raged all night, with heavy weapons taken over from the fragmented Lebanese Army. Rival left-wing Nasserite and right-wing Phalangist radio stations disputed which side was in possession of the battered Holiday Inn hotel, a strategic and psychological strongpoint near the seafont. The Nasserites said they had carried the battle several hundred metres further east to Phalangist territory. But the right-wing radio said its gunmen had recaptured the Holiday Inn. The situation was so dangerous that a military command council set up last night by the General who staged an anti-Franjieh revolt on March 11 was unable to meet. General Aziz al-Ahdab, who is still Beirut garrison commander, but had so far failed to unseat the President, set up the command last night to “co-ordinate expected military operations should a political situation fail”. The pro-Ahdab radio said to-day the first aim of the council was to restore cohesion to the army, bringing together left-wing deserters and the official Army Command.

**A HUNDRED YEARS AGO** MARCH 23, 1926

## Fall in the rupee

The recent sudden fall in rupee exchange has been due to heavy bullion enquiry in Bombay. This demand was accompanied by considerable speculation and the natural outcome was a fall. When advice of this was received in the Calcutta market, undue nervousness was displayed, with the result that in this centre Thursday's closing rate stood at 5 31/32d or one point lower than in Bombay. Since then the market has steadied, indicating the purely temporary character of the fall. All the factors point to the improbability of any further sudden drop. – “The Pioneer”.

# Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of trips under free bus travel scheme since inception

**898** crore. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. K. Stalin on Sunday hailed the success of the ‘Vidiyal Payanam’ free bus travel scheme for women, stating that the initiative has recorded nearly 898 crore trips since its inception. PTI

Number of dog-bite cases in Rajasthan in 2025

**900** An RTI application revealed that the State reported more than 460 dog-bite cases in 2024, which rose to over 900 in 2025. Jaipur recorded the highest numbers both years, with cases surging from 307 in 2024 to 633 in 2025. PTI

Percentage increase in Sri Lanka’s fuel prices due to conflict

**25** in per cent. Sri Lanka raised fuel prices by 25% on Sunday, as the country prepared for more impact from the war in West Asia. Regular petrol was increased to 398 rupees (\$1.30) per litre, up from 317 rupees, while diesel rose by 79 rupees to 382. AFP

Education systems with a national ban on phones in schools

**114** More than half of the countries have banned phones in schools amid mounting concerns about declining attention in classrooms and cyberbullying, according to the UNESCO’s Global Education Monitoring team. PTI

People killed in a strike on a hospital in Sudan

**64** At least 64 people were killed, including at least 13 children, in a strike on a hospital in Sudan’s western Darfur region last week, the World Health Organization said on Saturday. AP  
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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## What insurance numbers do not reveal

Insurance penetration and density are widely used indicators, but they show premium collection, not how well households are protected against loss of income; as a result, premium growth is often mistaken for progress, even when financial protection remains limited

ECONOMIC NOTES

T.C. Suseel Kumar  
R. Sudhakar

India is often described as an “underinsured” country. This claim is usually backed by two numbers that appear regularly in official speeches, policy papers, and media commentary: life insurance penetration and density. Low values of these indicators are taken as proof that insurance coverage in India is inadequate and that large sections of the population remain unprotected.

The problem is not that these numbers are wrong. The problem is that they are misunderstood – and then used to draw the wrong conclusions during public discourses.

In everyday economic language, penetration refers to how widely a product is used. Mobile phone penetration, for example, tells us what proportion of people or households have access to a phone. Density usually means how much of something exists per person.

In life insurance, however, these terms mean something quite different. Insurance penetration is defined as the total premium collected by insurers as a percentage of gross domestic product (GDP). Insurance density is the average premium paid per person, usually expressed in U.S. dollars. These definitions are internationally accepted and are useful for comparing the size of insurance markets across countries.

But these measures do not tell us what most people assume they do. They do not reveal how many families are insured, whether those families would be financially secure if the main earning member were to die, or whether insurance is serving its most important social purpose – protecting households against sudden loss of income.

What the numbers show

Premium-to-GDP, for instance, is essentially a measure of industry revenue relative to the size of the economy. It can move up or down for many reasons that have little to do with household protection. If the economy grows rapidly



GETTY IMAGES

due to infrastructure spending or increased exports, insurance penetration can fall even if more people are buying insurance.

On the other hand, insurers can push high-premium products and raise penetration figures without meaningfully improving protection.

Regulatory changes can further distort the picture. When product rules or commission structures are modified, premium growth often slows temporarily as insurers recalibrate. Penetration may then appear to decline. This does not mean fewer families are insured – it simply reflects a shift in how insurance is sold and priced. Treating such movements as evidence of poor coverage leads to confused diagnosis and poor decision-making.

Insurance density has similar limitations. It is often used to compare India with richer countries, leading to the conclusion that Indians are underinsured because they spend less on insurance. But such comparisons ignore income levels and cost of living. A family paying a modest premium in India may be making a far greater financial commitment, relative to income, than a family paying a higher premium in a developed economy.

Premium vs protection

More importantly, both penetration and

density confuse how much is paid with how much protection is received. In India, insurance products have long been sold as savings instruments rather than as pure protection. As a result, premiums can be high even when the life cover provided is modest. Premiums rise, but the financial security of dependents does not improve proportionately.

This gap between premiums and protection becomes clearer when claims data are examined. According to the IRDAI Annual Report 2024-25, life insurers settled a little over 10 lakh individual death claims during the year, paying a total of about ₹33,000 crore. This translates to an average payout of roughly ₹3.3 lakh per claim, showing a 97% claim settlement ratio.

While this reflects efficient claim settlement, it also indicates the level of financial support that life insurance typically delivers to bereaved families. For most households, such an amount would replace income for only a short period, if at all. Yet these claim payouts fully count towards insurance penetration and density. The numbers look reassuring, even though the underlying protection is often thin. This is why headline indicators can suggest progress while households remain financially vulnerable.

This confusion matters because it shapes how the problem is framed.

Rethinking adequacy

When India is labelled “underinsured” on the basis of these metrics, the implied conclusion is that people lack awareness or access. In reality, many households – especially in the formal and semi-formal sectors – already own at least one life insurance policy, either individually or through employers. The real issue is not reach, but adequacy. Families may have insurance, but not enough to replace lost income if something goes wrong.

This is not an argument for abandoning penetration and density altogether. These indicators are useful for tracking the growth of the insurance industry and for making broad international comparisons. But they are poorly suited to guiding public policy aimed at household protection. When revenue-based measures are treated as indicators of social security, they obscure more than they reveal.

A more meaningful approach would begin with simpler, more direct questions: how many households actually have some form of life insurance cover – whether individual, employer-provided, or through government schemes? And for those that do, how much life cover do they have relative to their income? These questions focus on protection, not premium collection.

Such measures are often dismissed as difficult to compute. In reality, much of the required data already exists – in regulatory filings, census household counts, and records of group insurance schemes. The goal need not be perfect precision. For public policy, understanding broad gaps in protection is far more important than tracking exact premium flows.

As long as India continues to rely on penetration and density as shorthand for insurance adequacy, the debate will remain confused. Premium growth risks being mistaken for progress, and industry expansion will be equated with social security.

Clear thinking begins with clear measurement. In life insurance, that means shifting the focus from how much money is collected to how well families are protected.  
(T.C. Suseel Kumar is a former Managing Director of LIC and R. Sudhakar is a former Executive Director of LIC)

THE GIST

Insurance penetration and density are often misunderstood and do not reveal how many families are insured or whether they would be financially secure if the main earning member were to die.

The real issue is not reach but adequacy, as households may have life insurance but not enough cover to replace lost income, leaving them financially vulnerable.

## Is compulsory voting feasible in the Indian context?

How can voter turnout be increased without making voting mandatory?

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

The Election Commission has announced the poll schedule for five Assembly elections to be held in April-May 2026. In a separate hearing before the Supreme Court on a poll-related matter, the court raised questions regarding mandatory voting in elections.

What is the right to vote in India?

Article 326 of the Constitution grants every citizen the right to vote without any discrimination. It provides that any citizen who is not less than 18 years old and is not otherwise disqualified under the Constitution or any law on certain grounds is entitled to be registered as a voter.

Section 19 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, requires a citizen to be at least 18 years old and ordinarily resident in a constituency to be registered as an elector. Section 62 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, provides the right to vote to every person whose name is entered in the electoral roll of a constituency. In various cases, the Supreme Court has held that the right to vote is a statutory right.

Should voting be made compulsory?

Voting is essential for a functional democracy, but it is neither a fundamental duty nor a legal duty in India. Proposals for compulsory voting have long been debated.

The Dinesh Goswami Committee on electoral reforms, set up in 1990, did not favour compulsory voting, citing practical

difficulties in implementation. Instead, it recommended improving voter participation through awareness campaigns.

The Law Commission, in its 255th report (2015), discussed the issue in detail. Compulsory voting does result in increased voter turnout by an average of about 7%. Nevertheless, this increase in participation is a direct corollary of the severity and strict enforcement of penalties for not voting.

Some democracies, such as Australia and several Latin American countries, have provisions for compulsory voting. In Australia, Argentina, and Brazil, voters may be fined if they fail to vote without valid reasons. In Peru, certain public goods and services are denied to non-voters.

Penalising non-voters by imposing fines

or restricting their access to government services is an extremely harsh measure that will not work in the Indian context. From a constitutional perspective, compulsory voting could be seen as violating the fundamental right to freedom of expression under Article 19(1).

What can be the way forward?

Low voter turnout can result in candidates winning by securing a minority of the total votes in a constituency.

However, as discussed in the Law Commission report, compulsory voting is neither desirable nor feasible in India. The solution lies in fostering enthusiasm amongst voters to exercise their right to vote through innovative campaigns, especially using social media.

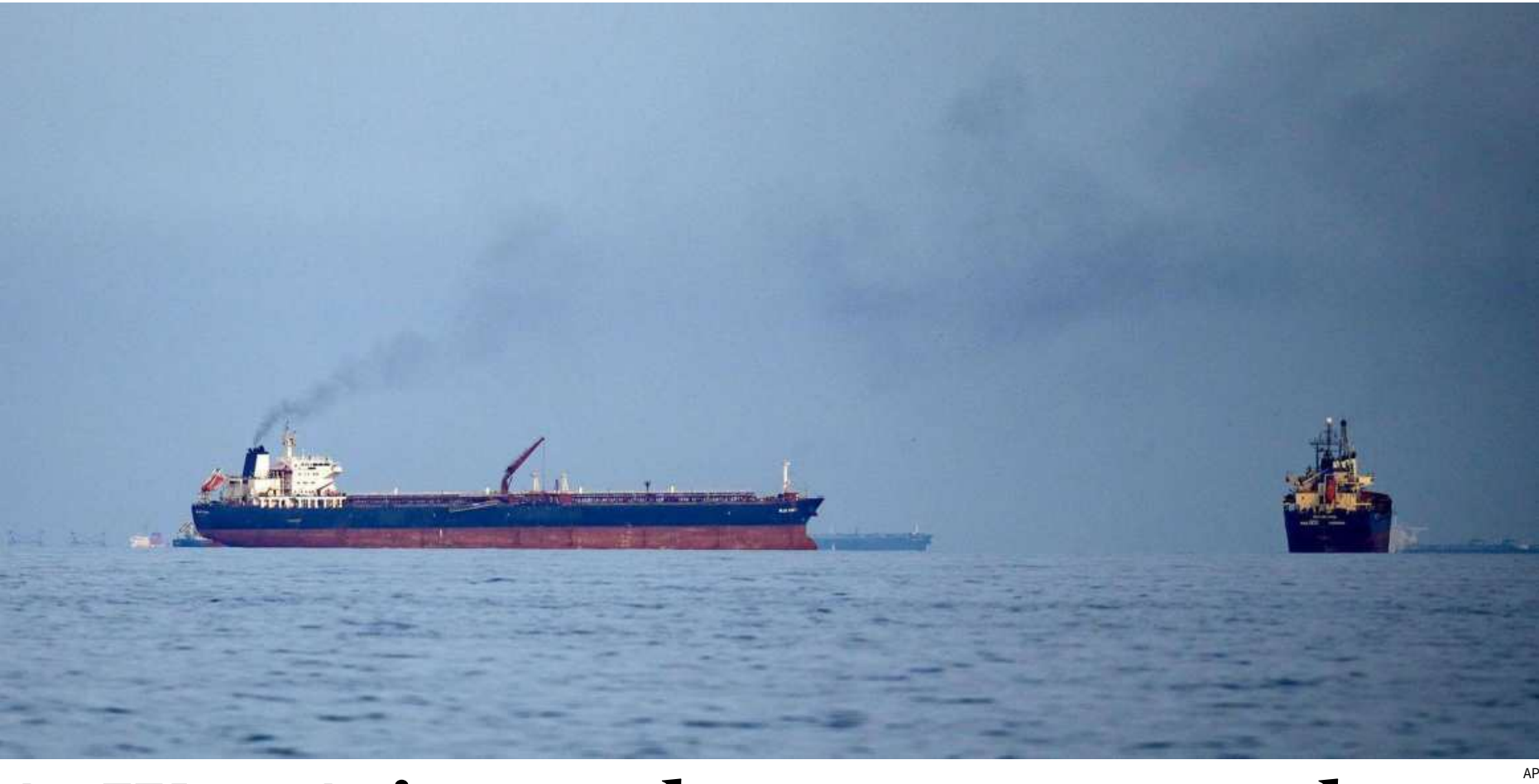
For migrant workers, stricter implementation of the statutory holiday on the day of polling, coupled with an increase in transport facilities by running special buses and trains, can effectively increase participation. With the advent of newer technologies, robust and secure methods acceptable to all stakeholders for remote voting should be considered.  
(Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of ‘Courseware on Polity Simplified.’ He currently trains at Officers IAS academy. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

The right to vote in India is a statutory right under Article 326 and the Representation of the People Act, and compulsory voting is neither a fundamental duty nor a legal duty.

While higher voter turnout shows a more representative democracy, compulsory voting is neither desirable nor feasible, and the focus should be on awareness, enthusiasm, and better access for voters.

CACHE



AP

# As West Asia war threatens gas supply, remembering a gas grid India never built

India’s push for the National Coal Gasification Mission to secure energy independence recalls a visionary 1955 proposal by Syed Husain Zaheer; initially dismissed by policymakers, Zaheer’s plan for a national gas grid was vindicated by the 1973 global oil shock

Dinesh C Sharma

The ongoing war in West Asia has plunged the world into a deep energy crisis. In India, the availability of domestic fuel, LPG, has been hit due to the disruption in supplies from the Persian Gulf. The global energy crisis is reminiscent of the Oil Shock of 1973, when members of the Organisation of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) cut oil production and slashed exports to protest the U.S.’s support for Israel in the Yom Kippur War. India responded by exploring alternative sources of energy, offshore oilfields in Bombay High, and experimenting with new technologies.

One technological option that found a second life this way was coal gasification. The idea of using gasified coal to meet some of India’s fuel needs first emerged in 1955 when Syed Husain Zaheer, director of the Regional Research Laboratory Hyderabad (RRLH) – now the CSIR-Indian Institute of Chemical Technology (IICT) – and later director-general of CSIR, submitted a plan to Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru for a cross-country national gas grid. The plan envisaged the use of fuel gas produced from gasifying of coal and its supply through pipelines for domestic and industrial use. Zaheer believed fuel gas of high calorific value could be produced by completely gasifying non-caking fuels such as shale coal, lignite, and bituminous coal, all found in India.

**‘Town Gas Supply Scheme’**  
The technology involved gasifying coal using high pressure to form hydrocarbons and using oxygen to maintain a high thermal efficiency. It started with converting the sulphur present in the coal to hydrogen sulphide (H<sub>2</sub>S) and small amounts of carbonyl sulphide (COS). Sulphur compounds are then removed from the gas stream and the separated acid gas is further processed to recover elemental sulphur.

The gas was further cleaned using water scrubbing to remove any remaining

particulate matter. In the 1940s, coal gasification was used at a commercial scale to provide town gas for street lighting in Europe and the U.S. But the concept’s techno-economic feasibility had yet to be established for Indian coal. Initially, Zaheer proposed a “Town Gas Supply Scheme” for Hyderabad based on gasifying coal found in the Singareni collieries and piping it to the city. If a gasification plant were established at Kothagudem, gas could be supplied not only to Hyderabad but also to towns along the 290-km-long route, per the plan. Based on surveys of fuel consumption, population and demand projections, family income, and fuel demand trends, Zaheer proposed a pressure gasification plant of 7.5 million cubic feet capacity, and suggested the gas pipeline could be laid along the railway track to facilitate easy maintenance and inspections.

**Tough going**  
To demonstrate the technology’s feasibility, pilot studies were needed, which in turn required funding. Zaheer’s idea did not find any takers in the Central government or the CSIR. On the energy front, the policy focus at the time was on finding petroleum reserves and the development of nuclear energy, besides harnessing hydroelectric power from large dams. So in 1961, Zaheer urged Nehru to make a policy decision to establish several plants for manufacturing town gas based on coal gasification in select coal belts and linking them through a countrywide grid. Nehru liked the plan and observed that it was “a modern and more economical method, and it will bring enormous relief to the railways”. But the Ministry of Steel, Mines and Fuel pointed to the “infeasibility of the plan for transporting gas over long distances”. The Planning Commission, the Coal Council, and the CSIR, as well, remained cold to the proposal and were reluctant to fund a pilot plant to test coal gasification. When Nehru appointed Zaheer the CSIR director-general in 1962, Zaheer got a chance to implement his idea to develop

a pilot plant at RRLH. But the going was not easy as the plan required importing equipment. The wars of 1962 and 1965 did not help, delaying the procurement of machinery from Germany, and there was a massive cost overrun due to the devaluation of the rupee. The project came to a halt as soon as Zaheer’s term ended in 1966. His successor, Atma Ram, formed a committee to review the project. The panel gave an adverse report saying “it would not be advisable to establish and operate the plant in a manner proposed by RRLH” and suggested that the imported equipment be disposed of. Back then, there was strong opposition to CSIR labs setting up pilot plants to demonstrate technologies they had developed. This was despite the RRLH having already been running a successful semi-commercial pilot plant on another coal technology: low temperature carbonisation. Following the RRLH model, the National Chemicals Laboratory in Pune and the Indian Institute of Petroleum in Dehradun erected pilot plants as well.

**‘Had we listened...’**  
After several reviews and controversies, the coal gasification project at RRLH received the go-ahead in 1972 and the crates of imported machinery were opened seven years after they had landed in Hyderabad. The project also received an unexpected boost: the Oil Shock in October 1973. The shortage of petroleum products sent the government scurrying for alternative fuels, recognising that “in the perspective of the country’s long-term energy requirements, consideration should be given to installing small to medium coal gasification plants to produce gas”. “It is now abundantly clear that a coal-based energy strategy is the only realistic course for us,” Prime Minister Indira Gandhi announced, recognising the past mistakes. In her inaugural speech at the Indian Science Congress session at Bhubaneswar in January 1977, she admitted, “Had we listened, in the early

’60s, to Dr. Husain Zaheer’s plea, and based our chemical feedstock policy not merely on oil but on the abundant coal reserves, we would have withstood the oil crisis with much less strain.” However, by the time RRLH erected the coal gasification pilot plant, the technology had moved to the next level. The pilot plant was used as a test bed for research on the integrated gasification combined cycle (IGCC), in collaboration with Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited (BHEL), which commissioned the first such plant in 1985. Unlike coal gasification to produce town gas, IGCC combines gas production from coal with electricity generation. The syngas produced by gasifying coal was used to run a power plant generating electricity. Gas-fired turbines were used to produce electricity and the excess heat was routed to steam-driven turbines.

**Second wind**  
Although India began early with fuel R&D with national laboratories engaged in coal, petroleum, and geophysics research, the funding was suboptimal and projects lacked the necessary industrial linkages. Policymakers and competing interests failed to see the need for long-term research in this area. Interest in clean coal technologies has been revived as climate action has intensified. The National Coal Gasification Mission, which India launched in 2021, aims to gasify 100 million tonnes of coal by 2030. “The adoption of gasification technology in India will revolutionise the coal sector, reducing reliance on imports of natural gas, methanol, ammonia and other essential products,” according to a government statement. Massive investments to the tune of ₹85,000 crore have been committed to the Mission. Coal India Limited and BHEL also floated a new company, Bharat Coal Gasification & Chemicals Limited, in 2024 to work on clean coal technologies. (Dinesh C. Sharma is a New Delhi-based journalist and author, and has written books on India’s post-1947 science and technology journey)

## THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz to mark World Meteorological Day, observed annually on March 23

V. V. Ramanan

**QUESTION 1**  
In which European city is the World Meteorological Organization headquartered?

**QUESTION 2**  
Expand GRIB, the concise data format commonly used in meteorology to store historical and forecast weather data.

**QUESTION 3**  
To a meteorologist, what is an ‘okta’, a scale of measurement?

**QUESTION 4**  
What is the term for rain that falls from a cloud but evaporates before reaching the ground, seen as streaks under a cloud?

**QUESTION 5**  
Parts of Kerala witnessed ‘blood rain’ as recently as 2012. What was the prime cause for such a freak downpour?

**QUESTION 6**  
What is the everyday two-word term for a strong, high-altitude wind band that pilots use to save time and fuel on long flights?

**QUESTION 7**  
The recurring natural phenomenon characterised by fluctuating ocean temperatures in the equatorial Pacific, coupled with changes in the atmosphere, is the ENSO. Expand ENSO.



**Visual Question:**  
Name the Indian scientist who in his capacity as the chairman of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) received the Nobel Peace Prize, along with Al Gore, in 2007. REUTERS

**Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:** 1. The President of Iraq, Saddam Hussein, was captured by the U.S. military in December 2003. The operation was named after an American film set during a fictional World War 3. **Ans: Red Dawn** 2. In 2007, members of a private military firm, which was contracted by the U.S. government, killed 17 Iraqi civilians in Nisour Square in Baghdad. Four employees of the firm were later convicted in a U.S. Federal Court. What was the firm called then? And which U.S. President pardoned the four employees? **Ans: Blackwater; Donald Trump** 3. George W. Bush had insisted that Iraq was a “gathering threat” that had to be confronted. What did he say Iraq possessed? **Ans: Weapons of mass destruction** 4. This European country opposed President Bush’s policy on Iraq. Frustrated with its response, the U.S. ordered that the names of food items that featured the country’s name be changed in restaurants at the U.S. Capitol. **Ans: France** 5. Mr. Bush referred to an axis of evil — governments that he alleged had sponsored terrorism. Name the three countries he was referring to. **Ans: Iraq, Iran, North Korea** Visual: A tapestry copy of this painting can be found at the United Nations headquarters. **Ans: Guernica** **Early Birds:** Haridas Pal | Sunil Madhavan | Arun Kumar Singh | Dodo Jayaditya | Lalchand Bhutani



### KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

## Organising the trip was like herding cats

She is in the doghouse for not calling her parents

S. Upendran

“Looks like the two-day conference has left you exhausted. What time did the delegates leave yesterday?”  
“Some of them had a flight late in the evening. They left only around 9:00 PM.”  
“How were the delegates? Did they enjoy themselves or did...”  
“We had a little over 200 people, and they gave us a pretty hard time. Getting all of them into a room was like herding cats.”  
“Herding cats? Never heard it before! What does it mean?”  
“Have you ever managed to get a cat to do what you wanted it to?”  
“I don’t think anyone has managed to do that! It does what it wants to, and not what someone tells it to!”  
“Absolutely right! Cats have a mind of their own and, therefore, cannot be controlled. And that’s what the expression ‘herding cats’ means: trying to do the impossible.”  
“In other words, when you attempt to ‘herd cats’, you’re trying to achieve the impossible. You’re trying to bring about order and discipline among people who do not have those qualities.”  
“Very good! Here’s an example. Trying to get two small kids ready for school is like herding cats.”  
“It certainly is. I’ve seen my sister struggle with her two brats! Here’s another example. The photographer said that getting all my classmates to stand still and look at the camera was like herding cats.”  
“I can imagine. Getting twenty people to agree on a movie that we could all watch after dinner was like herding cats. Are you leaving already?”  
“Have to do a bit of shopping. Would you like to come along?”  
“You and shopping! That’s pretty unusual, indeed! What are you...”  
“I need to buy a pair of sandals. After that, I plan to visit Sujatha and ask her about...”  
“In that case, I’m not coming. She’s pretty mad at me.”  
“Mad at you?”  
“As you know, last week was her birthday. I forgot all about it because of the conference.”  
“So, now you’re in the doghouse.”  
“In the doghouse?”  
“The expression suggests that you’re in trouble with someone. You’ve done something to upset the person.”  
“The students landed themselves in the doghouse when the Principal caught them jumping over the wall.”  
“Good example! If I don’t submit my project on time, I’ll be in the doghouse.”  
“But tell me, what is the connection between being in a doghouse and being in trouble?”  
“Where is the doghouse usually located?”  
“A doghouse or a kennel is usually found outside a house – away from the warmth and...”  
“Exactly! A dog is usually sent packing to its kennel when it has misbehaved or has done some mischief.”  
“So, when do you think you’ll get back into Sujatha’s good books?”  
“Not for a while, I’m afraid!”  
“Till then, we’ll have to look for you in the doghouse, I guess!”  
upendrankye@gmail.com

## Word of the day

**Swanky:**  
imposingly fashionable and elegant

**Synonyms:** classy, trendy

**Usage:** They moved into a swanky new apartment.

**Pronunciation:** newsth.live/swanky

**International Phonetic Alphabet:** /swæŋki/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’









OPINION

The  
**Hindustan Times**  
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

Wake-up call for the collegium

Justice Dipankar Datta’s candid remarks offer a moment of clarity — and an opportunity for reflection

An unprecedentedly candid admission by Supreme Court judge, justice Dipankar Datta, that the collegium system has failed to protect judges with integrity in the past, comes at a pivotal moment in the evolution of the institution — when questions are being asked about its transparency and decision-making.

Speaking at the first Supreme Court Bar Association national conference on “Reimagining Judicial Governance” in Delhi, justice Datta said the collegium failed to stand by judges who acted with courage and integrity, warning that such instances may discourage judges from prioritising ethics over career advancement. “Many judges have had the mental courage and conviction to take the hit for the greater good. However, how many judges in present times would prioritise ethics over career growth? Do you expect them to have the rectitude to practice what is preached? It is a bitter pill to swallow,” justice Datta said. “There have been instances in the past where those who followed this statement were not protected by the collegium by ensuring that they are not victimised for their righteousness,” he added. He then appealed to justice BV Nagarathna, who is currently a part of the collegium and was on stage, to stand up to the challenge and protect judges — an uncommon public appeal. The rarity of this exchange underlines the importance of the issue. In recent years, the collegium system has come under increasing criticism over opaqueness in decision-making and the repeated clashes with the executive over selective clearance given to collegium picks or inordinate delays in giving a response. The collegium system was designed by the Supreme Court to safeguard the independence of the judiciary and to ensure only limited participation of the government in choosing judges. This is important not only symbolically — to ensure a pillar of the Republic stands on its own — but also practically because the government is the largest litigator in courts.

If the collegium system has to fulfil its original mandate, it has to be more robust in pushing for transparency in its decisions. Similarly, the government has to reconsider its stance of selectively picking (and picking on) candidates recommended by the collegium. Such practices, shrouded in opacity, not only upset the delicate balance between the executive and the judiciary but also create an undesirable perception of bias. Think of the collegium’s statement on the transfer of justice Atul Sreedharan last year, attributing the decision to “reconsideration sought by the government”. This is detrimental to both critical processes, such as seniority and filling of vacancies, and also the standing of particular judges. Both the collegium and the executive should take note.

Warring parties in West Asia should call a truce

Iran’s reported attack with long-range missiles on the US military base on Diego Garcia located almost 4,000 km from the Iranian mainland — Tehran has since denied responsibility — and the air strikes on the Israeli cities of Dimona and Arad, located near a nuclear facility, are developments that point to the further widening of the conflict triggered by the Israeli and US military strikes on Iran last month. Both have the potential to send the conflict in West Asia spiralling out of control and expanding to theatres not just closer to India, but in Western Europe. Concerns about this unnecessary conflict have been further exacerbated by attacks on oil and gas fields and energy infrastructure, which have already begun impacting global energy supplies. Iran’s attacks on cities near Israel’s main nuclear facility and the strike on Qatar’s Ras Laffan gas facility were both retaliatory, carried out in response to Tel Aviv’s strikes on the Natanz nuclear facility and the South Pars gas field.

It is now clear that Iran will prefer destruction over surrender in a war imposed on it by Israel and the US, which have given no signs of having an endgame, especially with President Donald Trump perpetually shifting the goalposts. With Trump now saying he will obliterate Iran’s power plants if it fails to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, Iran has warned of further retaliatory attacks on regional infrastructure. The rest of the world has watched with trepidation as the parties to the conflict have shown no signs of pulling back from the brink. For India, the safety of 10 million expatriate workers, remittances, and energy supplies are at risk. It is time Tel Aviv and Washington are told to end the war, and Tehran is asked to respond positively to diplomatic overtures.

Wealth of India, hits and misses

The *Wealth of Nations* is 250 years old. How Adam Smith would see India based on the economic vision he outlined in his classic work

In a small pin factory in 18th-century Scotland, Adam Smith saw the secret to prosperity. One worker drawing wire, another straightening it, a third cutting — together, producing far more than they would have had each of them done all the tasks themselves. From that simple observation emerged *The Wealth of Nations*, published in 1776, a work that continues to shape how nations think about growth, markets and the role of the State. Two hundred and fifty years on, India stands at a moment Smith would have found fascinating: A vast, ambitious economy balancing State intervention and market dynamism, global integration and inward caution. What would he make of it?

Smith would recognise something familiar in India’s journey. He believed prosperity came from productivity — what people could produce through cooperation, specialisation, and exchange. India’s rise since 1991 reflects that logic. Markets expanded, entrepreneurs flourished, and millions entered a more connected economy. Digital public infrastructure — from payments to identity — has widened participation

in ways Smith would not have anticipated but would certainly have appreciated. The spread of mobile connectivity and low-cost data has further deepened markets, bringing even small entrepreneurs into wider value chains.

At the heart of Smith’s thinking was the idea of the “invisible hand” — that individuals pursuing their own interests, within a framework of competition and justice, can promote the broader good. But this is not an iron law. The invisible hand works only when markets are open and competitive, and when rules prevent manipulation.

That is where Smith’s attention would turn to in India today. Walk through any Indian city, and you see the energy of markets — start-ups, delivery networks, informal enterprises. Look closer, and unevenness appears: Dominant players in key sectors, regulatory systems that both enable and entangle, and a State that is at once facilitator and referee, and even a hindrance.

Smith was wary of such concentration. He warned that business interests, if unchecked, could work against the public by limiting competition. He would likely look askance at India’s growing corporate concentration and the proximity between big business and policymaking with concern — not because he opposed markets, but because he believed they must remain open. On trade, his verdict might be sharper.

Smith argued that nations grow

richer by specialising and trading freely. India has embraced globalisation in services, but in manufacturing, it has turned more cautious — raising tariffs and protecting domestic production.

Smith would also reject the idea of a minimalist State. He saw government as essential for providing public goods, building infrastructure, and ensuring justice. A functioning legal system and predictable regulation were central to growth.

India has made progress in infrastructure and digital systems, but institutional challenges remain — judicial delays, regulatory uncertainty, and compliance complexity. Contract enforcement and policy predictability, in particular, remain areas where improvement could significantly boost economic confidence. Smith’s benchmark of a “tolerable administration of justice” would still be evolving.

Then there is inequality — an issue to which Smith was more sensitive than he is given credit for. He believed prosperity must be widely shared, warning: “No society can surely be flourishing and happy, of which the far greater part of the members are poor and miserable.” For Smith, this was not just moral but economic. Growth cannot sustain

itself if most people are excluded. India’s growth has lifted millions, yet divides remain — in income, education, and opportunity. For Smith, this would signal unfinished work: Prosperity must become more broad-based and inclusive. This links directly to jobs — the quiet fault line in India’s growth story.

Smith measured wealth by the productivity of labour. India’s challenge is not growth alone, but its nature — capital-intensive in parts, informal in others, and not broad-based enough. The division of labour — the engine of productivity — requires scale and organisation. India has achieved this in services. It has yet to fully achieve it in manufacturing, where the potential for large-scale employment remains under-realised.

Complicating that challenge is the emergence of Artificial Intelligence (AI). Smith would welcome AI’s potential to boost productivity, much as he celebrated specialisation in his time. In India, AI could transform sectors from agriculture to health care, improving efficiency, reducing costs, and opening new avenues of growth. But he would also be uneasy. As a critic of monopolies, he would be troubled by the dominance of large technology firms and the concentration of data and platforms. This resembles the market distortions he warned against. He would



Duvvuri Subbarao



If Artificial Intelligence (AI)’s gains accrue mainly to owners of capital rather than workers, inequality could deepen.

BLOOMBERG

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also worry about distribution. If AI’s gains accrue mainly to owners of capital rather than workers, inequality could deepen. In India, where the challenge of employment is critical, AI risks weakening the link between productivity and broad-based prosperity.

Smith’s response would not be to resist technology, but to shape it — ensuring competition, preventing excessive concentration, and investing in human capabilities so workers can benefit. A “Smithian” agenda for India would be clear: Open markets more confidently, simplify regulations, strengthen institutions, invest in education and health, and ensure competition remains central — even in emerging sectors like AI.

There is also a deeper irony in Smith’s legacy. Two hundred and fifty years after he wrote *The Wealth of Nations*, much of the world — including India — remains preoccupied with the poverty of nations: How to reduce it, how to make growth inclusive, how to ensure opportunity reaches the many and not just the few.

The true wealth of a nation lies not in its balance sheets, but in the well-being and productive potential of its people.

Duvvuri Subbarao is a former governor of the Reserve Bank of India. The views expressed are personal

Firing up innovation for the new tech age

As the world stands at the cusp of a new technological epoch, defined by Artificial Intelligence (AI) and deep-tech disruptions, India’s innovation story is no longer emerging in isolation; it is increasingly intertwined with global collaboration, in partnership with leading economies, research institutions, and industry networks to co-create real-world solutions. In the evolving scenario, countries are increasingly eager to collaborate in frontier technologies to gain access to advanced research infrastructure, capital, and robust deployment ecosystems.

Bharat Innovates is India’s defining response to this moment. It is designed to expand access, unlock scale, and connect innovation with global capital, partnerships and deployment. A first-of-its-kind national platform, it takes India’s most promising deep-tech innovations from laboratories to global markets through a rigorous national selection process that curates a cohort of 100 high-potential start-ups from across the country. The upcoming Bharat Innovates event in Nice, France, in June 2026 will bring this cohort to the world, positioning India’s innovation ecosystem at the centre of the global conversation on technology, capital and governance.

The India–France relationship has steadily evolved into a dynamic collaboration across defence, climate action, space, digital and emerging technologies and civil nuclear energy. Today, innovation stands as the newest and perhaps the most transformative pillar of this partnership. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Emmanuel Macron, our bilateral relationship has rightfully evolved into a Special Strategic Partnership, with the year 2026 designated as the India–France Year of Innovation.

India and France have a shared ambition to lead in emerging technologies. The Indo-French Centre for the Promotion of Advanced Research (CEFIPRA) has evolved into a crucible of high-end research, fostering a deeper convergence of scientific abilities between our two countries. Academic mobility is expanding, with both countries working towards having 30,000 Indian students in France by 2030. This engagement is now moving beyond collaboration to co-development and co-creation of frontier technologies.

Anchored in three core strengths of scale, systems and institutional depth, India is ready for this moment. We have demonstrated the ability to build and operate digital systems at population scale. Aadhaar provides identity to over 1.4 billion people. UPI processes over 20 billion transactions every month. Platforms like ONDC and India Stack extend this architecture across sectors. It’s proven that Indian models are affordable, scalable, and secure. India’s ability to innovate for billions, frugally yet effectively, unmistakably attracts global attention.

India’s innovation ecosystem is increasingly deepening. Through the National Education Policy 2020, we are integrating education, research, skills, and entrepreneurship into a single continuum. Tinkering Labs, innovation councils, incubators, research parks and Technology Innovation Hubs are seamlessly facilitating the journey from idea to enterprise. With the third-largest start-up ecosystem globally, India today hosts over two lakh recognised start-ups, with 50% share emerging from Tier II and Tier III cities, alongside strong and

increasing participation of women entrepreneurs. This reflects a broad-based expansion of India’s innovation capacity.

India’s innovation journey is now at a decisive inflection point, where new and emerging domains are expanding the frontiers of research as also redefining national priorities. Bharat Innovates focuses on 13 priority sectors, including AI, quantum technologies, biotechnology, climate-tech, advanced materials, robotics and cybersecurity. This shift reflects a more strategic, future-ready approach, positioning India as a key driver in shaping the next wave of global innovation.

AI forms the core of this transformation. By 2030, it could contribute nearly \$15 trillion to the global economy, with India’s contribution projected at up to \$1.7 trillion by 2035. At the India AI Impact Summit 2026, all stakeholders deliberated on responsible and inclusive AI, positioning India as a key voice of Global South in shaping global AI governance and deployment frameworks.

Through the IndiaAI Mission, we are building sovereign AI capability at scale, strengthening compute infrastructure, datasets, and innovation ecosystems. We are embedding intelligence into learning systems making them multilingual, inclusive, and outcome-oriented.

Our approach to AI is clear. It must be human-centric, inclusive, interoperable, and sovereign in capability. It must be built on indigenous datasets, language models and governance frameworks aligned with national priorities. In an era of data concentration and algorithmic bias, we place emphasis on data sovereignty, ethical use, and public accountability. We are aligning institutions to this vision.

The ministry of education has established Centres of Excellence in AI across education, health, sustainable cities, and agriculture. In parallel, the Anusandhan National Research Foundation is strengthening long-term, high-impact research capacity.

We are also investing in multilingual and indigenous AI systems. Initiatives such as Bodhan AI, along with platforms like SARVAM AI, are advancing language intelligence and expanding access to knowledge across Indian languages. This is vital for inclusion and equally critical for building technologies that can work across diverse societies globally.

India is actively unlocking new pathways for deep technology investment. These ventures demand longer timelines and carry higher technical risk. We are strengthening investment frameworks including a ₹10,000 crore Fund of Funds to catalyse deep-tech innovation.

Bharat Innovates brings all these elements together. It connects research institutions, start-ups, investors, and global partners. It enables innovation emerging from Indian campuses to access global capital, markets, and validation. And it offers the world access to a dynamic and scalable innovation ecosystem.

India’s scale and diversity make it a natural aspirant for global deployment of technologies at scale. We are not just participating in the future of innovation: We are helping to define its direction. For innovation to serve the world, it must work across the world’s diversity across languages, geographies, and levels of access.

India offers that scale and ambition to match it. Bharat Innovates is India’s invitation to the world to co-create that future.

Dharmendra Pradhan is Union minister of education. The views expressed are personal



Dharmendra Pradhan

{ LI QIANG } PREMIER, CHINA



{ STRAIGHTFORWARD }

Shashi Shekhar



Reducing devotion to unbearable cacophony

On the first day of the Vikram Samvat 2083 (the Hindu new year), I got up a little early. In the red-hued sunrise, I remembered poet Kalidas. In *tusa hāra*, he beautifully narrates the spring season: *Drumah sapushpaah salilam sapadyam, streeyah sakama pavanah sugandhih/ Sukhaah pradasha divsashch ramyaah, sarvam priye charutaram vasante* (The verse means: Oh beloved! everything has turned so beautiful during spring. Trees are laden with flowers, ponds are full of lotuses, air is scented, evenings pleasant and days are delightful.)

With a lot of enthusiasm, I entered my housing society’s park to meditate but was unsuccessful. Why? An unbearable decibel assault was on from the Noida-Greater Noida expressway that is close to the society. A group of devotees were moving with the “flame” of the goddess as the period of Navratra was on, expressing their religious fervour through boom boxes blaring music at 120+ decibels.

I am a practising Hindu. My grandfather used to be a *dandi swami* (an ascetic of the Advait Vendant tradition). My father was a poet, and discourse on religion and literature within my household and outside shaped my early childhood. I thought of confronting these “decibel devotees”. I wanted to ask them, “Do you have any idea what the sacred flame represents?”

Our ancestors started the tradition of carrying a lamp to the temple to let knowledge reach all and sundry and not be confined to a fortunate few. Invocations such as *tamaso ma jyotirgamaya* (take me from darkness to light) were a result of this practice. But today’s youngsters are doing exactly the opposite. I never thought the first day of the Hindu new year would start on such a note. I thought that had the youngsters played *Durga Saptashati* or other hymns of Goddess Durga, people would have still tolerated the noise. But the songs being played were all ostensibly in praise of goddesses but set to music copied from cheap film songs. The people organising such processions forget that the noise is damaging their ear drums (and by that, their hearing) and their long-term cognition.

According to the World Health Organization (WHO) and reports from other environmental organisations, sound that is any higher than 85 decibels can not only permanently damage your hearing but also increase your blood pressure and affect concentration. These youngsters listen to it for hours. Many have been doing this for years. I shudder to imagine the consequences.

Such decibel devotees have no clue as to what havoc they create for their surroundings. In Delhi-NCR, noise pollution is already at a critical level. The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) and Delhi Pollution Control Committee data paint a grim picture. In most parts of Delhi, the average noise remains between 60-75 decibels; during night they hover at around 55-65 decibels. It is 25 decibels higher than the safe limits prescribed by WHO. Congested areas such as Kashmiri Gate, ITO, Anand Vihar and Karol Bagh regularly experience noise levels in excess of 85 decibels.

It’s no surprise that people in the Capital are increasingly suffering from insomnia, unease and hypertension. Half of the population in the region suffers from one of these ailments. Are we inadvertently creating an alling society?

Raising questions is a valid cause. During Navratra and other religious functions, noise pollution registers a 15-30% increase. You may be wondering if there are any regulations to check this menace. According to Bharatiya Nyay Samhita (BNS) sections 270, 292 and 293, high decibel noise is considered an attempt to create unrest. Boom boxes can be confiscated and those playing it can be jailed. It can also attract a fine of Rs 1 lakh. Though there is a provision of imposing a fine of Rs 10,000 to 50,000 for bursting high decibel crackers, these provisions have rarely been invoked to punish the guilty. Throughout the country, the police avoid taking action in matters of a ‘religious nature’.

Did people of the previous generation avoid high decibel noise? Not at all. They used drums, barrel noises, cymbals and conches. Many Sanskrit words are based on the science of sound. Our sacred Om is said to fill our body, mind and environment with positive energy. However, I have already mentioned the impact loud sound-producing equipment wreaks on us.

It’s not that only Hindus who suffer from this malady; others aren’t far behind. Some years ago, I was in Pahalgam during the time of Barawafat. Religious songs and sermons played throughout the night from the mosque’s many loudspeakers, at a very high pitch. It gave us sleepless nights. It felt as if even the perennial flow of the Lidder river was subdued by the noise assault.

We need to make a distinction between religious procession and aggression. Festivals were created by our forefathers to rejuvenate our body and soul, not to destroy them.

Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. The views expressed are personal

# Transparency needed

Public should know about the happenings at HDFC Bank

HDFC Bank is not an ordinary listed entity. It is India's largest private-sector bank and a systemically important body. It is also the second-most valuable company in the country, despite its stock being beaten down over the past couple of days. It is a widelyheld entity with foreign investors owning about a 48 per cent stake, while Indian institutional investors hold about 37 per cent. The sudden resignation of its chairman, therefore, cannot be treated as an ordinary event. Last week, Atanu Chakraborty, former secretary to the Department of Economic Affairs, resigned as part-time chairman and independent director, stating that certain practices of the bank were not in congruence with his personal "values and ethics". Given what is at stake, the explanation is inadequate and raises concerns about governance at the bank. There are several related questions that Mr Chakraborty, the bank, and the regulator need to address immediately.

Banking is an inherently unstable business, with short-term liabilities and long-term assets. If a large number of depositors start withdrawing their deposits, no bank will be able to fulfil its obligations. In today's connected world, this can happen even outside banking hours. Therefore, public trust in a banking entity must be actively maintained at all times. An abrupt exit at the top, along with possible governance concerns, can fuel rumours with potentially adverse consequences. Since the interests of millions of depositors and investors are involved, it is important to know about the bank practices that were not in line with the chairman's ethical values. Further, did he raise those issues with the bank board? If yes, how, and what was the board's response? It will also be important to know whether he approached the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) at any point.

Moreover, if things were not as desired for two years, what led to the resignation at this juncture, when the country and financial markets are grappling with a larger crisis? The stock markets are under pressure because of uncertainties related to the Iran war. The BSE Sensex, for instance, has fallen over 8 per cent in March so far. The last thing the markets need at this stage is governance issues at one of the largest of the listed companies. Further, since the RBI has a say in key appointments at private-sector banks — why there are such provisions is a different debate — it must also have a role in stopping abrupt exits. Was the regulator aware of the developments at the bank? The bank, on its part, did well to quickly appoint Keki Mistry interim part-time chairman and brief the regulator and investors. Mr Mistry has said that he would not have taken the responsibility if it did not align with his principles and the level of integrity he expects from the bank.

However, questions have been raised, and the bank has to open itself to further enquiries. It must let the stakeholders know the kind of concerns that were raised, if any, and what the management and the board did about them. Late last week, the bank asked three senior executives to leave, though it was unclear whether this was a consequence of Mr Chakraborty's exit. As things stand, the regulator must probe the matter if it's not already doing so, and inform the public about its findings at the earliest, along with the action taken by the regulator itself and the bank if there were gaps. The RBI must also make sure that such an abrupt exit does not happen again.

# Things getting out of hand

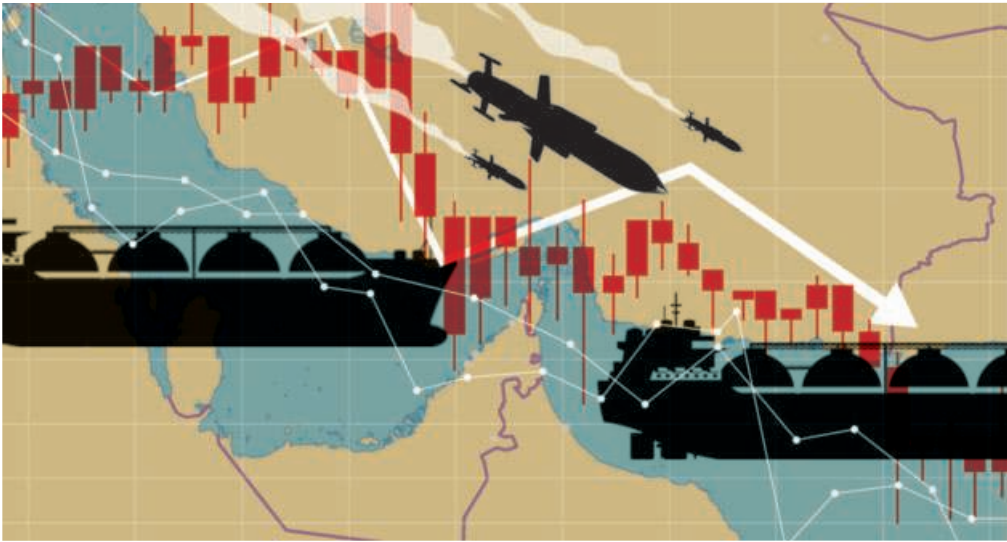
US miscalculations keep West Asia on the boil

If evidence were needed, the West Asian war, which is entering the fourth week, has proved that the United States (US) has miscalculated the outcome of its attack, along with Israel, on Iran — just as it did with the invasion of Iraq in 2003. Despite being bombed in different parts of its territory and suffering assassinations of leaders, Tehran has signalled its intent to fight a sustained asymmetric war. Over the weekend, Iran struck close to Israeli nuclear facilities in Dimona and fired two ballistic missiles in Diego Garcia, a US-United Kingdom military base in the Indian Ocean in retaliation for US-Israeli attacks on its Natanz uranium-enrichment plant. By expanding the theatre of war in unexpected directions and revealing Iran's extended strike capabilities — potentially to European bases — Tehran has removed any credible off-ramp for US President Donald Trump.

Now the US has threatened to attack Iranian power plants, forcing the rest of the world to grapple with adverse long-term consequences. With the objectives of the US and Israel clearly diverging, the prospect of an orderly conclusion appears remote. Dislocations in supply chains around the Straits and Iranian attacks on US allies have brought unprecedented disruption to the Gulf itself. Qatar, Iraq, Kuwait, and Bahrain have declared *force majeure* on energy exports, with Qatar declaring that it would take five years to revive its energy infrastructure. The region's status as a hub for tourism and global capital flows has been hit in lasting ways as the threat of terror groups rising from the ashes of the conflict — as the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) did in Iraq — gains traction. Soaring prices of global oil and gas have forced the US to resort to transactional policy announcements to contain the fallout, such as lifting sanctions on Russian oil companies and permitting the purchase of sanctioned oil already on the high seas. The unintended consequence has been to deliver significant gains for Moscow because it augments fossil-fuel revenues to finance flailing efforts to conquer Ukraine. China's ambitions for Taiwan have also gathered momentum, safe from the threat of US intervention.

With the US' military attention focused on the Gulf, Washington has shifted even more of the burden of support for Ukraine's defence (against Russia) to nations of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (Nato). The US' Iranian adventure has widened the breach between Nato and the US, potentially weakening the alliance's ability to resist an enriched Russia's forays into Eastern Europe. Nato members stalled US requests to help secure the Straits. They have allied instead with Japan to issue a tepid statement expressing their readiness to contribute to "appropriate efforts" to ensure safe passage through the Straits.

The war's impact on global business is evident across financial markets, with almost every asset class and commodity showing the second-order effect of disruption in supply chains for crude oil. For India, the vulnerabilities are evident in the steadily weakening rupee and shortages of fuel and cooking gas, most of which is sourced from the Gulf. As a result, the Indian basket of crude oil has risen significantly higher in value than the global benchmark Brent crude. Impending state elections have restricted the government to raising pump prices only for premium fuel. With the world's most powerful nation allying with West Asia's most powerful nation in a war of destruction, more uncertainty, thus, remains the only certainty in the foreseeable future.



# Chaos & consequences

Trump's America is a unique historical problem: Global impact, zero accountability

The war in the Gulf might be over soon, but then again it might now. The United States (US) administration of President Donald Trump, the primary motive force behind the war, sends out contradictory signals on a daily basis. On Friday, it was reported that plans were being drawn up for a ground assault by US marines on specific aspects of Iranian coastal infrastructure, including the oil and gas terminals on Kharg Island. Shortly thereafter, however, Mr Trump said that the war might be "winding down" because the US was getting "very close" to meeting its military objectives.

One problem, of course, is that it is far from clear what those objectives are. Presumably they began with the plan to decapitate the Islamic Republic's leadership and minimise its ability to launch long-distance missiles, and hopefully also slow its weapons-grade nuclear programme. At various points since then the objective has seemed to expand to regime change, and to contract to degrading the Republican Guard's warfighting ability. At this point the main objective simply seems to be to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, through which a significant proportion of global fossil-fuel shipments travels.

Markets continue to respond positively to Mr Trump's throwaway statements, even though there is ample evidence that they rarely have any connection to his subsequent actions. For example, on March 9, they soared after he told a reporter that "the war is

complete, pretty much", and then said publicly that the war would be "over pretty quickly".

The President has two competing requirements. First, he will want to end this war on terms that appear like it was worth getting into. And second, he has to try and ensure that its impact on American consumers is politically manageable. These clash because, for example, he has to simultaneously insist that the Iranian regime has become more isolated and economically insecure as a consequence of his actions — while also ensuring that the Iranian crude oil that is already on the high seas can be sold, in order to minimise spikes in oil prices.

This also means that he will not welcome outright destruction of Iran's energy infrastructure. Both Mr Trump and his defence secretary have said that they knew nothing about their ally Israel's attack on the world's largest natural-gas reserve, the South Pars field. Tel Aviv denied this claim, saying that the raid was coordinated with US forces.

These conflicting messages have essentially confused markets to the point where they are close to breaking down as information aggregators. The research firm Variant Perception said in a note on Thursday that the coming days would mark "peak uncertainty" about the war, and that gold and equities moving downwards together was a sign of panic-driven "tactical liquidation".

I suppose it is too much to expect the efficient



POLICY RULES  
MIHIR S SHARMA

by around 15 per cent, according to analysts. Add to this the complication of closing West Asian airspace and longer flight paths, and their margins erode further. In consumer goods, pressure is more diffused. Crude oil-linked packaging materials — polyethylene terephthalate (PET) chips, liquid paraffin, high-density polyethylene, and flexible laminates — account for roughly 15 per cent of operating costs, calculate analysts. Larger firms, with pricing power, can pass some of this on to customers; smaller, unorganised players cannot, accelerating a shift in market share. Glass production depends on natural gas. Textile producers rely on intermediates; disruption has already pushed polyester yarn prices up by 15-20 per cent. Cement avoids direct supply disruption but still suffers from price effects: Increase in fuel costs can reduce earnings, with an additional hit from higher polypropylene prices used in packaging. Tile producers in Morbi, Gujarat, have shut down due to lack of gas.

Each of these is a small cog. Together, they form a system that is bound to be affected by time and price. Over the past few weeks of shortages, very little has appeared amiss. But once inventories run down, in one to three months, replenishment will come at sharply higher costs, triggering a bigger hidden shock. The question is: How much of this has been priced in by the market? Markets react quickly to first-order shock — equities wobble, currencies weaken. By nature optimistic, investors tend to assume that normality will return soon. The second- and third-order effects are less visible. The broader fiscal arithmetic, and the effect on consumption, is treated as secondary concerns.

Every rise of \$10 in crude oil adds \$12 billion-15 billion to India's import bill. A sustained oil price above

markets' hypothesis to survive a world in which the future path of the world's single-most important economic indicator, the price of a barrel of Brent crude, depends on the impulses of one extremely unpredictable individual. However, there are nevertheless some indicators that are worth watching — perhaps because they reinforce the problematic dynamic that got us into this mess in the first place. One such is spreads between Brent, which tracks North Sea oil; Murban, which follows Gulf oil; and West Texas Intermediate. On Saturday, Murban hit \$146.40 a barrel, while Brent was at \$112 and WTI was just above \$90. As its supply lines come under pressure, the world's most global market is fragmenting. Asian buyers will be hit harder than European, which in turn will suffer far more than American.

This gets to the heart of the perverse incentives that drive much of Mr Trump's behaviour. He has the power to set off — in a distant part of the world — a war that may run countless economies aground. But, even if it hurts every global economy, it hurts the US least of all. Partly because it is insulated by distance, as it always was, but also because if the vector for economic stress is fossil-fuel prices, the US is now a beneficiary of higher prices as well as a victim. Chevron's stock is 5-10 per cent higher since the first strikes on Iran, although the Dow Jones Industrial Average is down 7 per cent.

The US today is a unique historical problem. It has every incentive to create chaos elsewhere, since that relatively strengthens its economy at the expense of everyone else's, while the rest of the world has no real leverage over it, either politically or economically. Over the longer term, this sort of imbalance cannot persist.

The natural response will be one of two things. Either the rest of the world consolidates itself into a more effective bloc, viewing post-Trump America as a greater danger than its own rivalries; or it identifies specific mechanisms by which it can impose costs on the US.

The first dynamic is hard to imagine, but there are some straws in the wind. A recent poll by Politico asking citizens of major Western nations whether it was better to depend upon China or Mr Trump's America threw up some startling results. In Canada, 57 per cent went for China, as compared to 23 per cent for the US; in France, it was 34 per cent for China and 25 per cent for the US. Even in traditionally Atlanticist Britain, 42 per cent argued for Beijing, and Mr Trump's America only got 34 per cent. It's hard to make the case to these countries about a distant threat of possible economic coercion by China when they face a more imminent economic collapse driven by unilateral US actions.

The second seems even more difficult to picture. It is true that, for example, Japan, an oil importer deeply exposed to the Gulf crisis, has major holding of US Treasuries. Other countries have been muttering about de-dollarisation for a while. But putting these into practice will involve a painful and costly transition. But the worse that US behaviour gets, the more likely countries will be to take the risks involved in cutting it off.

# Gulf war: Are the effects priced in?

The United States-Israel war on Iran has entered the fourth week and the Indian benchmark indices are down 8 per cent. The first-order effects of the war are familiar to all of us, with the Strait of Hormuz effectively closed. Of India's imports, roughly 54 per cent of crude oil, 60 per cent of liquefied natural gas, and as much as 90 per cent of liquefied petroleum gas transit through Hormuz. Along with oil and gas, India faces a shortage of refined products like naphtha, aviation turbine fuel, and gasoil. Deeper vulnerability lies in food. Food production depends on diesel and fertiliser. Diesel runs tractors, irrigation pumps, and the transport system, which carries crops. Fertilisers — urea, ammonia, and phosphates — determine yields. More than 30 per cent of the global urea trade and roughly 20 per cent of ammonia and phosphate pass through Hormuz.

The Gulf region is also a critical supplier of more than a third of global helium, a niche input indispensable for semiconductor and imaging machines. It accounts for around 30 per cent of global methanol production, a base chemical for plastics, paints, and fuels. It dominates sulphur exports — about 45 per cent of the world's total — which feed directly into fertiliser production. Sulphuric acid is used in the extraction of copper, cobalt, and nickel, which are used in transformers, batteries for electric vehicles, and advanced electronics. Even aluminium is affected: The Gulf produces roughly 9 per cent of global output and accounts for 22 per cent of supply outside China, leaving Europe and America exposed in sectors from automobiles to construction. Investors now have to decide how much of these effects are priced in so far.

Consider aviation fuel, which accounts for 35-40 per cent of the cost of running an airline. A 10 per cent increase in fuel prices can cut operating profits

by around 15 per cent, according to analysts. Add to this the complication of closing West Asian airspace and longer flight paths, and their margins erode further. In consumer goods, pressure is more diffused. Crude oil-linked packaging materials — polyethylene terephthalate (PET) chips, liquid paraffin, high-density polyethylene, and flexible laminates — account for roughly 15 per cent of operating costs, calculate analysts. Larger firms, with pricing power, can pass some of this on to customers; smaller, unorganised players cannot, accelerating a shift in market share. Glass production depends on natural gas. Textile producers rely on intermediates; disruption has already pushed polyester yarn prices up by 15-20 per cent. Cement avoids direct supply disruption but still suffers from price effects: Increase in fuel costs can reduce earnings, with an additional hit from higher polypropylene prices used in packaging. Tile producers in Morbi, Gujarat, have shut down due to lack of gas.

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IRRATIONAL CHOICE  
DEBASHIS BASU

# How the 'great replacement' theory went global



SAM ADLER-BELL

By some lights, our current political predicament comes down to a single powerful idea, which was born 30 years ago in the south of France. In 1996, the French novelist Renaud Camus took a break from restoring his 14th-century castle in Plieux to write a travel book — commissioned by the French government — about Hérault, a department on France's Mediterranean coast. According to Camus, he was horrified to find Hérault's "old round fortified villages" overrun by migrants from North Africa who had arrived from former colonies seeking economic opportunity.

In 2011, Camus published *Le Grand Remplacement*, a manifesto elaborating

his epiphany in Hérault: Liberal elites were conspiring to replace white Europeans with migrants from Africa and the Middle East. As the historian Ibram X. Kendi writes in *Chain of Ideas*, his wide-ranging survey of modern xenophobia, great replacement theory has since become "the most dominant political theory of our time."

Kendi, the author of lauded accounts of American bigotry like *How to Be an Antiracist* (2019) and the National Book Award-winning *Stamped From the Beginning* (2016), is careful to note that Camus merely provided a new name for "an old conspiracy theory," one that has animated many generations of ethnonationalists. He begins his story with Camus, but he eventually reaches as far back as the reign of King Leopold II in the Belgian Congo at the turn of the 20th century.

*Chain of Ideas* is an ambitious book: "a global history of the present," as Kendi writes. It is divided into 10 sections, each narrating the rise of a particular right-wing leader (or "great replacement politician," as he puts it) — Marine Le Pen in

France, Viktor Orban in Hungary, Alice Weidel in Germany, José Antonio Kast in Chile and so on — with an eye toward their strategies for putting old fascist wine in new bottles.

As a series of capsule histories of 21st-century right-wing movements, the book is serviceable. Kendi has amassed a wealth of detail from sources in French, Spanish and Dutch; he generally writes in a lucid, ambling style that is engaging enough page by page.

Kendi has long had a tendency to distill big ideas into simple categories. In *Chain of Ideas*, Kendi's love of taxonomy goes haywire. Each of his sections identifies one of 10 "interlocking ideas" — links in a chain — which together "give great replacement theory its reach and strength." ("Link 1: White people lose out as peoples of color gain"; "Link 2: Racial inequality data should be ignored"; "Link 9: Insurrections against democracy protect the nation.") The connection between each idea and its associated politician sometimes seems arbitrary. Why, for example, does José Antonio Kast best

illustrate the idea that "racism is biological prejudice and interpersonal discrimination"? It's not apparent.

By the time I got to learning how the Canadian opposition leader Pierre Poilievre was supposed to represent fighting "for freedom as patriots, like the nation's founders," my head was spinning. (Canada does not share America's reverence for its "founding fathers"; Canadians don't even agree who their "founding fathers" were.) Reading *Chain of Ideas* ends up feeling like going through an ambitiously organised junk drawer after 10 years of careless use. The compartments are labelled, but everything is all mixed up.

Kendi derives the notion of a "chain of ideas" from the French Enlightenment jurist Joseph Michel Antoine Servan, who in 1767 advised King Louis XV to bind his subjects with something stronger than iron and steel: "A fool

despot can constrain slaves with iron chains; but a true politician binds them much more strongly by the chain of their own ideas."

Kendi's contention is that great replacement theory is, today, the ideological fetters by which the rich persuade the white, heterosexual, Christian working and middle classes to prefer their own domination by oligarchic elites over the prospect of shedding their privilege and struggling for freedom in solidarity with more vulnerable minorities. As such, Kendi's solutions for our present social ills mostly aim to quarantine dangerous ideas. Kendi recommends "the banning of great replacement politicians when they break the law."

And, he goes on, "we must systematize civic, antiracist, queer, feminist and multicultural education."

But even a sympathetic reader will

wonder how to follow this advice in 2026, on the other side of the backlash against diversity, equity and inclusion programmes that once swept through liberal statehouses and the corporate world. Kendi does acknowledge that economic insecurity has made people more susceptible to right-wing populism.

But this admission feels perfunctory. Despite a few pages here and there on the links between great replacement party success and inflation, Covid and the Great Recession, Kendi tends to treat racist ideas as an all-powerful means of control, and the global realities underlying right-wing grievance — especially mass migration generated by war, want and climate change — as exaggerated if not illusory.

By focusing too much on what fascists say, rather than what they do — or the circumstances they are responding to — Kendi has written a book that is simultaneously too pessimistic, about the inexorable appeal of right-wing rhetoric, and too naïve, about the effort required to beat them back.

The reviewer is a co-host of the podcast "Know Your Enemy." ©2026 The New York Times News Service

OUR VIEW



# Could Hormuz flare up into a dollar-yuan war?

The conflict in West Asia hasn't just seen oil weaponized by Iran, it raises the potential of a currency war that might need to join the scenario calculus of RBI and other central banks

As reports emerged last week on which ships Iran had let through the Strait of Hormuz, India-bound carriers of LPG among them, one group was no surprise: vessels carrying Iranian crude exports. By data analytics firm Kpler's estimate, Iran's oil shipments kept up an average daily pace of 1.3-1.4 million barrels in March amid hostilities with the US and Israel. Most of it was headed for China, reportedly, bought by small refiners paying in Chinese yuan. In contrast, the Gulf states that sell the world's most valuable traded commodity in dollars have found their oil trapped. For decades, a 'currency war' has meant a game of mutual devaluation to cheapen exports for a trade edge. Is Hormuz a flashpoint that could spark off a new kind—a petro-currency war? As the world's dominant exporter, the People's Republic has converted about half its trade into yuan. As gatekeeper of the world's most cheaply extracted oil, the Islamic Republic followed last week's strikes at oil and gas facilities across the Gulf with a glower at the US alignment of regional monarchies, urging a rethink. Oil trade in dollars has long helped anchor the greenback's global liquidity, even after the US quit redeeming it for gold. Since the Iran war began, the dollar has reversed its tariff-led slide, thanks to a jump in demand for dollars as crude, gas and other imports got costlier for importers. Its dominance of trade payments underpins the US role as the global issuer of reserve money. This may have kept the dollar too strong for US industrial competitiveness, but it also grants America a privilege. It can stretch its fiscal deficit and pile up debt easily, since it gets to borrow cheaply from countries

that buy its bonds or export capital to it in other ways. This spells a key economic advantage: low cost of capital. Yet, its joint attack on Iran with Israel has driven up its bond yields as inflation risks arise. A tariff-wielding White House has sent mixed signals on its dollar policy, but its ultimatum to Iran on opening the Strait of Hormuz is part of an oil calculus, like its eye on Iran's Kharg export terminal. If China is quietly eyeing a stake in the outcome of a long battle for Hormuz, its pay-off plausibly includes a crude-invoice shift in favour of the yuan. To be sure, a currency war has not yet erupted, but the risk of one is no longer trivial. Where does this war leave the Indian rupee? Hit hard, unfortunately. With our trade gap set to widen amid scant capital flows, the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) circuit-breaker role is in focus. As selling dollars also sponges up rupee liquidity, RBI's open-market bond buying must increase to neutralize a dry-up. This loop of action has a limit, though, which means the rupee may have to weaken further for interest rates not to get pushed up. Given today's conditions, a rupee slide seems more likely to stoke inflation than boost exports, so RBI should calibrate its actions judiciously. Since RBI's other major trade-off between rates of exchange and lending arises from partial rupee convertibility, tighter curbs on some capital outflows may ease its task. But it would signal a macro crisis and take a severe inflow crunch to justify. For an optimal currency policy for the Indian economy to suggest itself, the dust of war must settle. On current trends, a dollar-yuan face-off cannot be ruled out. Central banks may need to diversify their scenario analysis accordingly. Geopolitical flux may have turned even 'black swan' events grey.

MY VIEW | MODERN TIMES

# The pothole can finally become a political issue in India

MANU JOSEPH



is a journalist, novelist and screenwriter. His latest book is 'Why the Poor Don't Kill Us.'

In my first job, one of my several bosses was managing a crisis at an event the magazine was hosting—police permission was not in place, the electricity had died and the whole thing was about to be called off. I walked in and said the helpers were yet to be fed. That look on my boss's face would appear on many other faces through the late 90s and the noughts whenever adults discussed geopolitics and I spoke about potholes and open defecation on beaches. There was a perception that civic issues were lightweight in the hierarchy of problems. In the beautiful film of our lives, the production design was done by India, and it was atrocious. But this was somehow not a tragedy in a nation where the middle-class seemed to imagine that the threshold for what constitutes a problem was very high. I would encounter the same irritation in senior bureaucrats when they talked about public transport and I would talk of air-conditioned cabins and automatic doors. There was an entrenched view back then that these

were trivial and even anglicised concerns. Now, for the first time, I sense a change in attitude. In a country that has immense political stamina for useless things, the moment for civic issues and civic order has come. I sense this in every conversation, the rage over civic conditions on social media and the rising number of citizen complaints about potholes, filth, pavements and wrong-side driving in cities like Mumbai, Gurugram and Bengaluru. And from the fact that the type of Indians who wear sunglasses for glare and not style have been protesting for better air. The conventional media too has been reporting more and more on civic issues. Last year, *India Today* did its 'first civic survey of India.' The fact that it did such a survey for the first time is among the many indicators that a certain middle-class disenchantment is gathering momentum. Contrary to their scepticism, quality of life has the potential to become a political issue if the story is slyly told by a popular figure. Without doubt, civic issues are at the moment an upper-class concern but that need not disqualify them from the mainstream. All major political movements, including the Naxal, began as upper-class grumbles. This is the reason why civic issues appearing so frequently in the laments of the

upper class is auspicious for India. In an altered America and Europe, escaping India is no longer a pleasant option. So, there is self-interest in making this a better place. The self-interest of the upper class is how India has done some good things. Today, mainstream political analysis suggests that civic issues do not matter in elections. To say this is to argue that how Indians actually live does not matter politically. But a smart politician can be persuaded to see quality of life as a new explosive political idea in a country where every other idea seems familiar and tired. In my best case scenario, our 'popular politician' will find a one-kilometre road in his city where he could demonstrate a slice of quality of life. First, on this stretch, the municipality would have done its job entirely well. The road would be beautiful. Its design would have meaning. For instance, it would have no speed-breakers that send cars flying or pavements that require a jump to get on or pedestrian cross-

ings that lead to a wall, or traffic lights hidden by trees. This is important because India has been asking drivers to be better people without doing its own job well first. The chief reason why Indians appear to change character on the Delhi Metro, I argue in my book *Why the Poor don't Kill Us*, is that the transit system has done its job well, leaving little scope for a pragmatic Indian to break the rules. Following the rules on Delhi Metro is often the quickest and best way to travel. Indian roads, not so. Once this one-kilometre showpiece begins to demonstrate the meaning of civic order, which would take hard work from several departments, it could then slowly expand its territory—to a whole ward, the whole city centre and one day to the whole city. A political idea that has some bearing on elections is almost always an idea where the politician is gifting something, not asking Indians to sacrifice their freedom by following the rules. Road and railway connections as promises are nothing new. What has not

yet become a full-blown political movement is the idea that urban commuters and public spaces can be comfortable, clean, beautiful and safe, like the Delhi Metro. India's civic chaos is a failure of the elite. In every society, citizens are trained to follow order, respect others, stay in one's lane and behind stop lines, and not drive on the wrong side, and not to honk. India needs to begin this training, the way it campaigned against smoking and for the polio vaccine. There is an argument that I have made in my book that one reason why there is peace between social classes is that Indian public spaces are so impoverished that they reassure most Indians that India has not left them behind. If you feel poor, India looks like an extension of your bad luck. So, you may argue that a more aesthetic India, with civic order, trees and gardens would antagonize the poor. Structural beauty in our country has a strong association with wealth. Modernity will always alienate some people, but it triumphs through persistence. A great city tires its opponents and gets them accustomed to its sights. Civic order would first suffocate Indians who are among the freest living beings on earth in public spaces, but eventually they will see the wisdom of it all.



**NITIN PAI** is co-founder and director of The Takshashila Institution, an independent centre for research and education in public policy.

It is impossible to tell how and when the current war in West Asia will end because we do not know what the United States—specifically President Donald Trump—wants out of it. Israel wants to expand through military domination of the region. Iran wishes the same but at this point is likely to be content with regime survival and deterrence. The Gulf's Arab states sought to create space for stability and growth by outsourcing security to the US, but have come to realize that they cannot escape the strategic costs of such an arrangement. It is unclear what Trump's political goals are and how they might affect Washington's geopolitical interests in the region. So we cannot predict the course of this increasingly destructive war with any degree of confidence. However, we can already discern trends that indicate that it will lead to a reordering of the world to our west. India must prepare for this potential geopolitical shift. As Narayan Ramachandran noted in his *Mint* column a few weeks before the US attacked Iran, fissures within the Trump coalition are highly likely to weaken the power and influence of his administration. The war will accelerate and exacerbate those divisions. Prominent right-wing figures like Marjorie Taylor Greene, Tucker Carlson and Joe Kent have called out Trump for being led by the Israeli lobby to go to war

despite it being unclear how it serves America's own interest. Many of the technology industry titans who backed Trump are worried about the economic damage that the war has already caused and Vice President J.D. Vance has kept his distance from it. The issue has split the Democrats too, with the younger lot disapproving of the pro-Israel stance of the party establishment. Therefore, however the war ends, the US-Israel relationship will not be what it was earlier. Even if Iran were to completely capitulate tomorrow, enough questions have already been raised about how the Israeli government led the US into this war for Washington to continue extending an effective *carte blanche* to Tel Aviv. The extent of this divergence depends on military outcomes, the extent of economic damage, its distribution, domestic political developments in the US and the positions of European and Arab countries, especially if international law throws up uncomfortable decisions at inconvenient times. While it is extremely hard to see Washington become antagonistic to Israel, it can calibrate how much political, diplomatic and military support it is prepared to extend, thereby constraining Israel's future behaviour. Israel is also losing the support of important European Union members. Nearly half of the EU countries have now taken positions critical of Israel in some form. Netherlands, Belgium, Sweden, Denmark, Italy, France and Germany have taken diplomatic and economic actions adverse to Israeli interests. While EU leaders publicly criticize Iran for bombing energy infrastructure and routes in the Gulf states, it is not lost on European societies that the economic shocks they are suffering are a result of a deliberate US and Israeli choice to start this war. The EU and its member countries are unlikely to distinguish themselves by taking bold positions on their own. They'll probably follow the US lead on this issue. This war is a watershed moment for

how the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries see their security. They can now calculate the actual benefits and costs of the US security umbrella that covers them. Despite asymmetry in military technology, Iran has been able to impose severe strategic costs on the UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar and Saudi Arabia by exploiting economic asymmetry. Even if most Iranian missiles are intercepted above Arab skies, the psychology underpinning the Gulf's prosperity has been damaged. And even if, as has been reported, the US did not prioritize Israel's defence over that of the GCC states, the realization that it might do so is not lost on the region's elite. We should therefore expect some strategic reorientation, perhaps through a Gulf-led military alliance that might include Egypt, Turkey and Pakistan. The Pakistani military establishment will surely be rubbing its hands in anticipation of the rewards it can secure by offering both military manpower and nuclear weapons. Many other relationships will come under stress. It is unclear what will happen to the Arab-Israeli rapprochement that America cobbled up, especially if Washington's own relations with the two sides worsen. West Asia can drive another wedge in the relationship between the EU and the US, especially if a longer war causes severe pain in the lives of ordinary people in Europe. Trump's taunts and insults will become harder for European leaders to swallow if their economies face crises of Washington's making. The upshot is that many of these new alignments are opportunities for India if New Delhi plays it right. It is important to remember that Iran is a potential ally in the Kautilyan calculus. As I argued in my previous column, at this time India's interests are best served by non-involvement. Let's Stay Away and Keep Away (SAKA) from foreign wars. Once the warring world solves its simultaneous equations, it will compute that India is a necessary factor in every solution.



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• TECH

## Science of induction cooktop, in demand amid LPG pinch

Arav Shah

New Delhi, March 22

THE WAR in West Asia has disrupted the supply of cooking gas to India and driven up the price of LPG cylinders, leading to a surge in the sales of induction cooktops in recent weeks. Traditional gas stoves rely on combustion to create an open flame, but an induction cooktop bypasses this chemical reaction. Its glass surface also remains relatively cool. So how does it manage to cook your food?

### Electromagnetic heating

Beneath the smooth ceramic or glass surface of an induction cooktop sits a tightly wound coil of copper wire. Switching on the stove completes the circuit and allows alternating current (AC) to flow through the wire. Unlike direct current, the direction of the flow of electrons reverses at regular intervals in AC. This AC generates a rapidly fluctuating magnetic field directly above the cooktop (*see diagram*).

This changing magnetic field passes effortlessly through the glass surface and the surrounding air without heating either, allowing the surface to largely maintain its temperature. Any warmth it acquires actually comes from contact with the pan.

### Conduction

Induction works best with ferromagnetic cookware — materials like iron or certain steels that respond to magnetic fields. Sometimes, only the base of the cookware may be made of such materials, often marketed as “induction base”.

So, how does the food get heated? It has to do with Faraday’s Law of Induction, which states that a changing magnetic field shall induce a voltage and, consequently, an electric current in all nearby electrical conductors, including metals.

When the metal pan sits inside this intensely fluctuating magnetic field, it acts as a conductor. Localised, swirling electrical currents are generated in the bottom of the pan itself. Known as eddy currents, these are pivotal to the heat-generation process.

But metals such as iron are not perfect conductors. They have an inherent electrical resistance. So, when the eddy currents swirl through the atomic structure of the pan’s base, they encounter this resistance. The ensuing electrical friction between the two converts the kinetic energy of the moving electrons directly into thermal energy (heat).

This process is governed by Joule’s Law of Heating, which explains how electrical energy is converted into heat when current flows through a material with resistance. The law states that the heat generated depends on three factors: the amount of current flowing, the material’s resistance, and the duration for which the current is applied. The relationship with current is quadratic — the heat produced is proportional to the square of the current. This means that even a small increase in current leads to a larger increase in heat.

### Energy efficient, some drawbacks

When the pan itself becomes the primary heat source, the energy transfer also becomes efficient. Induction cooktops convert about 85% to 90% of their electrical energy directly into cooking heat. In contrast, traditional LPG stoves hover around 40% to 50% efficiency.

While a gas flame loses a massive amount of its thermal energy to the ambient air around the pan, induction targets the heat exactly where it is needed. This is why induction cooking is faster, safer, and a more resilient alternative to unpredictable fossil fuels.

However, such cooktops are not without limitations. They are less durable than LPG stoves, harder to repair, dependent on electricity (which can be unreliable in India), and not compatible with all cooking styles.

• WAR IN WEST ASIA

## Decoding deadline, red line in Trump’s new threat to Iran



DIVYA A

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Sunday threatened to “hit and obliterate” Iran’s power plants if Tehran didn’t fully open the Strait of Hormuz within 48 hours. In a post on Truth Social, Trump said, “If Iran doesn’t fully open, without threat, the Strait of Hormuz, within 48 hours from this exact point in time, the United States of America will hit and obliterate their various power plants, starting with the biggest one first!”

Iran responded to Trump’s warning, saying it will retaliate by targeting US and Israel-linked energy and IT infrastructure, along with desalination plants in the region, if its power plants are hit.

In a recent attack, Iran fired missiles towards Israel’s Dimona, which has a nuclear research centre, and hit a building, causing significant damage. Iran said this attack comes in response to Israel’s earlier attack on Natanz, the site of an Iranian nuclear facility. Both sides have also attacked oil facilities.

With civilian infrastructure coming directly in the line of fire, as clearly spelt out by both sides this time, the US-Israel-Iran war has entered its most crucial and possibly the most precarious phase.

### Consequences of ‘obliteration’

Trump said the US would start by striking “the biggest” power plant. One of the most significant is Bushehr, a nuclear power plant around 750 km from Tehran that is also home to an Iranian navy base and a dual-use, civilian-military airport. Though it is said to contribute merely 1-2% of Iran’s power requirements, it is a key strategic site.

Just three days ago, Tehran had claimed that a projectile struck the grounds of the Bushehr plant — in close proximity to the operating power unit — also raising the spectre of a radiological incident. Although no release of nuclear material was reported following the incident, it underlines a long-time worry of Iran’s neighbours — that if the power plant on the shores of the Persian Gulf is hit, it could spell disaster for the entire region.

In fact, an attack on Bushehr is the primary concern for the international com-



Satellite image from Planet Labs shows the Bushehr Nuclear Power Plant in Bushehr, Iran, last year. AP

munity. Most Gulf nations (the UAE, Qatar, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia) rely on desalination for nearly all their drinking water. If a strike on Bushehr causes a radiation leak into the Persian Gulf, it could contaminate the water supply for millions across the region.

Iran’s electricity capacity (over 90,000 MW) makes it one of the largest power producers in West Asia. Iran mostly relies on natural gas for its energy needs — up to 80% as per estimates. The country is heavily dependent on thermal power for its electricity. These plants are primarily fuelled by natural gas, with fuel oil used as a backup during the winter. Iran’s big thermal power plants include the Damavand power plant near Tehran (2,868 MW), the Kerman plant in southeastern Iran (1,910 MW), and the Ramin steam power plant in Khuzestan province (1,890 MW), according to industry and energy databases.

These large, very visible plants can be vulnerable targets in a conflict, as opposed to underground or more modular and dispersed facilities.

Without electricity, Iran cannot process or export oil and natural gas. A disruption to Iran’s energy stability might create panic in global markets. A serious attack on Iranian energy facilities, or a disruption of the Strait of Hormuz, would likely cause global oil and gas prices to soar, causing severe market volatility.

However, it is believed that Iran has a particularly good power grid and gas distribution network, not very easy to destroy.

In fact, since 2017, Iran has been exporting electricity to Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Iraq.

Iraq relies heavily on Iranian electricity.

### Cascading effect

Since 2017, Iran has been exporting electricity to Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Iraq.

• Iraq relies heavily on Iranian electricity. A collapse of the Iranian power grid could potentially trigger a blackout and subsequent political unrest in Iraq.

Trump said the US will ‘obliterate’ Iran’s power plants if Hormuz isn’t reopened in 48 hours. Following through will plunge region into chaos

• ENERGY STRESS ALREADY

**Force majeure** is a clause invoked to avoid liabilities due to unforeseeable circumstances that can prevent someone from fulfilling a contract. This may involve suspension or curtailment of production. Gulf oil facilities that invoked this:

- QatarEnergy, the world’s largest LNG company, declared *force majeure* for its entire LNG output after attacks on the Ras Laffan hub. It led to Petronet LNG, India’s biggest LNG importer, to also issue such notices to Indian Oil Corporation and Bharat Petroleum Corporation, among others
- Bahrain’s BAPCO Energies, a major diesel and jet fuel exporter, after an attack earlier

this month. Leading aluminium smelter, Aluminium Bahrain, also made the declaration

• Kuwait Petroleum Corporation, exporter of naphtha (used in petrochemicals’ production), citing threats from Iran

• Iraq declared *force majeure* on all oilfields developed by foreign firms, according to *Reuters*. Oil ministry sources said it was due to difficulties in shipping via Hormuz.

A collapse of the Iranian power grid could potentially trigger a blackout and subsequent political unrest in Iraq.

Also, Russia has often targeted Ukraine’s power plants, and while the much smaller nation’s grid has been severely damaged, it has not been “obliterated”.

### Could lead to fierce retaliation

Iran has vowed “zero restraint” if its energy facilities are targeted. Tehran has threatened to attack energy infrastructure across West Asia, including assets belonging to US allies in the region. This could draw in neighbouring countries, escalating into a full-scale regional conflict. Iran has *de facto* closed the Strait of Hormuz — which is the key choke point for about 20% of global daily oil supplies — for what it calls ‘enemy-linked ships’.

Omaisr Anas, who teaches international relations at the Ankara Yildirim Beyazıt University, Turkey, told *The Indian Express*, “Trump’s warning that Iran’s energy infrastructure would be obliterated looks more like aggressive posturing for a ceasefire. Though the US has the capability to destroy Iran’s critical energy infrastructure, it is Trump’s allies in the region, including Israel, who will face the brunt of Iranian retaliation.”

Earlier this month, Trump had raised the idea of destroying Iran’s power grid but also downplayed it. “We could take apart their electric capacity within one hour, and it would take them 25 years to rebuild,” Trump had told reporters on March 11. “So ideally, we’re not going to be doing that.”

Any such action by the US on Iran’s civilian infrastructure could lead this war to a point of no return, as the assassinated Ira-

nian leader, Ali Larijani, had earlier indicated. Responding to Trump’s threat, he had posted a day later on X, “Well, if they do that, the whole region will go dark in less than half an hour and darkness provides ample opportunity to hunt down US servicemen running for safety.”

Thus, many see the latest threat as a tactic to bring Tehran to the negotiating table again, by giving it a 48-hour deadline.

### ‘Most serious test’

By creating disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz, Iran aims to make the aggression against it extremely expensive for the US and Israel. Iran has indicated it wants the war to stop, but not at the cost of its sovereignty or security, and it has not sought a simple ceasefire.

While the US has given a 48-hour deadline to Iran before its energy infra is targeted, reports indicate that should this gambit fail, the Trump administration is making preparations for a ground invasion, possibly to occupy the South Pars gas field on the Kharg island and open up the Strait of Hormuz by force.

Anas said the Iran-Israel war is the most serious test of any American administration since the Islamic revolution in 1979. “Even though the US President has declared success in many of his actions and air strikes on Iran, with Iran’s increasingly intense retaliation, the rhetoric of early success has come into question,” he noted.

Most of Trump’s allies in the region and in NATO are uncertain about Trump’s war plans. The more aggressively Trump goes against Iran, the more pressure he might face from his allies at home and abroad, added Anas.

• CLIMATE

## Heatwaves to hailstorms, how March weather has turned erratic

Anjali Marar

Bengaluru, March 22

THIS YEAR, sweltering temperatures in Jammu and Kashmir and Punjab, unusual heatwaves in Himachal Pradesh, and dry and hot weather across Gujarat and Maharashtra marked the beginning of March, a month that climatologically sees a slow transition from winter to summer.

Since last week, the heat has been replaced by thunderstorms, hailstorms and rain that have cooled down temperatures. Why did such erratic weather unfold?

### A combination of factors

First, we must understand Western Disturbances. Originating beyond Afghanistan and Iran, these are rain-bearing wind systems that pick up moisture from the Mediterranean Sea, the Black Sea, the Caspian Sea and the Arabian Sea as they move eastwards towards India.

Since November 2025, the Western Disturbances affecting India have been subdued in both frequency and intensity, directly affecting rainfall and snowfall. But

| • Week-wise rainfall departures (in %) over India |                |                |                 |
|---------------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------|-----------------|
|                                                   | Feb 26 - Mar 4 | Mar 5 - Mar 11 | Mar 12 - Mar 18 |
| East and Northeast India                          | -74%           | -85%           | 267%            |
| Northwest India                                   | -99%           | -93%           | -19%            |
| Central India                                     | -99%           | -98%           | -30%            |
| South peninsular India                            | 9%             | -92%           | 3.4%            |
| All-India                                         | -86%           | -92%           | 66%             |

SOURCE: IMD

this trend was broken in the past fortnight, when two successive, intense Western Disturbances (March 13 and 18) crossed northwest, north and eastern India.

The severe weather — thunderstorms, lightning, hailstorms, short but intense rain spells (over 115 mm in 24 hours) and snowfall — occurred across the western Himalayas, east and northeast India and some parts of southern India.

India Meteorological Department (IMD) officials attributed this to not only Western Disturbances but also the prolonged presence of a cyclonic circulation in

### Western Disturbances

• Originating beyond Iran, these are rain-bearing systems that pick up moisture from the Mediterranean Sea, Black Sea, Caspian Sea and Arabian Sea as they move eastwards towards India.

the lower tropospheric levels. Strong southwesterly or southerly winds pumped in moisture from the Bay of Bengal over the region, leading to a confluence of wind over central and northwest India. Experts at IMD said similar weather was reported in March 2023.

### Common in March

Western Disturbances trigger rain (and snowfall in higher altitudes) in the northwest, north, northeast and some parts of eastern India in non-monsoon months. This also holds true for early March, when the effect of winter is still lingering.

March is also the most favourable for hailstorms and thunderstorms. Temperatures begin to rise after mid-March and, under the right conditions, can trigger thunder, lightning, and intense rainfall.

In eastern India, local winds known as Nor’westers can lead to the sudden development of intense storms, heavy rain, and thunder. Also, when moist winds from either the Bay of Bengal or the Arabian Sea converge with cold winds over central or northwest India, it causes severe weather,

particularly over eastern and central India.

All these weather factors resulted in hailstorms being reported across a large geographical area this year too.

### Rest of March

The IMD has, for now, said that the thunderstorm activity will ease temperatures. East and northeast India will continue to receive light to moderate rainfall in the remaining days of this month.

Two more approaching Western Disturbances are set to affect India in the next few days. The first stream will bring thunderstorms accompanied by gusty winds and moderate rainfall, particularly over sub-Himalayan West Bengal and Sikkim till March 24. The second stream can cause very heavy rainfall over Sikkim and Gangetic West Bengal till early next week.

The severe weather will especially affect the western Himalayan region and northeast India. The plains of northwest, central and eastern India will see light to moderate rainfall till the end of March. Above normal rainfall is likely over Telangana, coastal Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, and Mahe.

• POLICY

## Andhra Pradesh’s effort to improve fertility rate is promising, but not enough



### EXPERT EXPLAINS

KS JAMES

FORMER DIRECTOR, INTERNATIONAL INSTITUTE OF POPULATION SCIENCES, MUMBAI

TO COPE with a declining total fertility rate (TFR) in the state, the Andhra Pradesh government led by Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu has incentivised births through a population policy introduced earlier this month. The state government said that shifting to a “population management” method will help the state towards better workforce participation.

TFR denotes the average number of children born to a woman. A TFR of 2.1,

called replacement level fertility, indicates that two parents can be replaced by two children (0.1 being the mortality adjustment since all children born might not survive). At 1.5, AP’s present TFR is lower than the national average of 2.1.

According to population experts, AP reached the replacement level (2.1) in 2005 and from 2015 onwards, its TFR has been oscillating between 1.5 and 1.7; in the last few years, it has hovered around 1.5. Moreover, AP’s mean age of marriage has increased from 17.6 years in 2005 to 22.9 this year, meaning more people are opting for relatively late marriages. In this context, Naidu has been urging young families in AP to have more than two children.

Professor **KS James**, a population expert who was director of the International Institute of Population Sciences, Mumbai, and is currently at the Center for Health and Wellbeing at Princeton University (US), told **Nikhila Henry** that governments, including AP, are thinking in the right direction but need to diversify their approach.

**The AP government says it has moved from population control to population management. How does this work?**

Yes, this is an important shift, and it has been relevant not only now but even earlier. Population control policies typically involve measures such as incentives, disincentives, and sometimes coercive approaches to reduce fertility rates. In contrast, population management refers to a rights-based approach that emphasises reproductive health and rights, informed choice, and individual well-being.

This approach is largely influenced by the International Conference on Population and Development (ICPD) by the UN in 1994, to which India is a signatory. But policy implementation was not often in line with that. Therefore, this change is welcome, as it aligns with the principles established in the 1994 ICPD principles.

**The government has decided to incentivise the birth of the second**

**and third child. Has this worked in other countries?**

Evidence suggests that family policies through incentives have not had a significant effect on increasing birth rates. However, such policies do have broader benefits. Research indicates that their impact is more substantial when viewed in terms of helping parents balance work and family responsibilities, improving gender equality, and creating a supportive environment for raising children.

Therefore, the objective should not be limited to increasing fertility, but should also focus on fostering a more supportive family environment and improving child well-being.

**AP’s TFR is at 1.5. Is this an alarming situation that needs intervention?**

TFR can decline due to various factors. For instance, increasing levels of education in recent years may lead to the postponement of marriage and childbearing, which can temporarily reduce TFR. However, fer-

tility levels may rise slightly later if this is the case. Therefore, a TFR of 1.5 observed over a short period is not necessarily a clear indication of a long-term trend or a cause for alarm.

**The government said that the joint family system could provide support for bigger families. Does this work?**

Joint family systems were more relevant during periods when large agricultural landholdings required collective labour. However, with rapidly changing economic structures and increasing urbanisation, such arrangements may no longer be practical or desirable for many families. Therefore, promoting joint family systems as a strategy to increase fertility may not be effective in contemporary contexts.

**Is incentivising IVF and disincentivising contraceptive methods the way forward?**

IVF primarily benefits couples who wish to have children but are unable to do so due

to infertility. However, such cases represent only a small proportion of all couples, and therefore, IVF is unlikely to have a significant impact on overall fertility levels. While supporting access to IVF is beneficial for affected families, its broader demographic impact would likely be minimal.

**On paper, is the AP government’s plan for increasing TFR workable?**

In many countries, low fertility is partly due to an increasing proportion of men and women remaining unmarried. However, this does not appear to be the case in Andhra Pradesh, where marriage remains nearly universal, although it is being postponed. Therefore, the current low TFR may not be permanent.

If there is a significant decline in marriage rates in the future, policies may be needed to support and facilitate marriage, such as helping young people secure stable employment and housing. At present, however, the existing policies do not seem to address these underlying factors.

**Happening today**

● **THE DELHI ASSEMBLY** is set to begin its Budget Session, with focus on the Capital's infrastructure, green initiatives, and education for the 2026-27 financial year.

TRACK THIS AND MORE ON [WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM](http://WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM)

**1,589 illegal Bangladeshi migrants sent back in 9 months: Delhi Police data**

**Mahender Singh Manral**  
New Delhi, March 22

INTENSIFYING THE crack-down against illegal Bangladeshi migrants, the Delhi Police is learnt to have traced 1,589 such people in the Capital, who were later deported via the Agartala-Bangladesh border, in the nine months from June 2025 to February this year.

This is a sharp increase from the previous seven months, between November 2024 and May 2025, when 720 illegal Bangladeshi migrants were learnt to have been traced in the Capital and sent back.

The drive started in November 2024, following directions from the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) to verify, identify, and detain illegal Bangladeshi migrants and Rohingya refugees.

According to data shared by the Delhi Police with the MHA, »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

U.S. AND IRAN STEP UP THREATS OVER ENERGY, WATER TARGETS AS WAR ESCALATES

**Trump gives 48-hour deadline on Hormuz, Iran warns of full closure**

Iran hits towns near Israel nuclear centre; Strait open to all except those who violate our soil: Pezeshkian

**Maayan Lubell, Alexander Cornwell & Idrees Ali**  
Tel Aviv, Jerusalem, Washington, March 22

IRAN SAID on Sunday it would strike the energy and water systems of its Gulf neighbours in retaliation if US President Donald Trump follows through with a threat to hit Iran's electricity grid in 48 hours, escalating the three-week-old war.

The prospect of tit-for-tat strikes on civilian infrastructure could deepen the regional crisis and rattle global markets when they reopen on Monday morning.

Air raid sirens sounded across Israel from the early hours of Sunday, warning of incoming missiles from Iran, after scores of people were hurt overnight in two attacks in the southern Israeli towns of Arad and Dimona, near Israel's main nuclear research centre. The Israeli military said hours later that it was striking Tehran in response.

Trump threatened overnight to "obliterate" Iran's »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



A residential neighbourhood hit by Iranian missiles in Dimona, southern Israel, Sunday. REUTERS

**PM chairs CCS on war fallout: team of Ministers, Secys to plan response**

**Harikishan Sharma**  
New Delhi, March 22

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Sunday chaired a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) to review the "global situation" and various "mitigating measures taken so far and being planned"

across sectors amid the conflict in West Asia — and directed that a team of Ministers and Secretaries be created in this regard for a "whole of Government approach".

The meeting was attended by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Home Minister Amit »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



**The War DAY 23**

- Iran continued to attack Gulf countries. UAE said it was targeted by 4 missiles and 25 drones on Sunday
- Israel ordered its military to intensify house demolitions in southern Lebanon
- WHO chief warned the war has reached a 'perilous stage' with attacks near n-facilities
- NATO chief downplayed Trump's rift, saying over 20 nations 'coming together to implement his vision'

**Amid LPG crisis, Shimla cooks fire up traditional 'char' to feed legislators**

**Saurabh Parashar**  
Shimla, March 22

INCESSANT HEAVY rain continued in Shimla from the previous night, and the minimum temperature dipped to 11°C. A team of eight cooks, under the leadership of head cook Dhani Ram Sharma, is busy system-

atically arranging firewood in a six-foot-long and one-foot-wide cavity that was dug two days earlier in a small, covered corner of Hotel Holiday Home (HHH), popularly known as "Triple-H", a flagship property of the Himachal Pradesh Tourism Development Corporation »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

**Bengal migrants fear for jobs as 60 lakh voters await results of adjudication after SIR**



**Ravik Bhattacharya & Atri Mitra**  
Minakhan, Bhangar, March 22

POLITICAL GRAFFITI, party symbols, and candidate names splashed across freshly white-washed walls; the faces of leaders beaming down from billboards and banners put up all around; and the cacophony of candidates out on the roads to make their case to voters. Though the first phase of the Assembly polls in West Bengal is over a month away, parties have »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

**E. EXPLAINED**

**Long process**

An estimated 28 lakh cases have been disposed of by judicial officers so far. If those whose applications are being scrutinised are not included in the rolls, they will have to approach the tribunals. The process may thus continue well after the polls are over.

● **Under adjudication**

**Districts with most cases**

|                   |           |
|-------------------|-----------|
| Murshidabad       | 11 lakh   |
| Malda             | 8.28 lakh |
| South 24 Parganas | 5.22 lakh |
| North 24 Parganas | 5 lakh    |

**Business as Usual**  
By EP UNNY

Unlike the ocean, our river shouldn't be reduced to a combat zone.

*It's in Ganga: Police case*

**Diego Garcia**

**IDEA EXCHANGE**

*'There's too much emphasis on economics today and not enough on the quality of storytelling'*

**SUDIP SHARMA**  
WRITER AND DIRECTOR  
PAGE 13



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# To prevent fire tragedies, address systemic failures

The Odisha government has suspended four officials and a probe into the Delhi tragedy is underway. Justice must certainly be served in these cases. But beyond fixing individual culpability, it is high time that the larger systemic failures that lead to avoidable fatalities are confronted with seriousness and urgency.

# In West Asia, an unknown endgame, a distant peace, and missing statesmen

# Youth suicides tell a grim story that society, policy must heed



VIKRAM  
PATEL

Emile Durkheim, the French sociologist, argued that suicide is a social phenomenon. How well individuals are integrated into society and are regulated by its norms influence suicidal behaviour. Two types of deaths by suicide that he described over a century ago are particularly resonant in India today: Anomic suicides, which occur during periods of rapid social or economic change, when norms are disrupted, and desires become unbounded or frustrated. And, fatalistic suicides which occur in situations of oppressive

PR  
KUMARASWAMY

While everyone, including the main leaders, wants an early resolution to the growing conflict, no country or group can get the parties to the negotiation table

To choose to die because of oppression by one's family or community constitutes a form of honour suicide — it's as morally abhorrent as honour killings. We must raise our voices against this travesty, which goes against not only the dreams of our young people but also the spirit of the Constitution.

*The writer is Paul Farmer professor at  
Harvard Medical School*

Three, the million-dollar question revolves around Iran. While the regime has shown its survival instincts and resilience in facing and responding to aggression, its future is more uncertain now than it was a few weeks ago. The regime's "survival" comes at a significant

# When weight loss becomes easy, language of choice blurs



**NIRBHAY  
RANA**

There is also a deeper cultural shift at play. When something becomes easier to achieve, it becomes harder to opt out of. The language of choice begins to blur, replaced by subtle expectations that operate through comparison rather than coercion. When weight loss becomes easy, thinness does not just become more common. It becomes expected.

*The writer is associate professor and programme coordinator for fashion design at IILM University, Gurugram*

PRIME MINISTER Rajiv Gandhi said it was becoming difficult for India to understand what the Sri Lankan government wanted to resolve the ethnic problem in the country. Gandhi said: "They (Sri Lankan government) are taking different positions, both political and military, in attempting to resolve the issue." He, however, made it clear that the killing of innocent civilians in the north and the eastern

FINANCE MINISTER V.P. Singh said the government would take corrective action to remove anomalies created by MORDANT in cases where it had led to "unintended" increase in excise duty. But no relief would be given in sectors where excise duty had been revised as a "conscious" decision, as in the case of cars, colour television sets, and other luxury goods. The Minister referred to the demand for the abolition of tax on inter-corporate dividends and said the government would announce its decision before the end of the month.



A GIANT AN-32 transport plane of the Indian Air Force, which left Pachinko for Leah, was reported missing. Official reports said the plane with 20 people, including three crew members on board, lost contact with air traffic control in Jammu while flying over Doda district. The aircraft was on a routine flight.

IN A dramatic midnight move, Bangladesh's main opposition alliance threatened to boycott elections. The decision of the Awami League-led alliance came three hours before the expiry of President H M Ershad's nine-hour ultimatum to decide in favour of the

## India’s foreign policy has held a difficult balance. Now, it’s abandoning its voice



MANOJ KUMAR JHA

**M**Y ESTEEMED colleague Shashi Tharoor’s claim that India’s silence on the West Asia conflict reflects “responsible statecraft” (*IE*, March 19) sits uneasily with the country’s long diplomatic tradition. Few in Parliament understand this tradition better than him. India’s foreign policy history has never been one of silence, but of a voice — even when it meant that it was sometimes solitary and often inconvenient. To suggest that restraint in moments of global crisis, where even the bombing of a school in Iran does not invite clear condemnation, constitutes sound statecraft is to overlook a deeply rooted legacy.

India has, time and again, chosen to speak even when doing so risked friction with powerful nations. The tension between moral clarity and strategic caution is not new to its foreign policy. What is new is the growing comfort with silence. There is a reluctance to articulate even basic humanitarian positions when they may cause discomfort to key partners.

To suggest, as Tharoor does, that this reflects “responsible statecraft” misreads India’s own history. Independent India has navigated the tension between principle and pragmatism, yet it did not abandon its voice. Humanitarian positions were not impulsive reactions, but expressions of ethical commitment. What we are witnessing instead is a normalisation of silence; an acceptance of ambiguity to accommodate “key partners”, even when they stand accused of violating international law. Such obfuscation does not strengthen India’s strategic position.

In the early years after Independence, under Jawaharlal Nehru, India articulated a foreign policy that was neither submissive to power blocs nor indifferent to injustice. It was during the Suez Crisis that this moral voice rang out clearly. When Britain, France, and Israel launched a military intervention against Egypt following Gamal Abdel Nasser’s nationalisation of the Suez Canal, India did not equivocate. Despite its own de-



ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

velopmental dependence on the West, India condemned the invasion unequivocally.

A similar clarity marked India’s stance against Apartheid in South Africa. In fact, it was the first country to bring the question of Apartheid to the UN in 1946. It cut off trade relations with South Africa, supported liberation movements, and pushed for sanctions. When much of the Western world maintained economic and political engagement with the Apartheid regime, India’s position stood out as morally uncompromising.

India’s solidarity with Palestine remains an example of its principled foreign policy. At a time when global discourse was shaped by Cold War alignments, India recognised the Palestinian cause as one of justice and self-determination. It was among the first non-Arab countries to recognise the Palestine Liberation Organisation, and later, the State of Palestine. This position often placed India at odds with Western powers, particularly the US. Yet, India remained anchored in a broader anti-colonial worldview that shaped its global engagements. It is therefore striking that voices like Tharoor, who have themselves eloquently articulated and defended this very worldview in the past, now appear to endorse a posture of restraint that risks diluting that legacy.

Even within its own neighbour-

**Humanitarian positions were not impulsive reactions, but expressions of ethical commitment. What we are witnessing instead is a normalisation of silence; an acceptance of ambiguity to accommodate ‘key partners’**

hood, India has not always allowed strategic caution to override moral or humanitarian considerations. The events leading up to the Bangladesh Liberation War illustrate this vividly. As millions of refugees poured into India following the crackdown by Pakistani forces in East Pakistan, under Indira Gandhi, India provided refuge and actively supported the liberation movement. This culminated in military intervention, despite clear signals from major powers like the United States and China that such action would not be viewed favourably.

India’s voice was equally assertive in its leadership of the Non-Aligned Movement. It critiqued both American and Soviet interventions when they were at odds with the sovereignty of smaller nations. Whether it was opposing colonial remnants in Africa or advocating nuclear disarmament, India’s positions were not calibrated to please either bloc.

It is also worth recalling India’s response to the Vietnam War, when India maintained diplomatic balance, but did not shy away from criticising war’s excesses. Even in recent decades, there have been moments when India’s voice carried a moral undertone. In its advocacy for climate justice, India has argued that developing countries should not bear the same burdens

as those who contribute most to global emissions. While this is also a defence of national interest, it is articulated in a language of equity and fairness that resonates beyond narrow self-interest.

I am citing these instances not to romanticise the past or to suggest that India’s foreign policy has always been morally pristine. There have been contradictions, silences, and compromises. Yet, taken together, they establish a pattern: India has, at crucial junctures, chosen to speak even when silence would have been easier, safer, or more strategically convenient. It is against this backdrop that contemporary restraint invites scrutiny. As India refrains from taking a clear public position on conflicts marked by visible humanitarian distress, the question largely is about the continuity of the innate Indian character. A nation that once prided itself on being a voice for the voiceless risks appearing selective in its empathy.

Defenders of restraint argue that the world has changed, that economic interdependence, energy security, and the safety of millions of Indian expatriates in volatile regions necessitate caution. These are valid considerations. Yet, the choice is not always between recklessness and moralism and calculated silence. There exists a spectrum in which a country can articulate its concerns, call for restraint, and uphold humanitarian principles without necessarily jeopardising its core interests.

The deeper concern is that prolonged silence, when it becomes habitual, reshapes expectations. If India no longer seeks to be a moral interlocutor in global affairs, it must acknowledge that this is a departure from its historical self-image. The legacy of speaking up was forged in situations where the cost of articulation was real. That legacy does not demand that India speak recklessly today, but it does challenge the notion that silence is inherently a mark of responsibility.

Statecraft is an exercise in balancing interests and values, but when the balance consistently tilts toward silence, it is worth asking whether the scale itself has been recalibrated. India’s past suggests that it is possible to navigate the complexities of power while retaining a voice that speaks, however cautiously, for principles larger than itself. The question for the present is whether it still chooses to do so.

*The writer is Member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha), Rashtriya Janata Dal*

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Another escalation

THE REPORTED Iranian missile attempt on Diego Garcia, even though unsuccessful, marks a troubling escalation in the ongoing West Asia conflict. (‘Iranian fires two long-range missiles at Diego Garcia, says its Natanz n-site hit,’ *IE*, March 21). It demonstrates capabilities that reach far beyond the region, raising fresh concerns for global stability and, closer home, for secure sea lanes and energy supplies that India relies on heavily. Rather than further military tit-for-tat, what is urgently needed is renewed diplomatic pressure — perhaps through back-channel talks involving major powers and regional players — to secure a ceasefire, reopen the Strait of Hormuz, and restart negotiations on nuclear and security issues.

*Abbharna Barathi, Chennai*

THE USE of intermediate-range ballistic missiles by Iran marks a serious escalation that moves this conflict well beyond West Asia. (‘Iranian fires two long-range missiles at Diego Garcia, says its Natanz n-site hit,’ *IE*, March 21) For India, the implications are clear — energy supplies, shipping lanes, and the safety of its nationals in the Gulf region. Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s call to the Iranian President is timely, but diplomacy must now be backed by concrete contingency planning.

*A Myilsami, Coimbatore*

### For a happier India

INDIA’S POSITION in the World Happiness Report 2026, 116th out of 147 countries, raises concerns about our collective well-being (‘World Happiness Report flags social media’s negative impact; Finland happiest,’ *IE*, March 20). Constant exposure to curated lifestyles on social media fuels unhealthy comparisons, lowers self-esteem and increases anxiety. Excessive digital engagement often leads to isolation and mental fatigue. There is a need to promote digital awareness and balance.

*Sanjay Chopra, Mohali*



RAJIB DASGUPTA AND KAMINI WALIA

THE UNION cabinet recently approved the launch of the Urban Challenge Fund (UCF), worth Rs 4 lakh crore. The Centre will provide an assistance of Rs 1 lakh crore, and at least 50 per cent of the cost will be raised from the market. Projects will be selected through a “challenge-based framework” across verticals, including economic corridors, urban mobility, climate resilience, disaster management, and water and sanitation. The UCF’s emphasis on competitive selection, market finance and private participation raises equity-related concerns.

India’s urbanisation is not driven so much by mass migration to megacities such as Mumbai or Delhi but to their suburbs — Gurugram, Noida, Navi Mumbai, and several other smaller settlements. Land use is transitioning rapidly as villages are converted into real estate and industrial hubs, while services related to transport, drinking water, drainage, and safe disposal of solid and liquid waste remain inadequate or fragmented. Spatial expansion without institutional readiness is a defining feature of India’s urbanisation. Urban local bodies (ULBs) control barely 1 per cent of GDP, compared to 5 to 8 per cent in BRICS and OECD countries. Master plans are often symbolic gestures rather than enforceable development frameworks. Slums and low-income settlements become sites of

**Urban public health crises are often framed narrowly in terms of hospital shortages and workforce gaps. Less visible, but arguably more consequential, are failures in everyday urban systems**

“concentrated disadvantage,” and redevelopment projects often prioritise engineering over dignity and social integration.

These weaknesses place India’s towns and cities at the intersection of three crises: Deteriorating public health, escalating climate vulnerability, and accelerating migration. The Finance Commission’s decision to allocate Rs 3.6 trillion to ULBs over five years signals recognition of cities as serious governance units beyond implementation sites. The significance of this move lies not in the quantum of funds but what urban finance enables — or constrains — across public health, climate adaptation or migration management.

Urban public health crises are often framed narrowly in terms of hospital shortages and workforce gaps. Less visible, but arguably more consequential, are failures in everyday urban systems

of urban grants that allows ULBs to identify and respond to local priorities like flood-proofing low-income settlements, upgrading informal waste systems or improving last-mile water access.

Heat waves, urban flooding, water stress, and air pollution are urban-centred risks. Yet, climate adaptation continues primarily to be a national or state-level policy domain, leaving cities to implement projects with little fiscal autonomy. Predictable and flexible fiscal transfers to ULBs can help correct this imbalance. Migration adds another layer of pressure. Covid exposed the fragility of this urban social contract. When ULBs lack resources, the first casualties are informal neighbourhoods.

Yet, finance alone cannot compensate for weak institutional design. Most ULBs remain administratively constrained, with limited autonomy over staff, planning, and revenue instruments. This underscores the next frontier of reform: Fiscal devolution must be matched by functional and political devolution. The Finance Commission has not just recommended a 455 per cent increase in this sector but also batted for untied grants and flexibility to ULBs. This calls for a paradigmatic shift in achieving synergy across fragmented urban agencies.

*Dasgupta is professor and chairperson, Centre of Social Medicine and Community Health, JNU. Walia is scientist G and head, Descriptive Research Division, ICMR*

## For public-health reform, fix urban governance

BE MADE BY ISRAEL pertaining to this extremely important and valuable South Pars Field unless Iran unwisely decides to attack a very innocent, in this case, Qatar.”

This perhaps marks the first instance of the US publicly disagreeing with Israel since Operation Epic Fury commenced. Yet, most of the reportage coming out of Washington suggests that, in contradiction to Trump’s statement, he was indeed aware of Israel’s attack on the Iranian gas field. In the fog of war, the only reliable conclusion is that much of the analysis is likely to be flawed. So, it might be more useful to focus on whether the US and Israel’s immediate objectives in this war are beginning to diverge. For the US, the existing status quo in the

Strait of Hormuz is not tenable. The impact of this war on the global energy outlook is beginning to look bleak. Following the Ras Laffan strike, fuel markets panicked — crude surged past \$112 and gas prices rose globally. The fear of energy inflation is spreading across the world, including in the United States. In the US, the ghost of the 1970s oil shock-led inflation stemming from West Asian wars still haunts monet-

**The US strategy against Iran is shifting from regime change to compellence. Israel is still aspiring for a regime change**

ary economists and politicians alike.

Thus, the US strategy against Iran is shifting from regime change to compellence. The idea is to keep attacking Iran and degrading its missile-launching capabilities to compel the Revolutionary Guards to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. What is also at stake is the reputation of the US’s deterrence capacity and the ability of American naval forces to safeguard global maritime chokepoints. Iran’s ability to choke the Strait of Hormuz will force American allies to reassess Washington’s reliability as a security guarantor, and the very premise of extended deterrence amid simultaneous crises.

In contrast, Israel is still aspiring for a regime change in Tehran. After the assassin-

ation of Ali Larijani, the de facto security tsar, Israel also killed the head of the paramilitary Basij force, Gholamreza Soleimani, and intelligence minister Esmail Khatib. Evidently, the Israelis still seem to be pushing for the decimation of their existential enemy: An Iranian state built around the worldview of the Revolutionary Guards and the former Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei. It is possible that the US was completely on board with the Israeli strike on South Pars. While Netanyahu was escalating to usher in regime change, Trump may have seen it as a way to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

*The writer is associate fellow, Observer Research Foundation*

## India & China, economic partners, political opponents



MANOJ PANT AND M RAHUL

**I**N 2020, India imposed restrictions on FDI from countries sharing a land border, primarily to prevent Chinese firms from acquiring stakes in Indian companies. This month the government eased some of these rules through an amendment to Press Note 3 (2026). This raises a larger question about India’s relationship with China.

Consider the global trade environment, particularly the renewed tariff disruptions associated with Donald Trump. India has responded to the need to diversify exports by accelerating free trade agreements with the EU and the UK. Alongside deteriorating US–China ties, this strengthens the prospects of a “China plus one” strategy, where production shifts partially away from China to countries like India.

Global production today is fragmented across borders. India’s manufacturing sector has lagged in integrating with global value chains compared to other developing economies. Meanwhile, China’s industrial structure is evolving. Rising labour costs are pushing it towards higher-value production, leaving space in labour-intensive segments. Capturing these opportunities requires technology, skills and supply-chain integration — areas where Chinese investment can play a catalytic role.

Geopolitics is accelerating this shift. Supply chains are being reorganised as firms diversify production away from China. This presents an opening for India. Chinese FDI can help relocate segments of production while preserving existing supply-chain linkages.

China also faces a structural overcapacity problem. Manufacturing output exceeds domestic demand, making exports essential. However, resistance to these exports is growing. The US and EU have imposed tariffs and regulatory barriers in sectors where Chinese output is seen as excessive. China’s trade partners in other developing countries are also wary of its exports.

Outward investment is one response. By setting up production overseas, Chinese firms can bypass export barriers (while achieving some local value added in host countries) and retain access to global markets. This pattern is already visible. Following the 2018 US tariffs, countries such as Vietnam saw a simultaneous rise in exports to the US and inflows of Chinese FDI.

There is a clear complementarity between FDI and trade. India needs scale, technology and integration into supply chains; Chinese firms need new production bases and market access. If managed transparently, both can benefit.

There is also a macroeconomic dimension. China’s persistent trade surplus reflects excess savings over domestic investment. These surpluses must be deployed abroad, either through exports or capital flows. Encouraging outward FDI from China is one way to ease global imbalances without intensifying trade conflicts.

Concerns about strategic dependence are valid but must be weighed against existing realities. India already depends heavily on Chinese imports, particularly in pharmaceuticals, electronics and industrial inputs. All past non-tariff barriers and anti-dumping actions have not prevented these imports. This is mainly because the imports in both pharma and electronics are the basis of India’s growing exports of these items. Similarly, Chinese power sector imports enable Indian firms to generate low cost power for consumers. Allowing Chinese firms to produce these intermediates within India could reduce import dependence while expanding domestic production. Domestic production via FDI offers greater regulatory oversight than imports.

Firms are, however, unlikely to relocate production without sufficient ownership to protect technology and quality. This often requires high equity stakes. In the past slow relaxation of FDI limits via periodic Press Notes has been the practice. This should continue given that existing FDI policies already provide safeguards.

Even when Trump leaves office, it is unlikely that US trade policy will change dramatically. It may be noted that even former president Joe Biden did not radically alter the protective tariffs imposed by Trump in his first term. Given also that the old “political cold war” between the West and the erstwhile Soviet Union has ended and been replaced by the new “economic cold war” with China, trade strategies must be amended. India too must follow suit if it wants to become the new economic power horse.

Can economic partnership and political opposition go hand in hand? It can and the clearest example is US–China today. Despite clear political differences, both China and the US have made it clear that they need to cooperate in economic circles. In fact, some commentators have argued that Chinese investors may well help to improve the India–China political relationship.

*Pant is visiting professor, Shiv Nadar University. Rahul is assistant professor, Institute of Economic Growth*

## The growing degrees of separation between allies

## NEWSMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

## WHY SUDIP SHARMA

Sudip Sharma is the co-writer, co-director and co-creator of the OTT series *Kohrra*. The show's second season was recently released on Netflix. Through his experimental storytelling, Sharma has consistently attempted to explore often overlooked facets of Indian society in films and shows such as *Udta Punjab*, *Sonchiriya*, *Paatal Lok* and *Bandar*. The success of *Kohrra* Season 2 has established Sharma as a formidable voice in the industry and reinforced the prevalence of a fandom for dark and gritty stories rooted in Indian reality, both urban and rural

# ‘There’s too much emphasis on economics today and not enough on the quality of storytelling’

Writer of films such as *Udta Punjab* and *NH10* and creator of shows *Paatal Lok* and *Kohrra*, Sudip Sharma on exploring Punjab beyond clichés, his reluctance to work with stars, censorship pressures and the adventurous Indian audience. This session was moderated by Alaka Sahani, Associate Editor



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

## Alaka Sahani: You seem drawn to dark stories. What attracts you to them?

Honestly, I don't know. I'm not necessarily attracted to the darkness but to the chance to explore human emotions in extreme situations. When circumstances are grim, emotions become more potent and people reveal themselves more clearly. A character's strength, weakness, courage or the lack of it gets exposed. For a writer and filmmaker, that offers a rich way of understanding people and humanity.

## Alaka Sahani: It was striking to see Mona Singh leading the investigation in *Kohrra* 2, especially at a time when fewer OTT series seem to put women at the centre. How did you choose her, and what interested you about placing a woman cop in a non-urban setting?

It may be true that people assume there are more working women in urban spaces than rural ones but even in rural areas police stations do have women officers, and I found their lives interesting to explore. They are doing a difficult job in settings that are often less conducive to women operating with ease. After the first season, where we had two male investigators, I wanted to change that dynamic and see what distinct challenges a female investigator would face.

Mona was the first name that came to mind. She has a certain strength on screen, and I wanted that to be central to the character. At the same time, because she is otherwise very much an urban person, it was important that she do the groundwork — visiting police stations, spending time with women officers in those regions, going through workshops, absorbing the rhythms of the character's life. She was completely up for the challenge.

## ON WHETHER POLARISATION IS AFFECTING STORYTELLING

*What we see in films now reflects both politics and society. For a filmmaker, the challenge is not to fall into that obvious trap. It is to retain empathy in your work and not preach to the choir*

## Devyani Onial: Your films and shows are deeply rooted in place — *Udta Punjab*, *Sonchiriya*, *Paatal Lok*, *NH10*. How much has your own upbringing across different parts of India shaped that?

I don't think I would be half the writer or filmmaker I am without that exposure to the land and its people. A lot of it has probably been subconscious. I spent my early years in Assam, some time in Delhi, quite a bit in Rajasthan, and I have been exposed to many parts of North and East India. Later, even my corporate job took me across the country. All of that helps when you're trying to write stories rooted in a particular milieu.

For me, geography is extremely important. If you can lift a story out of one place and drop it into another without losing anything essential, then perhaps the story is not fully engaging with its setting. The place should not be cosmetic or interchangeable. What interests me are the socio-political and cultural nuances of a geography, and how people's lives are shaped by them. I have always had a curiosity that goes beyond surface-level travel — the sort of 'Instagram travel' we see now. What really drives me is meeting people, talking to them, understanding how they live and sharing some part of life with them.

## Sunanda Mehta: You had an MBA from IIM Ahmedabad and a stable career ahead. How hard was it to walk away and enter films?

Very hard, though perhaps I didn't fully understand how hard it would be at the time. When you're young you make reckless decisions more easily because you don't always grasp the consequences. I jumped into it thinking this was just another career in another industry — how different could it be? I was in for a surprise. It was humbling. The industry was far more chaotic than it is now. But beyond that, I don't think I understood what it really meant to be a screenwriter of any worth. It's very easy to call yourself a screenwriter — there's no formal degree required. But it took me years to understand the difference between good and bad writing, to hone my craft, and to write something I was reasonably happy with. It took six or seven years before I could produce a screenplay that I felt deserved to be made. That journey was difficult, but it was necessary. It was my baptism by fire.

Do I regret the switch? No. I wouldn't recommend it casually to anyone but I love what I do.

## Sriram Veera: You often return to police characters. What makes them so compelling for you? And would you ever write a full comedy?

I love police characters because they stand at the intersection of chaos and civilisation. They are tasked with guarding that thin line and that gives them a fascinating vantage point. Through them you can explore victims, criminals, politicians, power structures — an entire society. There are all kinds of policemen: good, bad, corrupt, hon-

est. That variety really interests me.

And yes, I would absolutely be interested in writing a comedy. In fact, I am working on one right now. The police are a part of it. I also enjoy humour in dark settings. There is something deeply rewarding about it. It lightens things but also allows you to go deeper into the darkness underneath.

## Alaka Sahani: Your work shows enormous attention to characterisation. Why is that central to your process?

Because I'm not interested in cardboard stories built only around plot. For me, good storytelling requires plot and character to move together. A development in plot should affect a character, force a choice and that choice should have consequences for the plot. That dynamic is what makes stories interesting. If you look at most good cinema, that balance is there. Otherwise, you end up with films where a lot happens, the plot moves quickly but by the end there's nothing left with you. You forget them almost immediately. If I spend two years making something, I want it to be more than just fleeting entertainment.

## Sriram Veera: You once said you write to make sense of this country. After all this work, does India make more sense to you now, or less?

I do think I understand a little more about why things are the way they are. There are still many things that baffle me, exasperate me, keep me awake at night. I may not be at peace with them but through my work I'm

able to explore them — structurally, historically, socio-politically — and search for answers. The questions still trouble me but the inquiry itself becomes part of the work.

## Shubhra Gupta: You've said you are not especially interested in working with big stars. Is that because stars dilute the kind of storytelling you do? And more broadly, what is the hardest part of being a storyteller today?

What I meant was that I have never been driven by the desire to work with stars for its own sake. I have always been driven by the desire to tell my stories. What matters is whether the right actor is in the part. Of course, stars bring advantages — they make a project more accessible, increase visibility. But I'm not interested in reach for the sake of reach.

Stars also bring many other considerations. Budgets and the pressure to recover that money become larger and the creative process becomes much more market-driven. Over the last few years, there has been too much emphasis on economics and not enough on quality storytelling. Earlier, there was more balance. Even stars were sometimes willing to reduce their price if they believed in a film and wanted to help it be made. Now stars have their fixed remunerations, studios have their markups and the stories have to bear the burden of all of that.

I say this with humility: I don't think I'm the right filmmaker for the kind of cinema built around gigantic stars and their image.

I grew up watching Shah Rukh Khan and Amitabh Bachchan and admiring them but I'm not sure my stories support that kind of presence. I would not know how to serve the paraphernalia that comes with such immense stardom.

## Shubhra Gupta: Has the industry become more risk-averse overall?

Very much so. In the West, stars still mix it up. They may do a superhero film and then an indie or middle-of-the-road film with an interesting director. Here, that has largely gone away.

Roughly 10 to 15 years ago, the conversation around films shifted. We started talking more about box office numbers than whether a film was good. I often say, 'McDonald's may be the highest-selling burger brand but that doesn't make it the best.' Yet with films, once a movie becomes a Rs 1,000-crore film, we assume it must also be the best. That distinction has been lost and it is damaging the industry. Now there is a clear divide. You either have giant tentpole films or the struggling indie fighting to survive. The middle has almost vanished, except for the occasional breakthrough.

## Alaka Sahani: When OTT first took off, it seemed to open up a lot of space for edgy, experimental storytelling. Has that changed too?

Yes, definitely. In the early years of OTT in India, it felt like a free-for-all medium. No one really knew what would work, so all

kinds of shows were being made. Some succeeded, some failed but there was a willingness to experiment. In the last few years, that has changed. Budgets have come down, fewer shows are being greenlit and there is far more caution. Platforms are leaning towards safer genres. There is also now pressure to cast stars. That too points towards a more conservative ecosystem.

## Suanshu Khurana: Punjab in popular culture is often shown through prosperity, music and diaspora. What interested you in looking beyond those familiar markers?

When I first spent a substantial amount of time in Punjab during *Udta Punjab*, I was struck by how different it was from how it had been portrayed onscreen. And that wasn't only true of Bollywood — even Punjabi cinema often falls back on familiar clichés.

As real as *bhangra*, agriculture and prosperity are, there is also another reality of Punjab. Why weren't we talking about that? Those stories were simply waiting to be told. Punjab is a fascinating place. It is an outlier in many ways: it has its own language, religion, a long diasporic history predating Independence and a particular social texture. All of that makes it rich for storytelling. I still don't feel I've exhausted it.

## Shalini Langer: Was there any apprehension about using so much Punjabi in *Kohrra*?

Not from my side. We don't give audiences enough credit. Often filmmakers blame them for their own failures by say-

ing, 'The audience wasn't ready.' I don't buy that.

Audiences today are already consuming stories from all over the world in different languages. When Netflix came to India, *Narcos*, *Money Heist*, *Squid Game* became huge. Those are all signs that audiences are more than willing to engage with unfamiliar languages if the storytelling is compelling.

OTT gives you the option of dubbing if you don't want to watch in the original language. That is not my preferred mode but the option exists. I think audiences are more put off by inauthentic language. A watered-down version — just sprinkling in a few words of Punjabi — throws off Punjabi-speaking viewers as well. It doesn't ring true. If your storytelling is strong and your budgets are right, language is not a barrier.

## Unni Rajen Shanker: Are you conscious of political pressures, censorship and the broader climate in which stories are being told today?

Unfortunately, yes. Earlier, when we were only dealing with films, there was at least a visible Censor Board. We knew what barrier we were up against, however absurd. Now there are many layers of unspoken pressure and some of it has seeped into all of us. Even

while writing, you find yourself thinking, 'That won't fly, so why even try it?' The only way forward is to be clever and subversive. You can't stop writing because of pressure. You have to find ways of saying the same things without being caught. It gives me immense satisfaction when something slips through and reaches the screen.

## P Vaidyanathan Iyer: Does the polarisation of society also affect your storytelling?

Very much so. The polarisation we see in films now reflects not only politics but society. And for a writer or filmmaker, the challenge is not to fall into that obvious trap. It is to retain empathy in your work and not preach to the choir.

When I look back at some of my earlier work, I can see moments where there may have been a tendency to draw hard lines between right and wrong. Today, I think moral fluidity is important. You need to open up the work so that it can travel beyond one ideological camp and generate a more complex discussion.

## Devyani Onial: What is your relationship with violence on screen? Are you careful not to cross a line?

Of course, there is such a thing as too much violence and I think filmmakers have a responsibility in how they portray it. When OTT began, many of us felt like animals let out of the zoo after years of censorship. There was a sense that there were no restrictions anymore and we could do anything. I think we all went too far at times.

Personally, I now prefer not to show violence too explicitly if I can help it. I often find what is left unsaid is more effective. But more important than the quantity of violence is the context around it. Violence becomes problematic when it is portrayed as cartoonish, heroic or larger-than-life — when it is celebrated through slow motion, stripped of consequence and made to look cool.

If a film offers insight into violence — what drives people to it, what it does to victims, what it does to perpetrators — then even a violent work can be meaningful. Every filmmaker is entitled to an aesthetic but violence without causality is dangerous. That is what concerns me most.

## Suanshu Khurana: In *Kohrra*, you also explored taboo relationships and the remnants of feudal structures within Punjabi families. Was that a conscious way of talking about politics through the family?

Absolutely. Family is the most basic unit of politics anywhere in the world. If you cannot speak about politics at the macro level, then one route left to filmmakers like me is to examine politics at the micro level, through the family.

Punjab is especially interesting in this regard because it holds together very traditional, even patriarchal structures and a strong modern influence shaped by diaspora, mobility and global exposure. That tension between tradition and modernity is fascinating. It would have been a missed opportunity to set a story in Punjab and not engage with that.

Even those seemingly taboo or unconventional relationships are not simply sensational material. They have roots in the region's feudal histories, migration patterns and social practices. We wanted to bring those strands into a story that otherwise feels contemporary and explore the friction between what appears modern and what is actually inherited from older structures.

*The writer is chair, advisory board,  
Green College, University of  
British Columbia, Canada.*



CONTRAPUNTO

I find in many things more restraint and order in my morals than in my opinions, and my lust less depraved than my reason

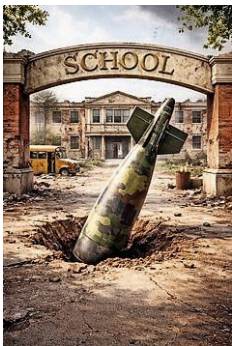
– MICHEL DE MONTAIGNE

Just Collateral Damage

Ordinary people are targets of war everywhere, even though international laws forbade it 50 years ago

If Earth formed 24 hours ago, humans have been around for just 1 second. And in that second, the time we've been good to each other is so short, you'd need to measure it with an atomic clock. Ancient Romans thought nothing of burning down enemy cities and slaughtering whole populations. At Carthage, in 146 BCE, they killed "hundreds of thousands" over two days, and sold 50,000 survivors into slavery. Civilians – women, children, artisans, traders – were fair game as late as WW2, when Nazis blitzed London night after night. And don't forget, Hiroshima and Nagasaki were horrors inflicted entirely on civilians.

For a while, it seemed WW2 had jolted our collective conscience. Geneva Conventions of 1949 laid down dos and don'ts for treatment of PoWs – some 3.5mn Soviet PoWs had died in German captivity – and civilians in occupied territories. Thirty years later, rules were written to protect civilians in active warzones. But after



four years of war in Ukraine, and now the fourth week in Iran, it's clear that these rules are observed only in the breach. Civilians in Kyiv, Mariupol, Tehran, Tel Aviv, are no more safe in enemy hands than Carthaginians all those centuries ago.

In Ukraine, residential blocks are attacked with drones and missiles regularly. Russia allegedly took away 20,000 Ukrainian children. It has knocked out Ukrainian power infra every winter, to make non-combatants suffer. In Gaza, 2mn people – 90% of population – are displaced or homeless. Did they have a hand

in the Oct 2023 Hamas attack in Israel? No, but they are "collateral damage". So are a million Lebanese. Everywhere, in every war, civilians bear the brunt. Trump and Bibi's "excursion" in Iran started with a "mistaken" missile strike on a girl's school. Since then, Iran has picked soft targets across West Asia, in Dubai, Qatar, Iraq, Saudi Arabia. In our immediate neighbourhood, the open war between Pakistan and Afghanistan has killed hundreds of civilians, including patients at a Kabul hospital.

Should WW3 break out – it seemed possible when Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022 – what are the odds it would spare civilians? On current evidence, international humanitarian laws exist only on paper, and countries that pushed them once – US, and Russia as part of USSR – show a cynical disregard for them now. But this absence of restraint in war should bother countries that are watching from the sidelines. India, China, Japan, all of Europe, S Africa, Canada, Brazil, should speak up. All is not fair in war. Not anymore.

Fund The Charge

Now is the time for automakers to step up and lead the setting up of EV-charging infra

It's anyone's guess how long the US-Israel-Iran war will continue. What's clear is that, there's no better time to step on the gas, read electric, to push for a swift and seamless transition to electrification of transport. EVs' contribution, to ensuring energy security, cannot be overstated. Great idea, right? But, as a Tesla motorist discovered on a trip from Delhi to Jaipur and back, the road – to a stress-free EV cruise – is very bumpy. As the motorist discovered, what the app showed, differed from ground reality; charging stations were few & far between; charging points were out-of-order.

With that as an on-road experience, it's no wonder EV penetration was barely less than 8%, fiscal 2025. That's not encouraging for GOI's goal of 30% annual vehicle sales to be electric, by 2030, just four years away. One think tank pegged the actual numbers – to keep 50mn EVs moving, India would need 1.3mn charging stations by 2030. Per a Niti report, over ₹40k cr were spent by way of incentives, over the last 10 years, to reach 7.6% penetration. And it's the hassle of running EVs.

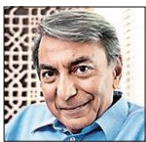


Niti argues 'gentle' mandates, and disincentives, will push the EV transition. Globally, laying out the EV charging infra has been led by consortiums of auto-companies. It happened in US, Europe, South Korea, Japan. India has around 20 charging point operators, but they can neither build the infra, nor maintain it at the scale required for a meaningful transition – limited cash flow, unsure returns, and fragmented regulatory landscape are all speed-breakers. In India, too, the mandate/disincentive should be for GOI to tell Indian automakers to stop whining for more incentives, and instead, get their skin in the game – and partner with govts to build the charging infra.

Labour pains

Thanks to AI, we may have too much leisure

Jug Suraiya



Workers of the world, relax, you have nothing to lose but your chores. The AI apocalypse looming over the world gives the Marxist rallying call a new twist.

According to Vinod Khosla, an Indian-American leading light in the realm of AI, four years from now 80% of today's workers, in fields from agriculture to science labs, will be made redundant by AI, and by 2040 no child who is five years old today will ever have to work for a living.

So what will all these workless people live on, apart from love and fresh air, assuming that climate change doesn't make the latter a figment of fantasy? No worries, says Khosla. AI will have a deflationary effect on the economy, bringing down the price of everything from food to housing, education to consumer goods, so that something that costs ₹1,000 today will cost ₹100 only, 24 years from now.

The money saved by getting wage-free AI to do all the work will go into a special fund that will provide a lifetime of unearned income, free of tax, to all citizens.

Released from the daily grind of earning a living, people will be free to "pursue their dream and follow their passion", enthuses the AI cheerleader. Utopia has never been so utopian.

But the trouble with pursuing one's dream is that when you catch up with it the dream might turn out to be a nightmare. And following your passion as a lifelong vocation can be an exhausting business, because unlike a 9-to-5, 5-days-a-week job, passion will demand to be followed 24/7, 365 days of the year, 366 in leap years.

It's like saying about needing a holiday after coming back from a holiday because being on holiday, with all the rushing about sightseeing and engaging in other frenetic activities that holidays entail, leaves you totally knackered.

Faced with the unendingly wearisome worklessness of dream pursuing and passion following, future generations might elect to be put into suspended animation and outsource all that dream pursuing and passion following to bots.

A solution that advocates like Khosla might endorse with a resoundingly affirmative "AI, AI, sir!"

If Trump Puts Troops In Iran...

His best options are, capturing oil export infra like Kharg Island, and seizing Iran's coastline to control Strait of Hormuz. Both come with considerable risks, as Iran has long prepared for these scenarios. Besides, there isn't much global support for Trump's moves

Abhishek Kadiyala



After US bombed Kharg Island, which handles 90% of Iranian oil exports, and dispatched marines and amphibious assault ships, such as USS Tripoli, to the region, talk of a US ground offensive has increased. But how might such an offensive unfold?

Trump's approach suggests US would aim for control of Persian Gulf coastline, not conquest. It would leverage Iran's energy infra, and influence over Strait of Hormuz, to force political concessions rather than pursue regime change.

**Point of attack** | Mountains in Iran's north and west act as natural barriers, making a land offensive prohibitively costly and slow. A western approach over Zagros range is also ruled out, now that US outreach to Iranian Kurdish groups has seemingly stalled, following their demands of political guarantees.

An eastern land approach through Pakistan is equally implausible, given strong opposition to US and Israel in Pakistan, especially after Khamenei's killing. And the ongoing Pakistan-Afghanistan conflict complicates this option. So, a ground offensive aimed at Iran's Persian Gulf coastline, with the objective of capturing its oil reserves and limiting its influence over Strait of Hormuz, might be more practical.

**Mode of attack** | The offensive could involve an amphibious assault to occupy oil-rich island territories, such as Kharg, the strategically important Qeshm Island, or disputed islands of Greater Tunb, Lesser Tunb, and Abu Musa. Although this requires fewer troops, the operational risk is greater. A ground offensive through the southwestern province of Khuzestan, involving a larger coalition and significant troop commitment, is another possibility.

An amphibious assault would most likely target Kharg, as US strikes have considerably destroyed Iranian military assets there. The reported deployment of over 5,000 marines to West Asia increases the likelihood of this option.

In a ground offensive through Khuzestan, US forces would enter from Iraq or Kuwait. Flat terrain and marshes here would favour an advance, supported

by overwhelming air superiority. The first phase would target Ahvaz, which has Iran's largest oil field. Khuzestan also has other major fields like Gachsaran, Marun, Bibi Hakimeh, Agha Jari, and Karanj, making it a critical energy hub. And given the presence of several Iranian nuclear sites in the region, seizing them could also be a key mission objective.

After capturing key oil infra, the campaign may aim to weaken Iran's access to the Gulf, while strengthening coalition supply lines, by advancing along the coastline, towards Bushehr and Bandar Abbas. Capturing major ports, such as Imam Khomeini and Bandar Abbas, would weaken Iran's military and economic



Night flight operations underway on USS Tripoli

position, along with its leverage over energy flows and maritime access.

Success of this plan would give US a strategic choice between halting and declaring victory – the safer option – or pushing inland, with support from local militias and anti-regime groups.

**Why action seems unavoidable** | Iran's new leadership has reportedly rejected Trump's proposals to renew negotiations. So, US is likely seeking a strong bargaining chip to bring Iran back to the negotiating table. Capturing critical and sensitive territory could provide this leverage, and act as an off-ramp.

Secondly, Iranian missile and drone strikes targeting US partners in West Asia, have strained confidence in

Cong Gotta Beat BJP To Even Be King Of Oppn

Party's poll results in Kerala and Assam will decide its place in opposition – is it first among equals, or not? Until that wrangle is settled, opposition INDIA bloc will remain listless

Asim Ali



Elections in Assam, TN, Kerala and WB might, finally, help resolve national opposition's core dilemma. Will INDIA bloc evolve into a jointly led 'coalition of equals', or into a Congress-led front, as 'first among equals'? Until this is resolved, opposition will likely remain in limbo, or "on life support", as J&K CM Omar Abdullah put it.

If Congress wins Kerala and Assam, where it's the main challenger, it would revive its claim to primacy. Defeats for Congress, and victories for TMC and DMK, in WB and TN, respectively, would reset equations among national opposition, towards parity.

After Congress's resurgence in 2024 LS elections – it won 99 of INDIA bloc's 234 seats – Congress's pretensions to opposition leadership have taken a battering. It fared poorly against BJP in Haryana, Maharashtra, Delhi and Bihar. The only states where INDIA constituents defeated BJP were fronted by regional outfits, Congress as junior partner – JMM in Jharkhand, NC in J&K. A TMC victory against BJP in Bengal would only add more weight to this trend.

Both Congress and state parties understand the stakes involved, which explains the pitched battles between them, last few months. In its bid for revival, Congress is fighting four distinct battles this election cycle.

First, in TN, Congress has been trying to break out of its mould as a junior coalition partner to DMK, confined to a few pockets. Much like in Bihar with RJD, Congress spent the lead-up to the campaign in sharpening its own identity, by distancing itself from DMK. This included overtures made by state Congress leaders to actor Vijay's TVK, and corruption allegations by veterans like Manickam Tagore against DMK, until now, their most loyal ally.

The gambit has failed so far. Stalin has steadfastly refused to either significantly increase Congress's seat share, or commit DMK to sharing power, or ministerial

portfolios, with the party. Ultimately, Congress high command has accepted this subordinate role, and pulled back from destructive moves like friendly fights that wrecked the alliance in Bihar.

Second, in WB, Congress has hitched its revival plans to political independence, moving out of the Left alliance, alongside which it fought the last two elections. Both Congress and Left Front have seen their fortunes plummet in Bengal. Neither could open its account in the last elections – down from 44, and 32, seats, respectively, in 2016's election.

The tussle between the former partners is effectively for political survival, which means finishing in third place, leaving TMC and BJP to fight for state power. WB will, thus, test the validity of Congress's idea, to regenerate its latent base, by contesting maximum seats possible. The assumption is that only by fighting alone can Congress recharge its dormant organisational cadre statewide, or at least in its former strongholds of north-central Bengal such as Malda, Murshidabad and Nadia districts.

Third, biggest stakes for Congress are in Kerala and Assam, both states where the party has been out of power for a decade, and is, therefore, primed to benefit from anti-incumbency sentiments. Much of the established old guard in both states has faded, passed away or defected. This has opened up space for Congress high command to implement the party's '2022 Udaipur declaration' for younger leadership, drawn from diverse castes/communities. Yet, that vision has been enacted only superficially. Few points:

● It's true Congress state units are fronted in both states by younger faces – VD Satheesan (Kerala) and Gaurav Gogoi (Assam). But overhauling of state party organisations hasn't kept step with these generational shifts. Nor are factional conflicts tamed, that had contributed

to Congress's drubbing in the last elections.

● Factionalism has become less institutionalised in Kerala than earlier decades (the classic Congress A of Antony/Chandy vs Congress I of Chennithala), the party still revolves around leadership groups, with KC Venugopal also entering the fray as a pillar of patronage. Meanwhile, Congress's strategy, to confer primary authority in Assam, to Gaurav Gogoi, and project him as presumptive CM nominee, fuelled squabbles – evident in the high-profile exits of veterans Pradyut Bordoloi and Bhupen Borah.

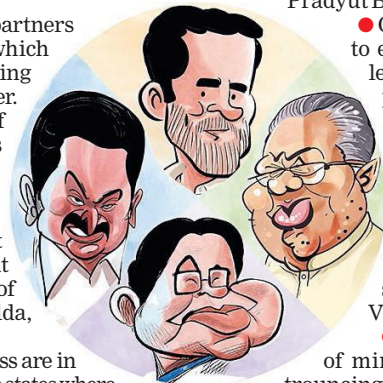
● Congress high command has also failed to enact inclusive representation at the leadership level, in either state, as was promised in the Udaipur declaration. In Kerala, party leadership continues to skew towards upper-caste Nairs and Christians, while in Assam, it's tilted towards caste-Hindu elites.

● Communalism and corruption aside, Congress hasn't articulated a programmatic agenda, in either state, that can be contrasted with Vijayan's or Himanta's tenures.

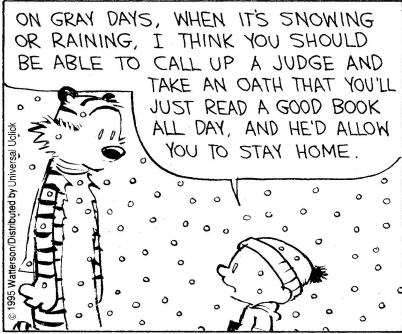
● Congress's strengths include return of minorities to its fold. Rakibul Hussain trouncing AIUDF's Ajmal, in LS 2024, indicated a Muslim return to Congress in Assam, a sentiment reinforced by Congress's decision, this time, to not ally with AIUDE. Similarly, Congress appears poised to increase vote share among Muslims and Christians in Kerala.

Finally, Congress high command appears unable to be a force multiplier for its state units, failing to translate pervasive mass concerns of national scope – unemployment and price rise – into electorally salient state issues. Unless the Gandhi-Kharge Congress finds a way to overcome this, it'll struggle to defeat BJP in head-to-head elections, and emerge as 'first among equals' within opposition.

The writer is a political scientist



Calvin & Hobbes



Navratri: Renounce Fried Food, Awaken Shakti Within

Anandmurti Gurumaa

To truly understand the essence of Navratri, one must first understand the nature of existence, which operates on three distinct levels: the gross, subtle, and causal. This triad can be beautifully understood through the simple analogy of an incense stick. The physical stick that you can hold and touch is the gross form. When lit, it produces smoke that is visible but impossible to grasp, representing the subtle form. Eventually, that smoke merges entirely into the vastness of space, leaving behind an invisible but undeniable fragrance – this is the causal state.

Similarly, the Divine Mother, or Bhagavati, exists in these three forms. Her gross form is the physical murti we worship, or her mythological incarnation. Her subtle form is the immense, invisible energy that powers our senses, just as the physical eye is gross, but the power of sight

within it is subtle. Ultimately, her causal form is the infinite, formless source of all creation, the golden womb from which the entire cosmos emanates.

Ancient sages understood this profound connection between macrocosm of the universe and microcosm of the human body, which is why Navratri is celebrated during the vital junction of changing seasons. As the cold retreats and summer approaches, our internal digestive fire naturally weakens, making the body vulnerable. To counteract this, fasting is prescribed.

However, modern society has deeply misunderstood this practice. True fasting is not an excuse to substitute regular grains with heavy, fried snacks eaten continuously. Genuine fasting is a conscious withdrawal from food to give the physical system a profound rest. For those who are healthy, a water fast allows the body to enter a state of

autophagy, which naturally clears out dead cells and heals internal organs.

This immense willpower to control the senses is perfectly exemplified in the legend of Devi. In her ultimate quest to attain Shiv, her penance was so fierce that she gradually renounced all food. When she stopped eating fallen leaves to sustain her physical body, she earned the beautiful name Aparna, the one who exists without even a leaf. We are called to emulate a fraction of this supreme dedication during Navratri.

Physical rituals we perform during these nine days are designed to anchor this commitment. Tying a sacred mauli, a thread on the wrist, acts as a constant physical reminder of our vows, gently stopping our hand when we reach for unnecessary food or distractions. Applying a sandalwood tilak on the forehead activates the ajna chakra; as it dries and gently pulls

the skin, it naturally draws our scattered attention inward, building an unshakeable focus and awakening our deepest intuition.

When the body is purified through fasting and the mind is anchored through discipline, true spiritual awakening begins. Lighting a ghee lamp in front of the Devi is not simply a ritual to show light to the divine, but a powerful tool to steady the human mind.

By practising *trataka* – unblinking gazing at the flame – alongside the chanting of sacred *stotras*, one can bring the wandering mind to a point of absolute stillness. The ultimate culmination of Navratri is the realisation that Bhagavati is not an external deity; she is the *Satchidananda* – truth, consciousness, and bliss – that breathes through our lungs, sees through our eyes, and beats in our hearts. By mastering our senses, our breath, and our minds, we move from being ordinary humans to realising the absolute, supreme Shakti that resides within us.

Sacredspace



Swami Vivekananda

A Samnyasin cannot belong to any religion, for his is a life of independent thought, which draws from all religions; his is a life of realisation, not merely of theory or belief, much less of dogma.



Editor's  
TAKE

## Preserving Bhagirathi: India's ecological test case

Bhagirathi is the source of a river that sustains millions. The challenge is, if India can pursue development without eroding it ecological foundation

The Bhagirathi Eco-Sensitive Zone (BESZ) is tucked in the Himalayan ecosystem and is one of the most fragile systems we have. It is highly vulnerable to even slight changes in climate or human intervention. Even limited construction and human activity can create havoc in this highly sensitive zone. Despite this, massive construction projects are underway, hundreds of dams are being built, and infrastructure expansion is seriously undermining the ecological integrity of the Himalayas.

It is not that the risks are not evaluated, but they have been sidelined in the name of development and progress. And the people have paid the price for it. Flash floods, landslides and forest fires have taken a heavy toll on human life and property. In this context, the recent intervention by Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav on the need for "stakeholder convergence" in the Bhagirathi Eco-Sensitive Zone is both timely and necessary. The Bhagirathi basin-where Ganga originates - is not merely a geographic entity is the basis of Indian civilisation. If anything goes wrong, it will affect the entire northern India, so preserving it is not just about environmental concerns but a larger issue of saving the lifeline of the nation. It is a national imperative.

The Bhagirathi Eco-Sensitive Zone (BESZ) is located in fragile Himalayan terrain with rich biodiversity and has high hydrological importance. This feeds one of the world's most densely populated river systems. Any disturbance here-be it deforestation, unregulated construction, or hydropower overreach can have a detrimental effect on millions of people who depend on the Ganga for water, agriculture, and livelihood. The present state of the BESZ is not a happy one and is constantly under strain. The push for infrastructure and economic development is not in keeping with environmental prudence. Many projects have been undertaken without adequate cumulative impact assessments.

At the same time, conservation cannot be pursued in isolation from local aspirations. The communities inhabiting the Bhagirathi valley face real challenges-limited access to services, economic constraints, and vulnerability to climate change. Stalling all projects will risk alienating these stakeholders and undermining conservation goals.

This is where the idea of "stakeholder convergence" becomes crucial. It implies genuine participation of local communities, scientists, and civil society in decision-making. Indeed, the BESZ must be governed by robust, science-based frameworks. Comprehensive cumulative impact assessments should guide all major interventions.

The monitoring committees must be empowered with real authority, technical expertise, and transparency in functioning. Sustainable livelihood - Eco-tourism, organic farming, and value-added forest produce can align economic incentives with ecological preservation. Local communities should be treated as custodians of India's ecological heritage not as encroachers!



ANIL  
BHATT

In the 1991 Gulf War, what the US-led coalition forces attacked near Baghdad, claiming it was a biological weapons laboratory, turned out to be a baby milk factory. The incident became a prominent example of the "intelligence controversies" about Iraq possessing weapons of mass destruction (WMD) and made it more difficult to differentiate between civilian dual-use infrastructure and hidden weapons production.

In 2003, the US attacked Iraq based on largely false assumptions that Saddam Hussein possessed stockpiles of WMD, held active biological/chemical weapons programs, and maintained ties to terrorist organisations like Al-Qaeda. Investigations after the invasion revealed that these assumptions were based on flawed or misrepresented intelligence, and no active WMD programs or links to the 9/11 attacks were found.

On February 28, 2026, following failed negotiations, claims of imminent threats, and Iran's alleged continued efforts to build a nuclear weapon, the US and Israel launched "Operation Epic Fury"-the name selected by Trump-a series of coordinated military attacks on Iran, aiming to dismantle its nuclear and ballistic missile programs, prevent regional attacks, and potentially force regime change. For twenty days since it began, this largely "troop-less" war has amounted to missile strikes and aerial bombardment, causing significant civilian casualties, including at least 165 schoolgirls and injuring many others in Iran.

The United States deployed a formidable array of advanced weaponry. These included Tomahawk cruise missiles launched from naval platforms, GBU-28 bunker-buster bombs targeting fortified underground facilities, and Joint Direct Attack Munition (JDAM) kits converting conventional bombs into precision-guided weapons. B-2 stealth bombers were used against hardened targets, while Hellfire "Ninja" missiles enabled highly precise strikes. Ground-based systems such as HIMARS were also reportedly employed.

Israel complemented these capabilities with its own advanced systems, including Delilah stand-off missiles and Rampage supersonic air-to-surface missiles. SPICE guidance kits enhanced strike accuracy even in GPS-denied environments. Its F-35I "Adir" stealth fighters and F-15I "Ra'am" strike aircraft enabled deep-penetration and heavy payload missions.

In twenty days, U.S. and Israeli forces have reportedly struck over 15,000 targets across Iran during an escalating conflict, with the Pentagon reporting over 7,000-7,800 targets hit by U.S.



RACHNA  
LAKHPATRI

## 2ND OPINION

Diplomacy fills the headlines. The real price is being paid in silence - at the bottom of our oceans, in the rivers we drink from, in the skies our children will breathe. There is a conversation happening in every war room in the world right now. It involves maps, missiles, and men in suits who speak the language of strategy with the ease of breathing. What no one is putting on the table - what no one has the appetite to discuss - is what is quietly dying while they talk. Not just the soldiers. Not just the civilians. But water. The very thing that made this planet worth fighting over in the first place.

We speak of wars in terms of land gained and lives lost. But no map ever marks the aquifer poisoned by depleted uranium, or the seabed cratered by bomb blasts, or the coastline choked in oil from a vessel that became



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## When the oceans bleed: Hidden war on water

collateral damage on a Tuesday afternoon nobody will remember. Wars are fought on land. But they bleed into water. Think of what goes into a modern war: the fuel leaking from warships, the chemicals used to manufacture weapons being dumped or washed into water bodies, the munitions tested in coastal waters, the industrial effluents from factories that run double shifts feeding a conflict economy. Now multiply that by every active conflict zone on the planet. The ocean does not file a complaint. It absorbs. It changes. It dies, slowly, in a way that takes decades to confirm and a generation to feel.

Marine life has no passport. The coral reef does not know whether the chemical that bleaches it came from a peace-keeping mission or a proxy war. The whale that beaches itself on a shoreline three thousand kilometres from a conflict zone does not understand geopolitics. It only understands that something in the water has changed. And when marine ecosystems collapse, the climate responds - not with a press conference, but with a fever that does not break.

We live in a curious age. Diplomacy is at a historic peak - there have never been more summits, more agreements, and more frameworks for peace. And yet the environmental cost of the conflicts that these summits are supposed to prevent or resolve has never been higher. We sign climate accords in glass buildings, and then burn

the ocean floor, testing weapons that are never officially acknowledged. The hypocrisy is not even hidden anymore. It is simply filed under 'national interest.'

The political landscape is complicated. Sovereignty is real. Security is not a luxury. People are not naive enough to believe that wars will stop because the fish are dying. But we need to be stubborn enough to believe that we must start counting the environmental cost of conflict the same way we count the human cost. A body count

makes the front page. A dead ocean makes a footnote in a scientific journal that nobody reads. How many filters will we use? That is the right question. Not how many wars will we fight, but how many layers of purification will it take before

what comes out the other end is safe enough to call water? We have the technology. We will build the filters. But there is something deeply broken about a civilisation that destroys a resource with one hand and engineers a solution with the other, and calls that progress. Water is not a resource. It is a relationship - between the land and the sky, between the living and those who come after. Every war that poisons it is not just a crime against nature. It is a crime against time itself. And time, unlike a ceasefire, cannot be negotiated.

The writer is a freelancer writes on development, social and gender issues

The Pioneer  
SINCE 1865

## TAMIL NADU'S POLITICAL MATURITY BEYOND CINEMA STEREOTYPES

Mr. Kiran Rijiju's recent remark on Tamil society—that Tamilians excel in science yet emotionally submit to film heroes—does not fully reflect reality. Tamil Nadu's progress is rooted in sustained investments in education, skill development, and healthcare, upheld by successive governments regardless of political affiliation. Despite limited natural resources and dependence on other states for water, Tamil Nadu consistently ranks high on development indices and maintains a strong industrial and infrastructure base. Even the Madras port, though not a natural harbour, remains a significant asset. Development, though varying in pace across regimes, has always remained a priority, making the state a major source of technocrats and skilled manpower. The claim regarding blind devotion to film heroes also

requires correction. Only M.G. Ramachandran and J. Jayalalithaa successfully transitioned from cinema to political power. Several others—such as Sivaji Ganesan, Vijayakanth, Karthik, and Sarathkumar—failed despite political attempts. Currently, Vijay's political foray appears uncertain, marked by limited clarity in ideology and crisis management. Public gatherings often reflect cinematic appeal rather than political endorsement. Tamil Nadu's electorate is politically aware and discerning. While alliances shift, voters do not easily conflate celebrity with leadership. Political parties, too, remain cautious in their strategies, reflecting a mature and pragmatic political culture that resists simplistic generalisations.

A G RAJMOHAN, | ANANTAPUR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Rupee debate: Then and now

There is nothing wrong in questioning the trajectory of the Indian Rupee (INR) from the tenure of Dr. Manmohan Singh to the present government led by Narendra Modi. When Mr. Modi assumed office as Prime Minister in 2014, the exchange rate stood at approximately 1 USD = ₹58.58. As of 20 March 2026, it has depreciated to around 1 USD = ₹93.49. It is worth recalling that during his tenure as Chief Minister of Gujarat, Mr. Modi was a vocal critic of the UPA government over the falling rupee, which declined from about ₹45 to beyond ₹60. In his speech on 20 August 2013, he remarked: "We never thought such a huge economic mess would be created. It's a grave concern. There is a lack of confidence in the leadership. It is the country's misfortune that the leadership only cares about staying in power and not about national security or strengthening the rupee." He went further to link the weakening rupee to the government's credibility, even drawing comparisons between the currency's decline and the age of the then Prime Minister. Today, while some argue that global factors—particularly the strengthening of the US dollar—have contributed to the rupee's depreciation, and that it has performed relatively better than several other currencies, the reality remains that the rupee has significantly weakened over time.

BIDYUT KUMAR CHATTERJEE | FARIDABAD

### Rising input costs add to farmers' woes

The sharp 25 per cent rise in pesticide prices amid the ongoing West Asia conflict has dealt a severe blow to already distressed farmers. Erratic and unseasonal weather has damaged standing crops, while soaring input costs have made fresh sowing increasingly unaffordable. This double burden is pushing farmers deeper into financial uncertainty. The situation becomes even more alarming when market prices collapse.

Farmers are often forced to sell their produce—such as potatoes in Punjab—at as low as ₹1 per kg, far below the promised Minimum Support Price (MSP). Such distress sales leave them trapped in a cycle of debt and despair, eroding both their income and morale.

The government must step in with urgent measures, including subsidies on essential inputs, assured procurement at MSP, and direct financial assistance.

Expanding crop insurance coverage and strengthening storage infrastructure are equally critical to protect farmers from both market and climate shocks. While farmers can explore diversification and cooperative models to improve their bargaining power, these efforts alone are insufficient.

Without strong and timely state support, their very survival remains at stake.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

### Explore new oil & gas wells

With the Middle East conflict showing no signs of resolution and tensions between the United States and Iran reaching dangerous levels, India must urgently reassess its energy strategy. A renewed focus on geological surveys by ONGC across the country, along with exploration of new onshore and offshore oil and gas fields, is essential. India's vast Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ), spanning about 2.37 million sq km, and its extended continental shelf of nearly 3.2 million sq km together provide a strong resource base for such efforts. In the short term, measures to curb petrol and diesel consumption are necessary to reduce dependence on imports. The Middle East has long remained a volatile region, and prolonged conflict could severely disrupt global supply chains of crude oil and gas. The experience of other ongoing conflicts highlights how fragile peace efforts can be. India must therefore move decisively towards energy self-reliance by expanding domestic production while simultaneously accelerating the transition to renewable energy sources. Strengthening both conventional and alternative energy capacities is the only sustainable way to secure the nation's future in an increasingly uncertain geopolitical landscape.

VINOD JOHRI | NEW DELHI

# Collateral crisis: The unseen global fallout

What began as a seemingly contained regional confrontation has rapidly spiralled into a global crisis, sending shockwaves far beyond the battlefield. From grounded flights and disrupted trade routes to surging fuel prices and rising household costs, the ripple effects are being felt in homes, markets, and airports across continents



HEMANGI SINHA

What began as a regional confrontation has quickly become a global shockwave, unsettling air travel, energy supplies, trade routes, and the daily routines of millions far from the battlefield. What on the surface seems to be a far-off geopolitical battle is really changing the everyday-increasing the cost of food and gasoline, postponing travel, upsetting livelihoods, and adding uncertainty to homes across continents. The effects of conflict are no longer limited to national boundaries in today's linked globe; instead, they spread across human networks, financial institutions, and supply chains, subtly altering how people move, work, and live.

## Aviation and Diaspora Disruption:

International air travel has completely stopped. Early in March, Gulf hubs, including Dubai, the world's busiest international airport, were closed, leaving "tens of thousands" of travellers stranded. "Over 3,400 flights were cancelled" at key Middle Eastern airports in the first weekend alone, according to travel industry analysts. Routes operated by Emirates and Qatar Airways to Ethiad were suspended, and all flights were halted at major hubs, including Abu Dhabi and Doha. In an effort to evacuate their residents, governments from Britain, France, India, and other countries hired special evacuation aircraft from the area. For instance, by early March, the U.S. State Department claimed to have evacuated "thousands" of Americans from the Gulf using "over a dozen" charter planes. In reality, regular travellers have taken extreme actions. To attend her brother's wedding in Europe, a Dubai expat travelled across multiple countries over 33 hours, passing through Saudi Arabia and Oman. Others eagerly awaited the resumption of regular flights in hotels or airport lounges.

## Energy Shock and Inflation

The fighting has caused petrol and oil prices to soar, directly affecting consumers. In the weeks after the strikes, Brent crude increased by almost 40%, from about \$70 to over \$100 per barrel. Fears of Hormuz interruptions caused European natural gas to soar by almost 38% in early March, momentarily



pushing Brent above \$120. Citizens globally should be cautioned that prices may rise significantly higher, even to \$130, if tensions continue. Everyday expenses are already being impacted by these increases. In only a few weeks, petrol prices in the United States increased by more than 21%. Even non-fuel products are impacted since over 40% of crude oil is utilised for transportation and chemicals; basic products like clothes, soap, and furniture, all of which are derived from petroleum, now need to be created with more expensive materials. Similar increases in heating fuel and fertiliser have put food prices and utility costs at risk.

## Shipping and Trade Delays

Global trade has been hampered, as has energy. About 20% of the world's oil regularly passes through the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow chokepoint that has effectively been sealed. Insurance companies have discontinued "war-risk" coverage for Persian Gulf lines, and at least 150 tankers are currently stranded off the strait due to drone and missile strikes. The cost of goods has increased dramatically as a result. Since the start of the war, air cargo rates from South Asia to Europe have increased by nearly 70 per cent (from roughly \$2.57 to \$4.37 per kilogram) as freighters add fuel stops and avoid ports closed by the war, such as Dubai. The cost of sea freight has also increased; certain tanker routes report rates that are more than three times higher than before the war. In actuality, this implies that most imported items are more expensive and require longer wait times. Imports of food, mechanical components, and electronics

must now pay these additional transportation expenses. Global inflationary pressure is the result, particularly in nations that rely heavily on imports.

## Financial and Economic Ripples

Currencies and financial markets are also responding. While the currencies of countries that buy oil have declined, safe-haven flows have bolstered the US dollar and gold. The rupee fell to an all-time low (around 92-93 per dollar) while Brent increased by over 40%. Other Asian currencies, including the won, baht, and peso, are under pressure due to widening trade imbalances, while Turkey's lira dropped to an all-time low (about 44 to the dollar). Fears of stagflation have caused stock indexes to decline, such as the Sensex in India and other Asian bourses. It has been noted that central banks are cautious because rising oil prices are putting fresh pressure on inflation projections, which may delay rate cuts or lead to further tightening. In many nations, borrowing and living expenses have increased for consumers and companies; mortgages, loans, and savings rates may also change. In summary, while prices remain higher than anticipated, global growth may stall.

## Human and Social Costs

Individual suffering is a result of these macro shocks. During Ramadan, many travellers from South and Southeast Asia and beyond experienced flight cancellations or were left stranded. Distress calls from migrant workers and families stranded between shuttered airports have increased, accord-

ing to embassies. There are reports of terrified pilgrims and vacationers waiting at airports, unsure whether they will make it home in time for Ramadan or other holidays. Everyday activities are affected, including missed doctor's visits, postponed business travel and weddings, and lost pay. In one striking story, a Lebanese woman "risked her life to get it" by cooking chicken beneath a tent for her family's Ramadan fast in the face of sniper fire since she was unable to get to a market safely. Religious and cultural customs, including holiday gatherings, Umrah pilgrimages, and parent visits, have been disrupted. As the typical freedom to travel or simply leave home disappears, there is an increasing psychological cost: people express worry, insomnia, and a sense of helplessness.

## Political and Strategic Shifts

The response from the world's leaders has been profound and extensive. The change has happened quickly in Washington: U.S. officials said that sanctions on Iranian oil may be lifted, releasing some 140 million barrels of crude onto global markets to lower prices. In an effort to safeguard oil shipments, the United States also said that its Navy will escort commercial ships through the Hormuz Strait "as soon as reasonable." Japan and other allies have been commended by President Trump for "stepping up" on energy security. Europe, on the other hand, has openly called for moderation and is discussing ways to stabilise markets (some EU countries are even considering lifting sanctions on Russian energy to secure alternative oil supplies). In the meantime,

nations like India are juggling their priorities: to guarantee energy supply and remove its sizable expat population-more than 3.5 million Indians reside in the UAE alone-New Delhi has discreetly taken action. Diplomatically, long-standing ties are being put to the test. While G7 partners work together on defence and reserve releases, disagreements have surfaced about penalties and crisis management. This battle has already expanded, presenting the possibility of a protracted, multipolar conflict due to regional proxies (in Syria, Yemen, and Afghanistan) and rivalry (Pakistan-Afghanistan tensions, proxy conflicts).

## Impact on culture & environment

The ramifications go beyond the realm of economics. The Middle East's \$367 billion annual tourism economy has all but van-

ished. According to one projection, the area may see 23-38 million fewer visitors this year, resulting in \$34-56 billion in lost revenue. Reservations in the UAE were already drastically down; a travel CEO reported a "big collapse in bookings" for March and Easter as tourists went to Portugal, Italy, and Greece. Airstrikes have reportedly destroyed at least 56 museums and monuments in Iran, including UNESCO-listed palaces and squares. UNESCO has expressed serious concern about hundreds of historical sites in the area. Attacks on pipelines and oil fields locally run the danger of causing minor spills and air pollution that might degrade air and marine quality. The environmental cost of our energy habits is paradoxically highlighted by this crisis: more stranded tankers increase the risk of spills; detoured aircraft use more fuel; and short-term fixes (such as using heavier fuels or postponing climate measures) may undo sustainability gains. This is "the worst disruption to global energy supplies in history," it will ultimately serve as a stark reminder of the necessity of replacing fossil fuels.

## Looking Ahead

A Vulnerable New Order, In the end, the "collateral crisis" highlights how intertwined and vulnerable the globe has grown. What started as a local conflict swiftly sent shockwaves through markets, supply chains, and everyday life worldwide. Energy and trade policy have to change drastically. The conflict has forced nations to "rethink ways to reduce long-term dependence on oil and gas." Recently, countries have been discussing increased fuel stocks and alternative pipeline or shipping routes, while nuclear power (in Japan, Europe, and Taiwan) and renewable energy have returned to the forefront. According to one insider, "energy security has never been as acute as now," thus no international leader is taking Gulf oil for granted. This entails some unpleasant realisations for common folks. Even after a truce, cultural losses, travel anxiety, and the expense of living pinch may continue. It is believed that the long-term lesson will be resilience-diversifying energy and trade partners, so that regular households won't be left to suffer the most when the next local dispute breaks out. However, homes around the world will soon have to prepare for higher costs, delayed deliveries, and anxiety. Our strong reliance on single commerce and energy routes now has serious social and political repercussions, as one expert said, and the effects of this shock will be felt for years.

# Balidan Diwas: Remembering the legacy of Bhagat Singh



RAHUL KAUSHIK

On March 23, each year, India pauses to remember not just the execution of Bhagat Singh, but the meaning of sacrifice itself. His Balidan Diwas is not a ritual of mourning; it is a reminder of a life lived with clarity, discipline, and an uncompromising sense of duty toward the nation. At just twenty-three, Bhagat Singh did not merely face death; he walked toward it with conviction, having already defined the purpose of his life.

To understand the significance of this day, one must look beyond the dramatic final moments in Lahore Central Jail and examine the deeper forces that shaped him. Bhagat Singh was not an accidental revolutionary. He was the product of a cultural and intellectual environment rooted in the ideas of the Arya Samaj, which had a strong presence in Punjab during his formative years. His family was deeply influenced by Swami Dayanand Saraswati's teachings, where nationalism was inseparable from civilizational pride and moral discipline.

His education in Dayanand Anglo-Vedic institutions reinforced these values. These were not mere schools; they were spaces where young minds were trained to internalise courage, service, and respect for India's ancient heritage. Bhagat Singh's nationalism, therefore, did not emerge out of reaction to colonial rule alone. It was rooted in a long-standing belief that the nation was a living entity deserving total commitment.

The emotional and intellectual turning point of his childhood came after the Jallianwala Bagh massacre. The young Bhagat Singh visited the site, collected soil soaked in the blood of martyrs, and preserved it with reverence. This act, often remembered symbolically, reflected something deeper, and that is his early acceptance of sacrifice as sacred. The Arya Samaj's interpretation of 'yajna' as self-offering for societal welfare found a living embodiment in him.

By 1923, Bhagat Singh had already chosen his path. He openly declared that he would dedicate his life to Bharat Mata instead of pursuing personal ambitions like marriage or career. This decision was not driven by impulse but by a conscious rejection of individual comfort in favour of collective duty. His life from that point onward was an unfolding of that commitment.



This clarity of purpose became most visible during his trial. When his father attempted to seek clemency, Bhagat Singh opposed it firmly. He believed that asking for mercy would dilute the moral foundation of his struggle. He chose principle over survival, demonstrating that for him, freedom was not negotiable at any cost.

As 23 March 1931 approached, the atmosphere across the country was charged with emotion. Appeals, protests, and public pressure attempted to halt the execution. Yet, Bhagat Singh remained unmoved. He had already accepted death as the final step in his commitment. For him, martyrdom was not an end but the completion of a promise he had made years earlier.

Even in his final days, his actions carried meaning. His request to eat bread prepared by a safai karamachari in jail was a deliberate statement against social hierarchies. At a time when caste-based discrimination was deeply entrenched, this simple act conveyed a powerful message that dignity is inherent and not determined by birth. Equality, in his understanding, was integral to national strength.

His intellectual life in prison further reflects the depth of his character. Bhagat Singh spent his last month's reading extensively, engaging with texts that dealt with philosophy, politics, and history.

Among these, the Bhagavad Gita stands out for its resonance with his life. The Gita's central idea of 'nishkama karma' i.e. performing one's duty without attachment to outcomes, finds a clear reflection in his choices. He did not act for recognition or reward; he acted because he believed it was his duty.

The Gita also teaches that death in the path of righteousness is not defeat. This idea aligns closely with Bhagat Singh's acceptance

of martyrdom. His composure, clarity, and absence of fear in the face of execution reflect a mind anchored in conviction rather than circumstance.

His journey was not solitary. Alongside him stood Shivaram Rajguru and Sukhdev Thapar, who shared his commitment to sacrifice and duty. Together, they represented a generation that saw freedom not as an abstract goal but as a responsibility requiring total dedication. Their unity was rooted in shared values, not merely shared circumstances.

Bhagat Singh's intellectual influences extended beyond immediate circles. He was deeply impacted by the writings of Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, particularly the interpretation of the 1857 uprising as a national war of independence. Bhagat Singh understood the power of ideas in shaping action. He ensured that such works were circulated widely, believing that history could inspire future generations.

His writings and jail diary reflect a mind that rejected blind sacrifice. He believed that sacrifice must be purposeful, directed toward achieving a larger objective. This distinction is crucial in understanding his legacy. He was not driven by emotion alone but by a strategic and disciplined approach to revolution.

On Balidan Diwas, what is remembered is not just the act of hanging three young men in Lahore Jail, but the culmination of a life built on conviction.

Bhagat Singh's martyrdom was not an isolated moment of bravery. It was the flowering of values cultivated over years - discipline, equality, intellectual rigour, and an unwavering sense of duty.

The relevance of 23 March lies in its ability to confront superficial understandings of patriotism. Bhagat Singh's life does not allow for comfortable narratives. It demands an engagement with the idea of sacrifice as responsibility, not spectacle. It forces a recognition that freedom was not granted but earned through lives that refused compromise.

Balidan Diwas, therefore, is not about remembrance alone. It is about confronting the standards set by those who chose duty over self, principle over survival, and action over hesitation. Bhagat Singh's legacy continues to stand as a measure of commitment that is unyielding, disciplined, and rooted in a vision that extended far beyond his own lifetime.



HARISH JAIN

Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev, and Rajguru remain among the most luminous names in India's struggle for freedom. Bhagat Singh, born in 1907 into a politically conscious Sikh family in Punjab, emerged in his early twenties as the most articulate voice of revolutionary nationalism, combining daring action with rare intellectual depth. Sukhdev Thapar, his close comrade from Lahore, was the disciplined organiser behind much of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association's work in north India. Shivaram Hari Rajguru, the youngest of the three, was remembered by contemporaries for his courage, marksmanship, and unwavering loyalty to the revolutionary cause. On 23 March 1931, all three were executed in Lahore Central Jail. Their martyrdom transformed them into enduring figures in India's political memory.

Among the many documents associated with their final days, one stands apart with unusual force: the demand that they should not be hanged like criminals but shot like soldiers. This text is generally believed to be a single letter written by Bhagat Singh and his comrades shortly before their execution. A closer examination of the historical record, however, suggests that it emerged through two related communications written in the last weeks before their death-one addressed to the Jail Superintendent and another to the Governor of Punjab.

The first communication appears to have been addressed to the Jail Superintendent, the immediate authority through whom prisoners were required to communicate with higher officials. In it, the revolutionaries made an argument that was both simple and devastating. They had been convicted under the charge of waging war against the King-Emperor. If that charge was to be taken seriously, they argued, they could not be treated as ordinary criminals. They were political combatants engaged in a struggle between an enslaved nation and an imperial power. As such, they should be treated as soldiers and executed by firing squad. This was not theatrical rhetoric. It was a deliberate political intervention. By invoking the very language used by the colonial tribunal, Bhagat Singh and his comrades turned the logic of the state against itself. If the state insisted that they had waged war, it had already admitted the political nature of their actions.

The second and better-known letter, addressed to the Governor of Punjab, carried this argument further. Here, the revolutionaries made their position unmistakable. They did not beg for pardon. They did not seek commutation of their sentence.

# The last defiance of Bhagat Singh and his comrades

Instead, they demanded that the British government recognise the political character of their struggle and treat them accordingly. Their demand was stark: if they were to die, they should die as soldiers, not criminals.

The distinction mattered enormously. Hanging was the punishment reserved for criminals and murderers. Execution by firing squad was traditionally associated with war. By demanding the latter, Bhagat Singh and his comrades refused the moral vocabulary the colonial state wished to impose upon them.

They would not accept the label of criminal. They insisted on defining themselves as participants in a political struggle. In that act of self-definition, the letter rose far above its immediate context. It became a manifesto. The timing of these communications is crucial. March 1931 was a moment of uncertainty and political negotiation. The Gandhi-Irwin Pact had just been signed. It secured the release of many prisoners involved in the Civil Disobedience Movement and appeared to promise a temporary settlement between the Congress and the colonial state.

But revolutionaries convicted in violent cases were excluded from its provisions. This exclusion reflected a hierarchy that was emerging within the freedom struggle itself. Certain forms of resistance were being legitimised while others were being quietly disowned. Some patriots could be accommodated within the political mainstream; others were left outside its boundaries.

Bhagat Singh and his comrades clearly understood this. Their letter must therefore be read not only against the colonial judiciary but also against the shifting political climate within the nationalist movement. It was written at a moment when compromise was increasingly being treated as political wisdom.

The revolutionaries responded with an ethics of refusal. They would not ask for mercy. They would not dilute the meaning of their struggle. And they would not allow either the colonial state or sections of the nationalist leadership to narrate their deaths as the punishment of criminals. What is striking about the document is its composure. It is not an emotional farewell. It is precise, disciplined, and politically clear. Even at the threshold of execution, the revolutionaries were concerned less with death than with how their struggle would be understood. The legal intelligence of their argument is remarkable. Colonial power had used the charge of waging war to justify exemplary punishment. Bhagat Singh and his comrades seized that very charge and exposed its contradiction.

Please read the complete story online at [www.dailypioneer.com](http://www.dailypioneer.com)

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